

ANGLIA RUSKIN UNIVERSITY

FACULTY OF ARTS, HUMANITIES
AND SOCIAL SCIENCES

VEGETAL MATTERS IN THOMAS HARDY AND OLIVE SCHREINER:
LITERARY REPRESENTATIONS OF THE ONTOLOGICAL, PHILOSOPHICAL,
AND MATERIAL PLANT

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Abstract

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ABSTRACT

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This thesis examines the representation of the vegetal in the writings of Thomas Hardy and Olive Schreiner. I argue that the vegetal has a prominent presence in their work and that they represent it as a location of vitality, change, process, and agency. In extending this to its participation in networks of causality and meaning, I demonstrate how they decentre humanity and situate meaning, knowing, and agency in wider networks that encompass all lifeforms. Developing current work within the plant humanities, this interdisciplinary study brings together the philosophical botany of Arthur Schopenhauer and Michael Marder and, recognising the vegetal as the epitome of materiality, the New Materialism of Jane Bennett and Karen Barad. I assert that although Hardy and Schreiner emphasise the evolutionary material connectivity across all lifeforms, they also represent the vegetal as 'other', using it to examine human modes of being. Through such comparison, they problematise the mind, viewing it as engendering a focus on self and the short-term, and through its dominance, suggesting that humanity fails to recognise the role of the body in perception and motivation. I explore their extension of literary form to embed long-term evolutionary frameworks, recognising Schreiner's innovative and experimental form as ontologically vegetal. Schreiner conceptualises humanity as a long-term continuous body, analogous to that of the vegetal, the individual having an ethical responsibility to contribute to its progress. Hardy uses vegetal settings to establish a long-term stability while the unceasing growth of vegetation also continuously transforms and re-creates place. Bringing these two late nineteenth-century/early twentieth-century writers into conversation, I examine how their work participates in debates between material and metaphysical notions of reality; Hardy using the material vegetal to challenge metaphysical views while Schreiner incorporates these two epistemologies into models of reality. This productive vegetal approach creates new post-human ecological readings of Hardy and Schreiner, in which life is seen as a continuum, meaning is relocated to material existence, and relationships are key.

Keywords: Olive Schreiner; Thomas Hardy; vegetal; materiality; long-term; post-human; philosophical botany; New Materialism.

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List of Abbreviations

The following abbreviations have been used throughout the text. They indicate the primary texts and the major theoretical texts.

Primary Texts

Thomas Hardy

<i>CP</i>	<i>The Complete Poems</i>
<i>RN</i>	<i>The Return of the Native</i>
<i>W</i>	<i>The Woodlanders</i>

Olive Schreiner

<i>AF</i>	<i>The Story of an African Farm</i>
<i>D</i>	<i>Dreams</i>
<i>FM</i>	<i>From Man to Man</i>
<i>TPR</i>	<i>Trooper Peter Halket of Mashonaland</i>

Theoretical Texts

<i>KB</i>	Karen Barad, <i>Meeting the Universe Halfway: Quantum Physics and the Entanglement of Matter and Meaning</i>
<i>JB</i>	Jane Bennett, <i>Vibrant Matter: A Political Ecology of Things</i>
<i>MM</i>	Michael Marder, <i>Plant-Thinking: A Philosophy of Vegetal Life</i>
<i>WWR1</i>	Arthur Schopenhauer, <i>The World as Will and Representation, Volume 1</i>
<i>WWR2</i>	Arthur Schopenhauer, <i>The World as Will and Representation, Volume 2</i>

Introduction

Metaphysics? What metaphysics do those trees have?
To be green and lush and to have branches
And to bear fruit at the right time [...]
But what better metaphysics than theirs,
The metaphysics of not knowing for what they live
And of not knowing that they do not know it.

(Fernando Pessoa, *Obra poetica*, in Michael Marder, *Plant-Thinking*, p.79)

It matters to the world how the world comes to matter
(Karen Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, p.380)

In this thesis I explore the work of Thomas Hardy (1840-1928) and Olive Schreiner (1855-1920) through examining their representation of the vegetal. I argue that the vegetal has a prominent presence in their work and that they represent it as a location of vitality, change, process, and agency. They further extend its reach to its participation in networks of causality and meaning, untethering these concepts from humanity. Reading Hardy and Schreiner's work from this perspective, I offer new readings of their work in which these features come to the fore, demonstrating how they decentre humanity and locate meaning, knowing, and agency within wider networks that encompass all lifeforms. I examine how through their use of the vegetal and its seemingly continuous and non-individualistic ontology, they embed long-term and evolutionary perspectives in which life itself is important and the transient individual part of such a continuity. I assert that their focus on the vegetal is indicative of the importance they place on materiality per se. Reading the vegetal as the epitome of materiality, all its attributes become proper to material itself. Features that in humanity are situated in the mind, such as intentionality, agency, knowing, and meaning, are relocated to materiality. I contend that their representation of the vegetal highlights how for Hardy and Schreiner matter itself matters. Hardy and Schreiner emphasise how through materiality all lifeforms are connected. Yet they also represent the vegetal as other and offer it as a means of exploring the problematic nature of humanity, particularly the human mind. As Eduardo Kohn (2013) states: 'attending to our relations with those beings that exist [...]

beyond the human forces us to question our tidy answers about the human'.¹ I argue that in doing so, they suggest that a vegetal mode of being can radically question human modes of being and offer lessons in how to live better in the world.

The key element of the vegetal which embeds its agency is, for Hardy, its spatiality and in his novels, he situates this in his vegetal settings. In chapter one I explore Hardy's *The Return of the Native* (1878), reading his representation of Egdon Heath as a place formed by the vegetal. I consider how its agency is located in its vegetal which also furnishes the long-term framework of the novel. I go on to discuss how, in *The Woodlanders* (1887), Hardy uses the vegetal setting to create a world of entanglements, in which imperfection and complex causalities challenge an idealist metaphysic underlying reality. In my final Hardy chapter, I analyse a selection of his poetry in which vegetal spatiality becomes the location of vitality and meaning, and its alternative mode of being offers life lessons to humanity. In the second part of this thesis, I explore the work of Schreiner, recognising her principal use of the vegetal as to express continuity. I begin by examining *The Story of an African Farm* (1883) and consider how she locates meaning in the continuum of material life underneath which lies a metaphysical connectivity. I move on to analyse Schreiner's posthumously published *From Man to Man* (1926), exploring her portrayal of a long-term evolutionary connectivity and her representation of humanity as a continuously progressing collective. In my final chapter, I consider three of Schreiner's allegories. I analyse her critique of individualistic attitudes and her presentation of a collective mode of being and ethics. Overall, the thesis demonstrates how my vegetal methodology creates productive readings across a variety of literary forms.

In what follows I discuss how, writing in the latter half of the nineteenth and early twentieth-centuries, Hardy and Schreiner negotiate how new understandings of materiality intrude into

¹ Eduardo Kohn, *How Forests Think: Toward an Anthropology Beyond the Human* (Berkeley, University of California Press, 2013), p.6.

notions of meaning and epistemology. Through incorporating long-term evolutionary ideas, I explore how they extend literary form itself. I go on to outline my use of theory, particularly my amalgamation of philosophical botany and New Materialist perspectives. I describe the twenty-first century 'plant-turn' in the humanities and show how my work expands vegetal ecocriticism through incorporating notions of agency, knowledge, and meaning within the vegetal, as well as incorporating vitalist and New Materialist understandings.

I follow this with an outline of the key findings of my thesis alongside explanations of some of the essential theory, divided into three topics areas. The first of these concerns Hardy and Schreiner's representations of life and humanity as collective and continuous. I explore how they problematise the role of the individual and explain how I use vegetal ontology to conceptualise this. I then consider how Hardy and Schreiner deal with the phenomenal and noumenal worlds. I draw a distinction between Hardy's materialist understanding and his representation of materiality as a challenge to the metaphysical, and Schreiner's perception of the material and metaphysical as inseparable. The third major element of my thesis looks at how Hardy and Schreiner question the dominance of the human mind. I frame this around their non-dualist understanding of humanity and explore how notions of knowing as centred in the material rather than in a separate sphere support such an understanding. The introduction concludes with an overview of the chapters that follow.

Before venturing further, I want to clarify my use of the term 'vegetal'. I use this to indicate the entire plant kingdom. It is preferred to the alternative of 'plant' as that can imply a narrow range of vegetal beings, excluding the larger forms such as trees or the smaller like mosses and suchlike. However, where I do use the word 'plant', it should be read as equivalent to 'vegetal'.

Putting Hardy and Schreiner into conversation makes for a productive pairing as they both foreground the vegetal and relocate many features conventionally assigned to the human, to

the vegetal and materiality. They are writing at a time when material evolutionary theories had altered understandings of the world framed by religious beliefs. However, as Mark Knight and Emma Mason comment, it is 'easy to exaggerate' the effect of Darwin's *Origin of Species* (1859) on religious beliefs.² Knight and Mason remind us to 'remain alert to the mutability and plurality of belief' in the nineteenth-century and that it rarely helps 'to characterise people's beliefs as either religious or secular'.³ Acknowledging a continuing dynamic between religious and material conceptions of the world, I recognise the remaining influence of religious ideas on their work, even though they both professed to a loss of a conventional Christian faith. Schreiner's conceptualisation of the connectivity between all beings relies upon a noumenal lifeforce behind materiality, and the ethical stance in her work is overtly indebted to Christian values. Although Hardy's work is more inherently materialist, he demonstrates a continuing tension between a materialist viewpoint and one that yearns for what that leaves out.

However, Charles Darwin and evolutionary theory looms large over this thesis. I argue that through incorporating the long-term perspectives necessary to evolutionary understanding, Hardy and Schreiner broker new realisms at the end of the nineteenth-century, offering routes towards twentieth-century modernisms. Their use of long-term evolutionary frameworks within the boundaries of the narrative form shows them grappling with integrating time-bound stories of human individuals with a decentralising of humanity in favour of a wider temporal perspective and the inclusion of other lifeforms. One of the leading critics of the novel form in this respect is Amitav Ghosh. In *The Great Derangement* (2016) he contends that the realist novel is unable to incorporate the long-term temporality

² Mark Knight and Emma Mason, *Nineteenth-Century Religion and Literature: An Introduction* (Oxford, Oxford University Press, 2006), p.156.

³ Knight and Mason, p.167.

necessary for grasping environmental reality as it has a narrative necessity for 'boundaries, in time and space'.⁴ He asserts that:

Within the mansion of serious fiction no one will speak of how the continents were created; nor will they refer to the passage of thousands of years; connections and events on this scale appear not just unlikely but also absurd within the delimited horizon of a novel.⁵

Hardy creates a long-term framework through his representation of the continuous growth of the vegetal against which he contrasts what become ephemeral stories of humanity.

Schreiner does so through her use of an experimental form in which the long-term is embedded in abstract sections which interrupt and yet interlace with the more short-term linear narrative.

To support my interdisciplinary analysis of Hardy and Schreiner's representation of the vegetal, I bring into service the philosophical botany of Michael Marder and Arthur Schopenhauer. I explore Marder's notions in some detail later in this introduction, but here I want to briefly explain the rationale behind my use of Schopenhauer's work. The vegetal is prominent in the philosophy of Schopenhauer. In his argument that Schopenhauer's perspective is of value to vegetal ecocriticism, Timothy Morton comments that 'Schopenhauer makes it terribly easy to appreciate lettuces. I am a manifestation of will. A lettuce is a manifestation of will'.⁶ Schopenhauer employs plants to explain how the force of the will is 'blind' and how it functions in all beings unclouded by consciousness, asserting that 'the truth that the will can exist without knowledge is apparent, we might say palpably recognisable, in plant life' (*WWR2* 295). This is a useful perspective from which to understand Hardy and Schreiner's demoting of the primacy of the human mind.

Schopenhauer's vitalist account of materiality, in which the will is separate to and yet

⁴ Amitav Ghosh, *The Great Derangement: Climate Change and the Unthinkable* (Chicago, University of Chicago Press, 2016), p.59.

⁵ Ghosh, p.61.

⁶ Timothy Morton, 'What Vegetables are Saying about Themselves', in *The Language of Plants: Science, Philosophy, Literature*, ed. by Monica Gagliano, John C Ryan, and Patricia Vieira (Minneapolis, University of Minnesota Press, 2017), pp.173-190 (p.174).

manifests itself through materiality, is a useful lens for examining Schreiner's own vitalist perceptions. In fact, Schreiner herself recognised that many of her ideas were similar to those of Schopenhauer. That Hardy's own philosophy shares an affinity with Schopenhauer is a truism in Hardy studies, although this is generally considered in relation to his representation of character and his perceived pessimism. However, we do know that Hardy owned translations of Schopenhauer's work with some of the texts marked up showing evidence of his reading.⁷

Recognising how Hardy and Schreiner extend their use of the vegetal to express the value of matter per se, I expand my approach to draw upon elements of twenty-first century New Materialism. In her 'vital materialism', which she describes in *Vibrant Matter* (2010), Jane Bennett discounts descriptions of matter as 'passive, mechanistic or divinely infused' (JB xiii) and reconceptualises it as 'as much force as entity, as much energy as matter' (JB 20). For Bennett, matter is 'vibrant, vital, energetic, lively, quivering, vibratory, evanescent, and effluents' (JB 112). As Hardy and Schreiner represent matter as agential and vital, this becomes a useful interpretive viewpoint. Bringing Bennett's work into conversation with that of Marder, I perceive how both perspectives work to raise the status of matter. The vegetal matters *because* it is matter, not *despite* it. Bennett's perspective is a useful counter to that of Schopenhauer as she refutes vitalist interpretations: a vitalist account of matter, such as that of Schopenhauer's, sees its life principle as something additional whereas Bennett views it as intrinsic to matter itself. Reading Hardy and Schreiner through these lenses shows Hardy's view to be closer to that of Bennett whereas Schreiner's bears resemblance to that of Schopenhauer.

⁷ Hardy owned translations of Schopenhauer's *The World as Will and Representation* and *On the Fourfold Root of the Principle of Sufficient Reason*, the latter of which is marked up by Hardy. This second text contains the essay *On the Will in Nature* in which Schopenhauer devotes an entire chapter to 'Plant Physiology'.

I also bring into play Karen Barad's 'agential realism', outlined in *Meeting the Universe Halfway* (2007). For Barad, things are secondary, and subsequent to, relationships, or what she terms 'intra-actions'. Beings emerge or materialise through intra-action and '*agency is a matter of intra-acting; it is an enactment, not something that someone or something has*' (KB 178, emphasis in original). Barad's work sees relationships as key, and this is a useful perspective for considering the agential entanglements between vegetal and human, and between other bodies in Hardy and Schreiner's work. Furthermore, rather than being contained within time and space, for Barad, these intra-actions precede, produce, and reconfigure temporality and spatiality itself (KB 179). For Barad 'matter isn't situated in the world; matter is worlding in its materiality' (KB 180-1). This is a particularly useful position for considering Hardy's presentation of Egdon Heath in *The Return of the Native*. Using Barad, I demonstrate how Hardy represents the vegetal as creating and continuously re-creating place, encoding temporality and historicity within its vegetation. Using a Baradian lens, I contend that Schreiner's representation of entanglements between matter and mind work to reconfigure the world and humanity.

I. The Plant-Turn

My study is situated within the field of vegetal ecocriticism, variously termed critical plant studies, the plant humanities, or the 'plant-turn'. This field has developed across the humanities over the course of the second decade of the twenty-first century and follows the lead of animal studies in challenging humancentric views. I argue that vegetal ecocriticism is more radical in that it also challenges a zoocentric perspective which continues to exist within twenty-first century ecocriticism. But even in 2018, John Charles Ryan can contend that the plant has been a 'conspicuous lacuna' within ecocriticism and that 'studies of plant life in contemporary poetry are curiously few and far between'.⁸ I position my own study

⁸ John Charles Ryan, *Plants in Contemporary Poetry: Ecocriticism and the Botanical Imagination* (London, Routledge, 2018), p.7.

within vegetal and post-human perspectives that decentre the human and question human exceptionalism, viewing all lifeforms as of equal value.

The 'plant-turn' refers to an interdisciplinary field that stretches across the humanities and the sciences. Early work in this field is disappointingly conservative. Rodopi Press's (now Brill) book series, 'Critical Plant Studies: Philosophy, Literature, Culture', launched in 2013 with the aim to 'initiate an interdisciplinary dialogue' and 'encourage an incremental shift of cultural attitudes from a purely instrumental to a respectful approach to vegetal beings'.⁹ However, the first book published in this series, Randy Laist's edited collection *Plant and Literature: Essays in Critical Plant Studies* (2013), although countering the notion of plants as instrumental and inferior, contains too many essays that rather conventionally focus upon the symbolic status of plants.¹⁰ As Ryan contends, in its 'diffuse form to date, this green-minded specialisation has been wont to centralise the figurative potencies of flora as symbols, metaphors, tropes, linguistic devices, and narrative artifices'.¹¹

Over the second decade of the twenty-first century, a plethora of books have been published within the field of vegetal philosophy, many of them influenced by the burgeoning area of botanical research into plant attributes such as memory, learning, and intelligence. These provide the philosophical background to much of my work and books in this field include Matthew Hall's *Plants as Persons: A Philosophical Botany* (2011), Michael Marder's *Plant-Thinking: A Philosophy of Vegetal Life* (2013), Eduardo Kohn's *How Forests Think: Toward an Anthropology Beyond the Human* (2013), and Craig Holdrege's *Thinking Like a Plant: A Living Science for Life* (2014).¹² More popular texts that foreground plants as dynamic

⁹ <https://brill.com/view/serial/CPST> (accessed 24th September 2022)

¹⁰ *Plants and Literature: Essays in Critical Plant Studies*, ed. by Randy Laist (Amsterdam, Rodopi, 2013).

¹¹ Ryan, p.10-11.

¹² Matthew Hall, *Plants as Persons: A Philosophical Botany* (Albany, University of New York Press, 2011); Michael Marder, *Plant-Thinking: A Philosophy of Vegetal Life* (New York, Columbia University Press, 2013); Eduardo Kohn, *How Forests Think: Toward an Anthropology Beyond the Human* (Berkeley, University of California Press, 2013); Craig Holdrege, *Thinking Like a Plant: A Living Science for Life* (Great Barrington, Lindisfarne Books, 2014).

intelligent beings include Michael Pollan's *The Botany of Desire* (2001), Richard Mabey's *The Cabaret of Plants: Botany and the Imagination* (2015), and Peter Wohlleben's *The Hidden Life of Trees* (2016).¹³

Michael Marder's *Plant-Thinking* has become a seminal text in this field, making an important contribution to advancing the plant humanities. Many later works in this field that utilise Marder's ideas offer progressive perspectives. These include the edited collection *The Language of Plants: Science, Philosophy, Literature* (2017), Chauncey Maher's *Plant Minds: A Philosophical Defence* (2017), John C Ryan's *Plants in Contemporary Poetry: Ecocriticism and the Botanical Imagination* (2018), as well as chapters in edited books, including those by Hannah Stark in *Deleuze and the Non/Human* (2015), Ruth Livesey in *Anticipatory Materialisms in Literature and Philosophy, 1790-1930* (2019), and Emma Mason in *The Figure of Christ in the Long Nineteenth Century* (2020).¹⁴ Such work has contributed to a radicalisation of this field in which earlier understandings of plants as mechanistic, passive, and hierarchically inferior, have been superseded by those that view the vegetal as a location of process and vitality, and even a site of intentionality, agency, knowledge, and meaning.

In the second decade of the twenty-first century, work in plant humanities has widened to embrace an interdisciplinary perspective, bringing other literary approaches into conversation. This includes two recent texts that focus on the cultivated plant. Elizabeth

¹³ Michael Pollan, *The Botany of Desire* (London, Bloomsbury, 2001); Richard Mabey, *The Cabaret of Plants: Botany and the Imagination* (London, Profile Books, 2015); Peter Wohlleben, *The Hidden Life of Trees* (Vancouver, Greystone Books, 2016).

¹⁴ *The Language of Plants: Science, Philosophy, Literature*, ed. by Monica Gagliano, John C Ryan, Patricia Vieira (Minneapolis, University of Minnesota Press, 2017); Chauncey Maher, *Plant Minds: A Philosophical Defence* (London, Routledge, 2017); John C Ryan, *Plants in Contemporary Poetry: Ecocriticism and the Botanical Imagination* (2018); Hannah Stark, 'Deleuze and Critical Plant Studies' in *Deleuze and the Non/Human*, ed. by Jon Roffe and Hannah Stark (Basingstoke, Palgrave MacMillan, 2015), pp.180-196; Ruth Livesey, 'Arboreal Thinking: George Eliot and the Matter of Life in *Adam Bede*' in *Anticipatory Materialisms in Literature and Philosophy, 1790-1930*, ed. by Jo Carruthers, Nour Dakkak, and Rebecca Spence (Cham, Palgrave MacMillan, 2019) pp.131-151; Emma Mason, 'Considering the Lilies: Christina Rossetti's Ecological Jesus', in *The Figure of Christ in the Long Nineteenth Century*, ed. by Elizabeth Ludlow (Cham, Palgrave MacMillan, 2020) pp.149-161.

Hope Chang's *Novel Cultivations: Plants in British Literature of the Global Nineteenth Century* (2019) considers the commerce in cultivated plants of the nineteenth-century and how this is mediated through the novels of the period.¹⁵ It is interesting that in terms of Schreiner she discusses *African Farm* and not *From Man to Man* which includes much more on the cultivated plant. Sue Edney's edited collection, *EcoGothic Gardens in the Long Nineteenth Century: Phantoms, Fantasy and Uncanny Flowers* (2020), brings the Gothic mode into play, examining elements of the uncanny and alien in garden writing of that period.¹⁶

I draw upon other texts that have embraced interdisciplinary perspectives. The recent edited collection, *Entangled Worlds: Religion, Science, and New Materialism* (2017) aims to find common ground between the ostensibly opposing fields of materiality and religion, viewing the perceived binary of mind and matter as incoherent.¹⁷ My work puts into service Jane Bennett's contribution to this volume, in which she purports a materialised 'onto-sympathy' between plants and humans.¹⁸ I also incorporate elements of the emerging field of econarratology, that examines narrative form in relation to ecocriticism and environmental studies. Erin James and Eric Morel, the editors of *Environment and Narrative: New Directions in Econarratology* (2020), state their intention to overturn notions of the study of narrative theory as anthropogenic and consider instead how narrative can convey and foster environmental forms of understanding.¹⁹ I draw upon some of these insights in my analysis of Schreiner's innovative and experimental narrative form. However, I inflect the

¹⁵ Elizabeth Hope Chang, *Novel Cultivations: Plants in British Literature of the Global Nineteenth Century* (Charlottesville, University of Virginia Press, 2019).

¹⁶ *EcoGothic Gardens in the Long Nineteenth Century: Phantoms, Fantasy and Uncanny Flowers*, ed. by Sue Edney (Manchester, Manchester University Press, 2020).

¹⁷ *Entangled Worlds: Religion, Science, and New Materialism*, ed. by Catherine Keller and Mary-Jane Rubenstein (New York, Fordham University Press, 2017).

¹⁸ Jane Bennett, 'Vegetal Life and Onto-Sympathy', in *Entangled Worlds: Religion, Science, and New Materialism*, Ed. by Catherine Keller and Mary-Jane Rubenstein (New York, Fordham University Press, 2017), pp.89-110.

¹⁹ Erin James and Eric Morel, *Environment and Narrative: New Directions in Econarratology* (Columbus, Ohio State University Press, 2020).

econarratological lens through reading Schreiner's experimental narrative form as ontologically vegetal which, I argue, enables her to extend her temporal and collective perspective.

Hardy and Schreiner use the vegetal as both concrete being and as a model of a non-human and non-zoocentric mode of life. Cognisant of it as a continuous long-term and collective being, as agential and meaningful, and as having a heteronomous relationship to alterity, my own approach draws heavily on Marder's *Plant-Thinking*. In this, Marder explores the modes of being appropriate to plants, recognising them as possessing the attributes of agency, intentionality, and expression. He also considers how they embrace a collective ontology and embody time. I draw upon all these features in my examination of Hardy and Schreiner's vegetal.

Marder's perspective differs to that of Matthew Hall who in *Plants as Persons: A Philosophical Botany*, suggests that to be of value, the other-than-human needs to be given 'personhood'. Marder and Ryan take issue with such an idea, as do I. Marder asserts that it is neither necessary nor helpful to attribute to vegetal beings features embraced by personhood in order for them to be 'respect-worthy' (MM 55), and Ryan writes that he intends in his 'phytocriticism' 'not to homogenize vegetal otherness through a form of personhood'.²⁰ My point is that by attributing 'personhood' to the vegetal, one is in danger of implying that humans are more important as well as the sole beings who possess attributes such as agency, meaning, and knowledge. I argue that in viewing the vegetal as other that does not make it a lesser being neither does it suggest that it is incapable of being a participant in a world of agency, knowing, and meaning.

²⁰ Ryan, p.8.

A further aspect of Marder's work that is pertinent to the study of Hardy and Schreiner is his notion that the vegetal 'in its very being [...] accomplishes a lived destruction of metaphysics', its ontology deconstructing binaries such as 'self and other, depth and surface, life and death, the one and the many' (MM 11). This provides a helpful viewpoint for considering Hardy and Schreiner's own responses to the metaphysical. It is particularly useful in my exploration of Hardy's representation of the vegetal as a material challenge to metaphysical understandings of reality.

Through putting Marder's lens into conversation with other fields, specifically those of New Materialism and the vitalism of Schopenhauer, and engaging with interdisciplinary practices, my methodology extends the field of Marderesque vegetal ecocriticism. I not only widen it into considering materiality per se as a site of vitality, agency, causality, historicity, and meaning, but also recognise the continuing role of the metaphysical within the world of materiality, especially relevant to Schreiner studies. As such, I draw these potentially disparate fields into conversation and bring to light where these perspectives converge or diverge. This creates a broader, more complex, and productive approach for investigating the uses of the vegetal in literary texts, and Hardy and Schreiner's work in particular.

II. Individual and Collective

In Hardy and Schreiner's work, the individual being is less important than the continuity of life itself and the relationships between individuals. I conceptualise Schreiner's representation of humanity as a long-term continuous and collective body. I read this, and the corresponding relationship between collective and individual, through the model of the vegetal body, drawing upon Marder's notion of vegetal being as an 'ontological paradox' (MM 183) in that it deconstructs the binary oppositions of 'the one and the many' and the 'self and other' (MM 11). For Marder, the plant is a 'provisional unity of multiplicities' which 'transcend[s] the distinction between "part" and "whole"' (MM 84); its parts (shoots, roots,

leaves) able to act independently as well as cooperating with the whole plant. In fact, the whole idea of the existence of individual beings becomes virtually untenable in the plant-world. Through such a lens, individuality becomes a zoocentric notion but as Merlin Sheldrake suggests, 'if we only have words that describe neatly bounded autonomous individuals, it is easy to think that they actually exist'.²¹

Barad also demotes the importance of the individual, claiming that 'existence is not an individual affair. Individuals do not preexist their interactions; rather, individuals emerge through and as part of their entangled intra-relating' (KB ix). In reading Barad alongside Marder, I recognise these conceptualisations as plant-like, in that the individual parts of plants are only viable in relation to the other parts. Approaching Schreiner's representation of the relationship between individual and collective through these perspectives, suggests that the individual's importance is in relation to their contribution to collective life. In fact, in *From Man to Man*, Schreiner explicitly uses plant analogies to illustrate humankind as 'intimately in its nature a solidarity and a whole with all its parts reacting on one another' (FM 188). The way that Hardy problematises interpretations of humans as autonomous is reflective of his awareness of their integral relationship to alterity. In the two Hardy novels I explore in this study, characters who construct themselves as autonomous come to bad endings or learn to reframe themselves as heteronomous and part of a wider framework of entanglements and relationships.

Across her work, Schreiner extends her framing of the relationship between the individual and the collective to consider ethics. In *From Man to Man* and her allegories, her critique of hegemonic societies is centred around their focus on egoic individuality. In examining her ethics of responsibility towards others through Marder's vegetal ontology, I establish that the ethical stances of Schopenhauer and Barad are modelled in vegetal being. For Marder, plant

²¹ Merlin Sheldrake, *Entangled Life: How Fungi Make Our Worlds, Change Our Minds, and Shape Our Futures* (London, The Bodley Head, 2020), p.103.

modules are 'both members of a plant and independent entities in their own right' (MM 84), with each part, although independent, contributing to the growth and survival of the whole. Schopenhauer develops his theory of the will into an ethical position based upon the fact that our 'intuitive knowledge [...] recognises in another's individuality the same inner nature as in one's own' (WWR1 367-8), meaning that it should engender virtuous responses. I argue that this bears similarity to the relationships between the vegetal modules of a plant. In her life of Schopenhauer, Helen Zimmern identifies how Schopenhauer's ethics reflect those of the gospel. She notes that his understanding that 'the fundamental basis of morality [is] love of one's neighbour' shows that 'his ethics were thus in unison with those of the New Testament, and might be defined as its scientific expression'.²² Schopenhauer's perspective becomes particularly useful for examining how Schreiner's ethics reflect those of the gospel, especially since she overtly calls this to our attention in her *Trooper Peter* allegory. Furthermore, as Schopenhauer's ethics embed temporal relationships, this is a useful perspective for exploring Schreiner's notion of a long-term responsibility to the future of humankind.

Bringing into service Barad's ethics, I recognise how this is predicated on a similar understanding of the inherent relationships between beings. Barad conceptualises this as an 'incarnate relation that precedes the intentionality of consciousness' (KB 392). I assert that such an a priori understanding is implicit in Schreiner's notion that ethical responsibility precedes and overrides socio-political context. Moreover, reading Schreiner through Barad's notion that through intra-actions, one is engaged in 'bringing forth new worlds' (KB 170) and therefore that 'the becoming of the world is a deeply ethical matter' (KB 185), is a useful perspective for exploring Schreiner's call to ethical action in aid of the creation of a better future.

²² Helen Zimmern, *Arthur Schopenhauer: His Life and Philosophy* (London, Longmans, Green, and Co. 1876), p.154. (I draw upon Zimmern's book on Schopenhauer as evidence shows that Schreiner read this. I explain this in more detail later in this introduction.)

I propose that Schreiner's experimental and innovative use of form in *African Farm* and *From Man to Man*, in which she combines realist narrative and abstract sections, can be read as ontologically vegetal as it models a similar relationship between the individual and the collective. The realist narrative sections articulate the stories of individuals while the abstract sections universalise such accounts. Moreover, the way that Schreiner blurs the boundaries between these narrative forms is redolent of plant ontology.

Through such use of form, I contend that Schreiner also embeds a vegetal temporality into the narrative. She uses the abstract sections to create a long-term framework which also incorporates cyclicities and reiterations. This impersonates the growth of the vegetal in which a linear accumulation of material is interrupted by cyclical seasonal responses. Marder's understanding of how seasonal reiterations are not simply repetitions is useful here. For Marder, each leaf, say, is different to any previous leaf. I draw upon this notion to examine Schreiner's cyclical reiterations which, rather than mere repetitions, are each distinctive. Marder further claims that repetition 'achieves the exact opposite of deadening; it stakes out the being of everything that is living' and that 'there is no life without iterability' (Marder 113-16). Reading Schreiner's structure through this lens, I suggest that her complex temporal structures reflect the temporality of life itself.

I demonstrate how Hardy also uses the vegetal to create a long-term framework. In the two Hardy novels, I consider his vegetal settings through Marder's notion that plant spatiality is time itself. For Marder, through growth, plants 'spatially express time' and therefore embody a 'temporalisation of space and spatialisation of time' (MM 96). Read through this lens, Hardy's settings embed a long-term temporality against which humanity and their stories become ephemeral. But the vegetal's continuous growth also enshrines endless change and Hardy's representation of the vegetal emphasises its vitality and adaptation. Through

comparison, Hardy represents humankind as a species in decline: a direct contrast to Schreiner's representation of humanity as in continuous evolutionary development.

Both Hardy and Schreiner consider the transience of life and how it is a necessary, if difficult, reality for humanity to address. In his poetry, Hardy overtly draws on the vegetal's seasonal transience as a comparison to human responses to death. I read this through Marder's notion that vegetal growth ontologically deconstructs the binary of life and death (MM 11). For Marder, the continuously growing modular plant becomes almost immortal as the 'continual death of used organs has replaced death of the plant itself' (MM 122). Through such a lens, I argue that Hardy positions death as central to an understanding of life itself as continuous. Schreiner's representation of transience embraces a similar notion. Her portrayal of humanity as a continuous body enshrines an acceptance of the transience of the individual.

III. Material and Metaphysical

I read Hardy and Schreiner's work as concerned with the relationship between the phenomenal material world and a metaphysical worldview. I establish that for Hardy this relationship is antagonistic whereas for Schreiner these epistemological viewpoints are interdependent. I bring this divergence to light through considering their representation of vegetal materiality, of entanglements between beings, and a life force.

In *The Return of the Native*, I read Hardy's emphasis on the darkness of the material vegetal as a challenge to the enlightenment of reason and the metaphysical biblical creation in which light overcomes darkness. In *The Woodlanders* Hardy extends such a challenge through creating a phenomenal world, based on the spatiality of the arboreal, in which complexity is integral and counters metaphysical notions of the ideal. Entanglements between beings, human and vegetal, create networks of causality with unforeseen consequences. I combine

the approaches of Marder's vegetal spatiality and New Materialist notions of entanglements to analyse this world of relationships. Bennett suggests that things or bodies become 'entangled' with one another, forming 'assemblages' that themselves generate 'emergent properties' (JB 24). Furthermore, these entanglements mean that 'instances of efficient causality' become 'impossibly rare' (JB 32). I argue that the complexity of Hardy's web in *The Woodlanders*, in which even the vegetal becomes entangled in the plot, counters straightforward notions of causality. Moreover, Hardy's web illustrates Bennett's relocation of agency to the assemblage, rather than individuals and a 'mind capable of choice and intention' (JB 32). Extending these notions through Barad, I suggest that Hardy's web becomes of greater importance than the nodes (characters, events, and suchlike) it connects, further demoting the importance of the individual and individual agency. His evolutionary 'Unfulfilled Intention' (W 48) embeds imperfection as a principle of life, one that illustrates Schopenhauer's notion that nature only exists because of competition between beings (WWR1 146-7).

In *The Woodlanders*, Hardy blurs the ontological boundaries between lifeforms. His emphasis on their common materiality reconceives relationships between them as horizontal rather than hierarchical. Schreiner evokes similar material connections across lifeforms, but her explicit models of connectivity, unlike Hardy's, merge the material with the metaphysical. She purports that the lifeforce, for want of a better word, that connects all beings is both material and metaphysical.

For Schreiner, the lifeforce is something additional to materiality. I read it as bearing an affinity with a vitalist perspective, such as that of Schopenhauer, and I draw upon him to explore this aspect of Schreiner's work. I prefer to use Schopenhauer's vitalist philosophy in preference to other vitalists, as Schreiner herself recognised the affinity between her ideas and those of Schopenhauer. She writes in a letter that:

I have been looking at that life of Schopenhauer to-day. If I had ever read him, or even knew before I came to England that such a man existed, one would say I had copied whole ideas in the African Farm and From Man to Man from him. There is one passage of his on the search for philosophic truth that reads like a paraphrase of my allegory in the African Farm. There's something so beautiful in coming on one's very own inmost thoughts in another.²³

The 'life of Schopenhauer' to which she refers is that of Zimmern's *Arthur Schopenhauer: His Life and Philosophy* (1876).²⁴ In a later letter to the Librarian of the London Institution she asks, 'would you very kindly send me any of Schopenhauer's work that you have except the "World as Will & Idea" which I do not want'.²⁵ One might speculate whether the reason for not wanting Schopenhauer's *magnum opus* is because she has already read it.

For Schopenhauer 'matter is the mere *visibility of the will*, but not the will itself', which is the additional 'vital force'.²⁶ I read Schreiner's life force as similarly that which manifests in materiality, with the underlying connection between all beings as metaphysical. I am not the first to use Schopenhauer in ecocritical readings. As this connective force embraces all lifeforms, his philosophy has increasingly been appreciated and brought into service within ecocriticism. Morton asserts that Schopenhauer transcends the 'normative anthropocentrism of Western thought' in his taking seriously of nonhuman beings.²⁷ John Gray suggests that Schopenhauer presents 'the first and still unsurpassed critique of humanism' and that 'for Schopenhauer we are at one with other animals in our innermost essence'.²⁸ Greg Pritchard

²³ Olive Schreiner, letter to Havelock Ellis, 2nd March 1885, <https://oliveschreiner.org> [accessed 29th August 2022].

²⁴ Zimmern.

²⁵ Olive Schreiner, letter to London Institution, 15th December 1888, <https://oliveschreiner.org> [accessed 29th August 2022], Schreiner's underlining. (Schopenhauer's *The World as Will and Idea* is the same text as *The World as Will and Representation*.)

²⁶ Schopenhauer, 'On Philosophy and Natural Science', in *Parerga and Paralipomena: Short Philosophical Essays*, Vol. 2, trans. by E.F.J. Payne (London, Clarendon Press, 1974), p.107, emphasis in original.

²⁷ Timothy Morton, 'What Vegetables are Saying about Themselves', in *The Language of Plants: Science, Philosophy, Literature*, ed. by Monica Gagliano, John C Ryan, and Patricia Vieira (Minneapolis, University of Minnesota Press, 2017), pp.173-190 (p.174).

²⁸ John Gray, *Straw Dogs: Thoughts on Humans and Other Animals* (London, Granta Books, 2002), p.38-41.

and Laurence Wright view the Schopenhauerian will as that which connects all beings and therefore instils a respect for the whole natural world.²⁹

Reading Schopenhauer through Marder, I recognise how he anticipates materialist explanations of the life force, both negating mechanistic understandings of materiality. Marder's own explanation makes use of Merleau-Ponty's phenomenological intentionality, in turn an extension of Husserl's (MM 160). Marder suggests that the growth of the plant indicates a 'becoming-spatial and a becoming-literal of intentionality' (MM 37). Particularly pertinent for present purposes, he claims that this intentionality supplants the metaphysical idea of the will.³⁰

My use in this study of Schopenhauer's and Marder's interpretations of the life force provides a productive friction for my analysis of this aspect of Hardy and Schreiner's work and highlights where their conceptualisations converge or diverge. In Schreiner's work, the awareness of a metaphysical connectivity embeds a further meaning in materiality. Marder's perspective is more useful for examining Hardy's materialist account of vegetal vitality and agency. But there are elements of Hardy's vegetal agency that seem close to a metaphysical force, but bearing in mind his materialist credentials, I find Bennett's notion of an 'onto-sympathy' that is rooted in an 'overlap between materialities of humans and plants' a cogent and legitimate reading of such kinship.³¹

²⁹ Greg R. Pritchard, 'A Whale, a Bear and a Fish: Ecocriticism and the lessons of Schopenhauer', *Green Letters: Studies in Ecocriticism*, 7(1) (2006) pp.23-25; Laurence Wright, 'Ecological Thinking: Schopenhauer, J.M. Coetzee and who we are in the world', in *Toxic Belonging? Identity and Ecology in Southern Africa*, ed. by Dan Wylie (Newcastle, Cambridge Scholars Publishing, 2008).

³⁰ Marder, 'Plant Intentionality and the Phenomenological Framework of Plant Intelligence', *Plant Signalling and Behaviour*, 7.11 (2012), 1365-1372 (p.1367).

³¹ Jane Bennett, 'Vegetal Life and Onto-Sympathy', chapter in *Entangled Worlds: Religion, Science, and New Materialism*, Ed. Catherine Keller and Mary-Jane Rubenstein (New York, Fordham University Press, 2017), pp.89-110 (p.90-1).

IV. The Problematic Dualism of Humanity

Hardy and Schreiner problematise the human possession of mind and my exploration of this is a key element of this study. It is therefore incumbent at this point to clarify my use of terms such as 'mind', 'consciousness', and 'reason'. For the purposes of this study, I recognise 'mind' as having two components: that of intelligence and reason, and that of consciousness (or subjective experience). Where I use the word 'mind' I do so to refer to both elements. Hardy and Schreiner, however, often use such terms more loosely and, where necessary, I draw attention to this.

Hardy and Schreiner present the possession of mind as that which creates existential burdens and an associated necessity to create meaning within the individual life. For Hardy in particular, thought, emotion, and consciousness are presented as responsible for human unhappiness. They both suggest that by generating a focus on the individual, the self, and a concomitant short-termism, the mind impedes a longer-term and wider awareness of being part of a continuity of beings that have developed over evolutionary time. I explore how they explicitly and implicitly contrast this to the connectedness and continuity inherent in the vegetal.

In his autobiographical '*Life*', Hardy comments directly on the questionable benefit of a mind:

A woeful fact – that the human race is too extremely developed for its corporeal conditions, the nerves being evolved to an activity abnormal in such an environment. Even the higher animals are in excess in this respect. It may be questioned if Nature, or what we call Nature, so far back as when she crossed the line from invertebrates to vertebrates, did not exceed her mission. This planet does not supply the materials for happiness to higher existences.³²

³² Thomas Hardy, *The Life and Work of Thomas Hardy*, ed. by Michael Millgate (London, Macmillan, 1984), p.227 (entry dated 7th April 1889). (This '*Life*' has become known as Hardy's 'autobiography'. It was first published as a biography under the name of his second wife, Florence Hardy. However, in subsequent years it has been recognised as largely penned by Hardy himself and referred to as the '*Life*'. It is, however, written in the third person and consists largely of dated entries.) Further references to this text are indicated as Thomas Hardy, *Life*.

In his poems 'Before Life and After' and 'The Aerolite', both of which I address in Chapter Three, Hardy explores the notion that the evolution of the human mind is 'abnormal'. Elsewhere in his poetry, he expresses an envy of the vegetal's lack of mind. In this sense, he anticipates Marder's suggestion that humanity can learn lessons from the vegetal's 'healthy existence that does not problematise itself and therefore does not become an issue for itself' (MM 79)

I argue that Hardy and Schreiner write against a dualistic conception of mind as separate to body. For Hardy in particular, characters who rely too heavily on reasoning are represented as dissatisfied, conflicted, or misguided. Across Hardy's work, he presents the light of reason as damaging and that which engenders a notion of humanity as non-corporeal. Through his characters, he implies that when understanding and cognition is understood as embodied, humanity gains a wider understanding or 'insight'. For Schreiner, dreams, intuition, and feelings all enable an embodied understanding and I contend that characters that recognise these modes of understanding are portrayed as vegetal-like in their embrace of corporeality. In her allegories Schreiner extends such a non-dualist notion of humanity to suggest that transcendence itself is corporealized.

I explore such notions through Barad and Marder's negation of the separation between being and knowing. Barad uses an echinoderm, the brittlestar, as her model for this, asserting that "'I think, therefore I am" is not the brittlestar's credo' (KB 379). For Barad, as the brittlestar's entire body is a 'visualising system', there is no mediator (such as a lens) between the subject body and the materiality of the outside world. Its visual system is '*materially enacted*'. For the brittlestar then, 'being and knowing, materiality and intelligibility, substance and form, entail one another' (KB 375, emphasis in original).

Brittlestars literally enact my agential realist ontoepistemological point about the entangled practices of knowing and being. They challenge our Cartesian habits of mind [...] Knowledge making is *not* a mediated activity [...] Knowing is a

direct material engagement, a practice of intra-acting with the world as part of the world (KB 379, emphasis in original).

In a similar vein, Marder uses the plant as a lifeform that connects being and knowing:

ontophytology overflows the strict confines of traditional ontology [...] there is no reason why this excess should not be reflected in a corresponding epistemophytology – the epistemology of plants – that similarly oversteps the bounds of the conventional theories of knowledge (MM 152).

Without detracting from Barad's coherent and fascinating analysis of the brittle star's ontoepistemology, it seems to me that the embodied quality of the brittle star has a striking similarity to Marder's vegetal. In my view, Barad could equally have used a plant to illustrate her point. However, the correspondences between Marder and Barad's integration of material being and knowing suggests that this is common to all life and that mind or intellect is not necessary or essential for knowing. For Marder, consciousness is not 'an epistemological flaw' but a move from 'material knowledge to the formal knowledge of intelligence' (MM 154-5). Hardy might suggest that this is where life developed too far.

I use these insights to explore Hardy and Schreiner's embodied humanity. I contend that it is through an acceptance of their own materiality, or a reliance on embodied modes of knowing, that their characters gain a better understanding of their kinship with other lifeforms, as well as embrace a more heteronomous mode of life for themselves. In this way, they both counter notions of human exceptionalism based upon the possession of mind.

In a challenge to mind-based sources of meaning, I argue that Hardy and Schreiner purport a meaning to material existence, reflecting Marder's vegetal which is 'laden with meaning in all its spatiality, materiality, and finitude' (MM 76). For Hardy, this is particularly explicit in his poetry where he writes against Wordsworthian subjectivity and relocates meaning to mere existence. In Schreiner's *African Farm*, a post-faith search for significance is resolved through finding it within a rootedness amongst other lifeforms, albeit with an awareness that this connection is metaphysical as well as material.

V. Overview of chapters

In Chapter One I consider Hardy's *The Return of the Native* and begin by exploring his representation of the setting of Egdon Heath. Rather than topographical feature, I argue that Egdon Heath is a place created by the vegetal and that Hardy uses the continuous growth of the vegetal to embed a long-term temporality against which humanity and the plot become ephemeral. I assert that Hardy uses the darkness of the heath vegetation to counter the light of the sun and in doing so, also rewrites the biblical creation. Yet I also recognise the vegetal setting as a location of continuous vitality and explore how Hardy agentially entangles it with character and plot. In the second part of the chapter, I examine Hardy's problematisation of the human mind, in which he views thought as a 'disease of flesh' (RN 151) and that which creates a sense of autonomy. I read Hardy as writing against dualist conceptions of humanity, viewing the mind as embodied, and embodied insight a challenge to intellectual enlightenment. Finally, I explore how in presenting the emotions as embodied and their workings unconscious to the rational mind, Hardy allies the human body to that of the vegetal.

In Chapter Two I argue that in *The Woodlanders* Hardy develops his use of the vegetal setting as a challenge to human abstractions, the challenge now being to an idealist metaphysics underlying reality. The world of *The Woodlanders* is one of imperfection, illustrated through the evolutionary 'Unfulfilled Intention' (WL 47) which inscribes the impossibility of any preconceived ideal. I explore how through his 'great web' (WL 17), Hardy creates a complex world with entanglements across beings, vegetal and human, in which labyrinthine agencies and causalities result in unintended consequences. I contend that, as in *Return of the Native*, Hardy deposes the human, questioning the role of the imagination and spreading agential capacity across all lifeforms. I demonstrate how for Hardy, humanity

is dominated by the vitality, change, and adaptability that he locates within vegetal spatiality, and how he therefore counters human-derived notions of hierarchy and ownership.

My final Hardy chapter analyses a selection of his poetry, including five poems in which the vegetal is prominent. I explore Hardy's explicit framing of the vegetal as other, and his implication that its freedom from the burden of mind is a preferable mode of being. He purports that the vegetal can offer a discontented humanity, lessons in how to live and extends this to the vegetal's heteronomous mode of life and embrace of constant change and transience. I argue that in his poetry Hardy explicitly writes against Romantic subjectivity, problematising anthropocentric notions that meaning is located within the human mind, repositioning it to material existence. I explore how in these poems he replaces the human speaker's perspective with the vegetal's own voice and agency, and how his use of poetic form, allows the vegetal to spatially dominate. I conclude the chapter by exploring two poems in which Hardy explicitly questions the benefit of human consciousness and suggests that non-consciousness is normal.

In Chapter Four, I explore Schreiner's presentation of the search for meaning in a material world in *The Story of an African Farm*, and how she locates this within the continuum of life. For Schreiner, reasoning creates a barrier to the perception of an unexplainable underlying metaphysical connectivity, and I analyse the two models she creates of an interconnected material and metaphysical reality. I consider Schreiner's further suggestion that in engendering a focus on the individual self and its survival, the mind hinders understanding of the connection between beings and the relative insignificance of the individual, creating existential dissatisfaction. I also explore Schreiner's use of a forward-looking experimental form that interpolates abstract sections and linear narrative. I offer a reading of this as ontologically vegetal in the way these two forms juxtapose individuality and the collective, as well as combining a long-term temporal linearity with cyclicities and repetitions.

In Chapter Five I move on to discuss what I consider to be Schreiner's *magnum opus*: her *From Man to Man*. I analyse how the connectivity that she portrays in *African Farm* is further developed in *From Man to Man* through her use of a long-term framework that repositions the individual within evolutionary progression, further decentralising humanity. I examine the development from *African Farm* of her innovative use of form and how in this novel she more fully contextualises the abstract sections within the realist narrative. I argue that this enables her to entangle theory and practice, process and matter, and abstract and concrete, blurring the dividing lines between these, and demonstrating how each pairing in these binaries contributes to progress. I discuss how the use of a botanist as her main character enables her to overtly use the ontology of the vegetal to analogise and critique hierarchical hegemonic society and demonstrate the role of the individual in creating progress across humanity. Finally, I analyse how Schreiner characterises the human creative force as analogous to the life force, both having the ability, through the entanglement of matter and mind, to connect across time.

My final chapter concerns Schreiner's allegories, a form that she repurposes to examine and critique contemporary society. I assert that in her allegories she conceptualises humanity as a continuous temporal body, and I explore this through its resemblance to vegetal ontology. I argue that through this continuous body, Schreiner links past, present, and future, and demonstrates how individual action in the present must be in service to the long-term collective progress of humanity, and how meaning then becomes located within the relationship and contribution of the individual to the progress of that collective body. Although ethical concerns are important across Schreiner's work, I demonstrate that in her allegories, she places ethics at the centre of her vision, explicitly critiquing the ethics inherent in hierarchical hegemonic societies. I recognise her ethical standpoint as having similarity to a vegetal ethics, in which the role of the individual is in service to the collective

and explore how this ethical stance resembles other models that embrace relationships and responsibility rather than individuality.

Chapter One - Material Darkness and Symbolic Light: The Vegetal Darkness of Egdon Heath in Hardy's *The Return of the Native*

Matter isn't situated in the world; matter is worlding in its materiality

(Karen Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, p.180-1)

Whereas humans remember whatever has phenomenally appeared in the light,
plants keep the memory of light itself

(Michael Marder, *Plant-Thinking*, p.156)

In this chapter I argue that the dominating presence of Egdon Heath in *The Return of the Native* shows the importance of materiality to this novel. It is in the vegetal of the heath that Hardy embeds many of its characteristics as well as the long-term temporal framework of the novel. In the spatiality of this vegetal Hardy locates features more conventionally ascribed to humanity: face, voice, and agency, as well as the capacity for its involvement in the plot. I contend that his focus in *The Return of the Native* on materiality extends to his representation of humanity. He views humankind as material beings and suggests that the domination of the mind prevents a recognition of the importance of human corporeality, resulting in dissatisfaction, the unawareness of the embodied basis of many motivations, and a dismissal of our material kinship to all other lifeforms, including the vegetal.

Previous scholarship has considered Hardy's Egdon Heath as landscape feature. However, I read his representation of the heath as vegetal. I contend that not only is it a vegetal setting, but that it is a place that has been created by the vegetal. It is through the vegetal's ability to create place that Hardy historicises the heath and, read through the lens of Karen Barad, means that Egdon is constantly being re-created. Although Hardy uses it as an expression of long-term endurance, the vitality of its vegetation makes it a location of perpetual change and adaptation. Even scholars who examine Hardy's representation of the vegetal of the heath, such as William Cohen who, in his article on its faciality refers to it as 'perhaps the most famous landscape description in British fiction', or Sinéad Garrigan Mattar who uses

Hardy's description of heath-bells to illustrate Hardy's tendency to animism, fail to fully consider the material and spatial implications of Egdon as a construction of the vegetal.³³ Such a lacuna is perhaps understandable. Although many landscape terms are derived from the vegetation that constructs those places: think of wood, copse, or prairie, we often turn these into terminologies of landscape. Such semantic conflations are seen in Hardy's own writing: he uses the term 'heath' to refer both to 'Egdon Heath' and to the vegetation: 'the heath and fern had insidiously crept in' (*RN* 53).

I demonstrate how a failure to understand Egdon as vegetal has resulted in a corresponding failure to recognise many of the heath's features as located within its vegetation. In this chapter I argue that the heath's darkness, its human-like capacities, its agency, and its impact on humanity, are all situated within the vegetal. Readings of Egdon as a 'character' are, for me, a misnomer and reminiscent of approaches such as Matthew Hall's in which to be of value the non-human must be given personhood (see p.17). Rather than necessitating humanising the heath, through reading it as vegetal, I recognise the active presence of the heath in this novel as embedded within the vegetal's own capacities. Marder's conceptualisation of the vegetal as a lifeform that has its own vitality, agency, communicative ability, and meaning, all embedded within its spatiality, is a useful lens for exploring these aspects of Hardy's Egdon.

In this chapter I also press into service the materiality of the vegetal to examine Hardy's representation of humanity as non-dualist and embodied and his problematisation of the notion of the separate mind. Many scholars have recognised that for Hardy it is the body and emotions, rather than the rational mind, that motivate humanity. George Levine claims that

³³ William A Cohen, 'Faciality and Sensation in Hardy's *The Return of the Native*', *PMLA*, 121(2) (2006), 437-452 (p.446); Sinéad Garrigan Mattar, 'The Return of the Native: Animism, Fetichism, and the Enchanted Heath', *The Thomas Hardy Journal*, 24 (2008), 4-22.

for Hardy 'rationality cannot trump all. Lives are shaped by desire and chance'.³⁴ Phillip Mallett argues that for Hardy 'we are as much motivated by instinct and the body as by reason and the intellect'.³⁵ Hardy's presentation of the emotions as motivational, and yet embodied, and that 'the springs of human action may be inaccessible even to the actors', means that, for humanity, life must be fundamentally difficult and perplexing.³⁶ But my reading of *The Return of the Native* from the perspective of the vegetal extends these views. I assert that for Hardy, the domination of a separate interior sphere of mind separates humanity from a recognition of our materiality and our fundamental evolutionary relationship to all lifeforms, even the vegetal. For Hardy, thought is destructive. It creates dissatisfaction and the need to search for purpose and meaning, rather than understanding that these are to be found within existence itself.

Through the importance and efficacy of materiality and corporeality, I argue that Hardy undermines the abstract and the metaphysical. In *The Return of the Native*, light and darkness are used as symbolic oppositions: light associated with the abstract, and darkness, particularly that of the heath vegetation, with materiality. I contend that through his description of the heath, Hardy imagines a materialist rewriting of the metaphysical biblical creation. Rather than light displacing the darkness, the material darkness of the heath continues to dominate light. For Hardy, light is also symbolic of the problematic mind, whether that be the metaphysical light of the spirit or the symbolic light of reason; darkness is opposingly corporeal. Furthermore, the internal light of the intellect is challenged by the insight of the body. Rather than enlightening, the 'parasite' thought blinds humanity into assuming that we are rational beings rather than motivated by our corporeality. Such a blindness correspondingly prevents a recognition of kinship with the world of all beings and

³⁴ George Levine, 'Hardy and Darwin: An Enchanting Hardy?' in *A Companion to Thomas Hardy*, ed. by Keith Wilson (Chichester, Wiley-Blackwell, 2009), pp.36-53 (p.45).

³⁵ Phillip Mallett, 'Hardy and Philosophy' in *A Companion to Thomas Hardy*, ed. By Keith Wilson (Chichester, Wiley-Blackwell, 2009), pp.21-35 (p.30).

³⁶ Mallett, p.30.

engenders a sense of superiority. In contrast, Hardy implies that the roots of our being are as embodied as the vegetal of the heath. The opposition between the metaphysical and the material is extended in *The Woodlanders* which I examine in the next chapter.

The remainder of this chapter is divided into two parts: the heath and the human. I begin Part I by reading Hardy's Egdon Heath as a place created by the vegetal. I consider how Hardy uses the heath vegetation to embed *The Return of the Native's* long-term temporality, while also portraying it as a site of a seemingly paradoxical continuous change. I go on to analyse how Hardy uses heath vegetation to generate a darkness that dominates both light and time, challenging metaphysical constructions and human interpretations of temporality. I conclude Part I by exploring how Hardy relocates features usually attributed to the human to the spatiality of the heath vegetal. This includes faciality, voice, and awareness, ultimately establishing agency and awareness within the vegetable, the heath becoming an active participant in the plot. In the second part of the chapter, I consider Hardy's problematisation of humanity. I begin by exploring how Hardy presents the domination of the intellect in humanity as putting the mind in conflict with the body and disconnecting humanity from corporeality. I go on to demonstrate how humankind's ensuing assumption of autonomy is misguided and how a vegetally heteronomous mode of being might be beneficial. I trace the journey of the returning native, Clym Yeobright, from an autonomous mode of life to one that embraces heteronomy, predicated on a literal blinding caused by his focus on the intellect. Such a blinding allows his corporeal insight to emerge and symbolically unblind him. I conclude the chapter with an examination of how Hardy's portrayal of humanity as irrational and motivated by the bodily emotions recognises our similarity to the vegetal, and thereby all other lifeforms.

I: EGDON HEATH

I(i) Egdon Heath's Vegetal Temporality: Permanence and Change

The Return of the Native is the only one of Hardy's novels in which the first chapter is solely devoted to landscape. In fact, John Blackwood's criticism of Hardy's manuscript includes the comment that 'there is hardly anything like what is called Novel interest' in the first part of the story.³⁷ As part of his argument that fiction plays little attention to place other than as setting, Lawrence Buell claims that although Hardy presents Clym Yeobright as influenced by his environment, 'the heath is ancillary to Clym's story [...] *Return of the Native* is about people in place, not about place itself'.³⁸ On the contrary, my analysis suggests that Hardy's focus on Egdon Heath in the first chapter is indicative of its importance to the novel. Hardy's suggestion that the first book edition include a sketch-map of the scene of the novel as its 'unity of place [...] affords an opportunity of doing so', serves to further suggest the centrality of the location.³⁹

The title of the first chapter, 'A Face on Which Time Makes but Little Impression', announces Hardy's use of the heath to create his long-term temporal framework. For the heath, 'civilisation was its enemy; and ever since the beginning of vegetation its soil had worn the same antique brown dress, the natural and invariable garment of the particular formation' (RN 10). I argue that it is the vegetation that clothes the heath that makes it of 'antique' temporality. Moreover, reading the heath as created by its vegetation, makes the vegetal the location of the challenge to civilisation.

³⁷ Simon Gatrell, 'The Textual History of *The Return of the Native*', in *The Return of the Native*, ed. by Phillip Mallett, 2nd edn. (New York, Norton & Co., 2006), pp.343-363 (p.346).

³⁸ Lawrence Buell, *The Environmental Imagination: Thoreau, Nature Writing, and the Formation of American Culture* (Cambridge (Massachusetts), The Belknap Press of Harvard University Press, 1995), p.255.

³⁹ Thomas Hardy, letter to Messrs Smith & Elder, in Thomas Hardy, *Life*, p.125-6.

In this respect, one could contend that Hardy gestures towards human constructions of place as usurping the vegetal's natural ability to do so through its inherent materiality. It is useful to read this through Marder's notion that spatiality is 'the exclusive province of vegetal life' (MM 72) and plant spatiality an encoding of time. Hardy's embedding of the longevity of Egdon Heath in its vegetation brings into service Marder's notion that plants 'spatially express time' (MM, 96). They transform space into place. Moreover, rather than the vegetal being a passive inhabitant of place, for Marder 'place dynamically emerges from the plant's living interpretation of and interaction with its environment'.⁴⁰ Reading Hardy's vegetal through this lens, it has an active role in the historicising of Egdon Heath.

Hardy uses such vegetal longevity to historicise the heath through his description of it as like the vegetation found there in the Domesday Book where it is described as a 'healthy, furzy, briary wilderness'. He extends this resemblance by alluding to the Domesday Book's "Turbaria Bruaria" – the right of cutting heath-turf' (*RN* 10), an occupation that continues to be carried out by the natives in the novel. He also indicates that the modern-day bonfires on the heath are 'lineal descendants from jumbled Druidical rites and Saxon ceremonies' (*RN* 18). In a later text, he also links the heath to the long-term through literary history: in his short story, 'The Withered Arm' (1888), he writes that it is 'not improbably the same heath which had witnessed the agony of the Wessex King Ina, presented to after-ages as Lear'.⁴¹

Hardy further lengthens the long-term temporality of the heath to a pre-human deep time. I have already indicated that its vegetation has clothed the heath 'ever since the beginning of vegetation' but Hardy extends this by hundreds of millions of years through characterising its vegetation as that of the carboniferous period:

The ferny vegetation [...] was quite uniform: it was a grove of machine-made foliage, a world of green triangles with saw-edges, and not a single flower [...]

⁴⁰ Michael Marder, 'Plant Intentionality and the Phenomenological Framework of Plant Intelligence', *Plant Signalling and Behaviour*, 7.11 (2012), 1365-1372 (p.1367).

⁴¹ Thomas Hardy, *Wessex Tales* (London, Macmillan, 1976), p.79.

The scene seemed to belong to the ancient world of the carboniferous period, when the forms of plants were few, and of the fern kind; when there was neither bud nor blossom (*RN* 174-5).

Reading this description through Schopenhauer's understanding that plant form is permanent whereas its material changes over time (*WWR1* 277), Hardy's 'antique brown dress' is only similar to that of the carboniferous period in terms of form. The vegetation being 'uniform', emphasised through the description of its 'machine-made [...] triangles with saw-edges', enables Hardy to use it as an expression of permanence, whereas materially it is entirely different.

As well as characterising it as permanent, Hardy also draws attention to the vegetal's constant change and adaptation. Paths are constantly reclaimed by the vegetal: 'a little patch of shepherd's-thyme intruded upon the path' (*RN* 241), and areas cleared for farming 'after holding on for a year or two, had receded again in despair, the ferns and furze-tufts stubbornly reasserting themselves' (*RN* 149).

Barad's 'agential realism' provides a useful alternative lens for reading what could be seen as Hardy's oxymoronic combination of permanence and change in the heath's vegetation. Barad contends that temporality and spatiality are produced and reconfigured through intra-actions, rather than intra-actions happening within time and space (*KB* 179). For Barad, matter 'is generative [...] in the sense of bringing forth new worlds, of engaging in an ongoing reconfiguring of the world' (*KB* 170, emphasis in original). Reading Hardy's Egdon vegetation through Barad draws attention to how its continuous growing and adaptation constantly creates and re-creates this place. Rather than fixed or immutable, as many have characterised Hardy's Egdon Heath (encouraged perhaps by Hardy's own language, such as his description of the heath as 'from prehistoric times as unaltered as the stars overhead' (*RN* 11)), I argue that Hardy encodes time through his representation of perpetual change within that permanence.

Through using the vegetal to represent time, Hardy embeds process and vitality within permanence. The impression of permanence, the 'Face on Which Time Makes but Little Impression', is due to the vegetal's incessant growth being largely imperceptible to humans due to its duplication of form and, from a human perspective, the slowness of its growth and change. In fact, Hardy makes the point that although the vegetation might appear in 'the repose of actual stagnation', this is an 'apparent repose of incredible slowness'. It might 'exhibit the inertness of the desert' but it is 'exercising powers akin to those of the meadow, and even of the forest' (RN 14-15). As Francis Hallé points out, the vegetal cannot be in a condition of stasis. It is not 'that plants *can* grow indefinitely; they *must* grow, to the extent that they die if so impeded'.⁴² Perhaps Jane Bennett's suggestion that 'the claim to a vitality intrinsic to matter itself becomes more plausible if one takes a long view of time' is illustrated in Hardy's long-term, constantly changing, heathland vegetation (JB 10-11).

Hardy's evocation of continuous change includes his recognition that the long-term survival of the heath is predicated upon competition and adaptation. Vegetal beings constantly explore and respond to the environment through plasticity and modular growth. Hardy's heath vegetal competitively reclaims the space that had previously been itself reclaimed by cultivation – Barad's dynamic matter's 'worlding' in action (KB 180). Although Captain Vye's paddock was 'bearing evidence of having once been tilled' the 'heath and fern had insidiously crept in, and were reasserting their old supremacy', their competitive success emphasised through Hardy's aggressive anthropomorphic language. Although 'hedges will not grow because of the wind and the wilderness', the banks surrounding Vye's paddock are topped with 'disconnected tufts of furze, standing upon stems along the top, like impaled

⁴² Francis Hallé, *In Praise of Plants* (Portland and London, Timber Press, 2002), p.97, emphasis in original. (For many of the botanical explanations in this study I am indebted to Francis Hallé's book. It is particularly useful for this study as it directly compares the plant and animal kingdoms. Hallé also addresses the roots of the asymmetry, bias, and injustice inherent in our zoocentrism and anthropocentrism.)

heads above a city wall', suggesting a need for defensive fortifications to keep out the heath vegetal enemy (*RN* 53-55). Its success is perhaps demonstrated by the fact that its extent in the Domesday book shows that 'the area of Egdon down to the present day has but little diminished' (*RN* 10).

In this respect, it is interesting that in Hardy's self-confessed earliest poem, 'Domicilium', he makes the point that the real heath upon which Egdon is based, has reduced in size. Although the 'garden-plots | And orchards' had been 'uncultivated slopes', the road had been 'shut in by ferns', and 'so wild it was', it is no longer so (*CP* 3-4). It seems that in the fictionalised Egdon Heath of *The Return of the Native* Hardy was keen to emphasise its extent as continuous from at least the time of the Domesday Book rather than accept its actual diminution. I suggest that his fictionalisation of the real demonstrates the importance of the heath to his creation of his long-term temporal framework in *The Return of the Native*.

Reading the heath through Barad also draws attention to how Hardy makes the heath itself a place of historicity, not simply through linking it to human history, but by historicising the vegetal itself. Barad argues that it is not just the human, language and culture that have historicity (*KB* 132), but that through its world-making capacity, matter is also 'an ongoing historicity' (*KB* 151). Reading Egdon Heath through this lens, as created and re-created by the vegetal, Hardy extends its historicization. After all, as Timothy Morton claims, 'what we call Nature is really just solidified history'.⁴³ Moreover, Hardy suggests that ancient human intrusions become natural through ageing processes: 'an aged highway, and a still more aged barrow [...] almost crystallised to natural products by long continuance', implying that the natural is at least as historicised as the human-made (*RN* 11).

⁴³ Timothy Morton, *The Ecological Thought* (Cambridge, Massachusetts, Harvard University Press, 2010), p.42.

In his article on Hardy's use of 'scalar shifts' in his novels, Benjamin Morgan argues that Hardy makes interactions between 'divergent timescales [...] a structuring feature of narrative form, such that the novel acquires the formal capacity to induce layered modes of durational awareness'.⁴⁴ In *The Return of the Native*, Hardy's dominant timescale is that of the heath and against this long-term temporality, the tragic plot, that of the love triangle between Eustacia Vye, Clym Yeobright, and Damon Wildeve, becomes ephemeral. It is an interruption, both to the heath itself, and the lives of the heath natives. Although Diggory Venn had (wrongly) assumed that the marriages in the novel would be 'good for at least twenty years to come', Clym's marriage to Eustacia is a 'chasm' (RN 311, 244). Eustacia and Wildeve, the disruptive outsiders, thrive on change and modernity, whereas the heath 'gave ballast to the mind adrift on change, and harassed by the irrepressible New' (RN 11). The fact that the central story of Eustacia and Wildeve's disruptive influence lasts exactly one calendar year perhaps serves to emphasise it as a mere interlude.

Drawing attention to the short-term nature of his plot, Hardy also gestures towards its artificiality. The final book of the novel is entitled 'Aftercourses' and begins:

The story of the deaths of Eustacia and Wildeve was told throughout Egdon, and far beyond, for many weeks and months. All the known incidents of their love were enlarged, distorted, touched up, and modified, till the original reality bore but a slight resemblance to the counterfeit presentation by surrounding tongues (RN 314).

Through highlighting how stories can be exaggerated, Hardy implies their inauthenticity, and their abstract nature can perhaps be contrasted to the concrete reality of the heath. Moreover, Hardy shows an awareness here of the fictional story as a discontinuity in time, and an understanding of the necessity for time boundaries around stories – the very notion that causes Amitav Ghosh to assert that the realist novel cannot encompass the long-term and instead 'conjure up worlds that become real precisely because of their finitude' (see

⁴⁴ Benjamin Morgan, 'Scale in *Tess* in Scale' in *Novel: A Forum on Fiction*, 52.1 (2019), 44-63 (p.53).

p.10-11).⁴⁵ Hardy's suggestion that his long-term heath outlives his plot, somewhat counters Ghosh's criticism of the temporal limitation of the realist novel form.

Hardy even muses on the potential ephemerality of his own fictional text. Referring to the surviving barrows as the 'records' of the ancient inhabitants of the heath, he contrasts those on the 'cultivable tracts' which are 'as writers on paper beside writers on parchment' whose 'records had perished long ago by the plough' (*RN* 316). Like the records of agriculture, his own story, written on paper, is ephemeral and will perish, in contrast to the concrete human landmarks on the heath.

I(ii) The Darkness of the Vegetal as a Challenge to Light

As well as using the spatiality of the vegetal to create place and temporality, Hardy uses it to establish a darkness that challenges not only the light of the sun but also that of the biblical creation. The predominant feature of Hardy's heath vegetal is darkness. Rather than presenting it in aesthetic terms, through focussing on its spatial or structural aspects (its biomass), Hardy uses it to emphasise a vegetally-constructed darkness. He minimises any reference to flowers or colour. The crimson flowers of the heather only appear in one of four seasons, and even then, they are only 'gorgeous' when the sun shines in that season (*RN* 201). He nowhere mentions the yellow flowers of the furze, and neither are the purple heath-bells seen in flower. The dominating form of vegetation, the carboniferous fern, is non-flowering and its structure, that even persists after its death - 'between thickets of tall and dripping bracken, dead, though not yet prostrate' (*RN* 301) - provides density.

Hardy uses the vegetally-produced darkness to embed a materialist rewriting of the biblical account of creation. For comparison, I place here the pertinent verses from Genesis followed immediately by Hardy's description of the darkness of the heath as a challenge to light:

⁴⁵ Ghosh, p.61.

In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth. And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters. And God said, Let there be light: and there was light. And God saw the light, that *it was good*: and God divided the light from the darkness. And God called the light Day, and the darkness he called Night. And the evening and the morning were the first day (Genesis 1. 1-5, emphasis in original).

The heaven being spread with this pallid screen and the earth with the darkest vegetation, their meeting-line at the horizon was clearly marked. In such contrast the heath wore the appearance of an instalment of night which had taken up its place before its astronomical hour was come: [...] The distant rims of the world and of the firmament seemed to be a division in time no less than a division in matter. The face of the heath by its mere complexion added half an hour to evening; it could in like manner retard the dawn, sadden noon (*RN* 8).

In the Genesis account, darkness is original and displaced by light and time. Hardy also presents darkness as original, preceding light, although his darkness is material. The darkness of the heath creates, or at least dominates, time. It enforces night before its 'astronomical hour' and retards or dims the brightness of daytime. Such darkness is explicitly located in the vegetal: the 'darkest vegetation' which is the 'complexion' of the heath's face. Rather than the face being supplanted by the metaphysical 'Spirit of God', Hardy's material face continues to have effect, reminding the reader of the chapter title: 'A Face on Which Time Makes but Little Impression'. Reading this through Barad's notion of a continuous 'worlding', rather than an absolute change, Hardy's vegetal face is continuously re-challenging the light. Hardy also implies that it is more efficacious than astronomical time: at night, the sky's darkness is 'incomplete [...] in comparison with the total darkness of the heath below it' (*RN* 49).

Hardy extends the material as a challenge to light through its association with other forces of darkness. The dark heath acts in 'sympathy' with the night:

when night showed itself an apparent tendency to gravitate together [...] The sombre stretch of rounds and hollows seemed to rise and meet the evening gloom in pure sympathy [...] in a black fraternisation towards which each advanced half-way (*RN* 8).

Such 'black fraternisation' suggests a defiant threat to opposing forces. The heath also colludes with storms: 'the storm was its lover, and the wind its friend' (*RN* 10) and Hardy suggests that the low-growing vegetation of the heath is adapted for stormy conditions. Trees just off the heath undergo 'amputations, bruises, cripplings, and harsh lacerations' yet 'on the open heath, how ineffectively gnashed the storm! Those gusts which tore the trees merely waved the furze and heather in a light caress. Egdon was made for times such as these' (*RN* 178). Such a triumphant phrase alongside the 'caress' demonstrates the heath's accord with such material forces of darkness, reinforcing its opposition to the forces of the metaphysical light.

Hardy also makes the point that the heath vegetation acts as a coolant. As the ground 'uncarpeted with vegetation' reflects 'from its surface [...] the heat which it had imbibed during the day', it reminds us of how the vegetal absorbs light (*RN* 245). Of course, it is in doing so, that through the processes of photosynthesis, it produces new materiality. In the context of my reading of Hardy's vegetal darkness as a challenge to light, the vegetal can use light to defy light, reinforcing materiality as the location of the challenge.

I(iii) Vegetal Faciality, Voice, and Agency

Hardy situates features usually located within the human, including faciality, voice, and agency, within the spatiality of the vegetal. There are countless references to Egdon as a 'face': it 'had a lonely face', Rainbarrow has a 'lowering forehead' and its vegetation is frequently described as hair with paths 'like the parting-line on a head of black hair' (*RN* 10, 48, 12). It also has its own sensory capacities: voice, observational ability, and a tactile awareness.

Perhaps it is these capabilities that have led to claims that in *The Return of the Native* Egdon Heath is a 'character'.⁴⁶ Cohen refutes such interpretations, as do I. However, I take issue with Cohen's alternative reading of the heath. Although he recognises 'the correspondence between human and landscape faces', he reads Hardy's description of the heath as filtered through the sensory capacities of its human characters, conceptualising the consequent relation between heath and human as 'symbolic, embodied, and continuous'.⁴⁷ For me, this is an anthropocentric interpretation, potentially predicated through Cohen's reading of the heath as landscape feature rather than as vegetal. If the heath is viewed as vegetal, its face, voice, perception, and agency, can more credibly be located within its own vitality without the necessity for anthropocentric interpretations. In my reading, it is not that Hardy likens human and heath, but that he relocates human features to the heath, widening the capacity of the vegetal.

Hardy represents the vegetal's 'voice' as produced through its spatiality. Wildevie hears 'the intonation of a pollard thorn [...] the breezes filtering through its unyielding twigs as through a strainer. It was as if the night sang dirges with clenched teeth' (*RN* 77). Although the sound is caused by the breeze filtering through twigs, it is the specific qualities of the species that produces the distinctiveness of the voice. Pollarding is carried out to create vigorous new growth, and it is this that gives it its 'unyielding twigs'. Rather than anthropomorphising the sound, Hardy's comparison of it with a 'strainer' and 'dirges with clenched teeth', draws attention to its consequent dense network of twigs.

These distinctive voices of different vegetal species enable a listener 'acoustic pictures' of the scenery:

⁴⁶ Cohen, p.446-7, provides some examples of these, including Jean Brooks in '*The Return of the Native: A Novel of Environment*, in *Thomas Hardy's The Return of the Native*, ed. by Harold Bloom (New York, Chelsea, 1987), and William H Rutland in *Thomas Hardy: A Study of His Writings and Their Background* (New York, Russell, 1962). See Cohen footnote 17.

⁴⁷ Cohen, p.446-7.

they could hear where the tracts of heather began and ended; where the furze was growing stalky and tall; where it had been recently cut; in what direction the fir-clump lay, and how near was the pit in which the hollies grew; for these differing features had their voices no less than their shapes and colours (*RN* 78).

Although it is humans who perceive the differences in these voices, they are enabled to do so because the disparate voices are produced through the distinctive spatial qualities of each species. The furze even has a different voice depending upon whether it is 'stalky and tall' or 'recently cut'.

Vegetal spatiality almost becomes a language. Hardy describes the heath-bells' 'worn whisper, dry and papery' as caused by 'neither stems, leaves, fruit, blades, prickles, lichen, nor moss. They were the mummied heath-bells of the past summer [...] dried to dead skins by October suns' (*RN* 50). Hardy makes the point that rather than the sound created by these heath-bells coming from the vitality of its life, it is produced through the structural spatiality formed by the dead parts. This structural voice suggests to me that Marder's interpretation of vegetal spatiality and posture being a plant's 'language' might be a useful lens. For Marder, a plant meaningfully 'expresses itself' through its spatiality and he is insistent that in interpreting this as 'language', rather than using a metaphor, he is treating language through the 'hyper-materialist tradition' that 'is alive to the spatial relations and articulations between beings, animate or inanimate' (*MM* 75). Through this perspective, Hardy's vegetal spatiality can be read as communicative and meaningful.

This contrasts with two anthropocentric interpretations of the heath-bells' voice that Hardy speculates upon:

"The spirit moved them." A meaning of the phrase forced itself upon the attention; and an emotional listener's fetichistic mood might have ended in one of more advanced quality. It was not, after all, that the left-hand expanse of old blooms spoke, or the right-hand, or those of the slope in front; but it was the single person of something else speaking through each at once (*RN* 50).

The 'emotional listener' in 'fetichistic mood' hears the distinct sounds of different areas. The second listener is of 'more advanced quality' and hears a single voice. Mattar reads this passage as an enactment of 'the evolution from a fetichistic to a theological mode' that is 'monotheistic'.⁴⁸ Although she reads Hardy in *The Return of the Native* as at times veering towards 'fetichism' and 'animism', she also perceives the connection between such beliefs and scientific materialist thinking, claiming that both are rooted in an understanding 'that more metaphysical systems of thought lack', that 'humanity is part of the larger organism of nature'.⁴⁹ That being so, for me even an animistic interpretation is problematic as it fails to take into account the fact that this sound is created by the dead parts of the heath-bells. My reading of this passage recognises that both the fetichistic and metaphysical interpretations by the listeners on the heath are imagined interpretations. In suggesting that 'the spirit moved them' is a notion that is forced upon their attention, Hardy highlights the fact that such an idea is rooted within the listener and that these are therefore anthropocentric interpretations. In contrast, the narrative voice makes it clear that the cause is definitively material, but, I argue, this does not mean that it is any less lacking in meaningful communication.

Hardy extends such vegetal capacity to the possession of awareness and agency. The heath 'became full of a watchful intentness now; for when other things sank brooding to sleep the heath appeared slowly to awake and listen' (RN 8-9). Like the 'black fraternisation' of vegetal darkness and the night, this sinister vegetal alertness seems threatening. Hardy implies that the vegetal has agential capacity and this is reinforced through its spatiality enabling its participation in the plot. Such agency works to drive the plot forward, benefiting the natives and furthering the transgressions of the outsiders Eustacia and Wildeve, which eventually lead to their deaths. The threat is to the outsiders on the heath.

⁴⁸ Mattar, p.15.

⁴⁹ Matter, p.14.

This is particularly evident when tracing the symbolic and literal role of paths, these being places where the vegetal has been destroyed. For the outsiders, the wayfinding functions of paths are necessary; to the natives they are less essential. As Wildeve walks Eustacia home after the dance that they have attended while married to other partners, 'the irregularities of the path were not visible', with the result that 'Wildeve occasionally stumbled; whilst Eustacia found it necessary to perform some graceful feats of balancing whenever a small tuft of heather or root of furze protruded itself through the grass of the narrow track'. As a result, Wildeve must give her his hand, furthering their transgressive association. In contrast, Venn, in his role as a *deus ex machina*, is easily able to follow Wildeve by crossing 'the pathless portion of the heath' (RN 222-3). Natives like him have a more developed 'sense of touch in the feet' so that 'a difference between impact on maiden herbage, and on the crippled stalks of a slight footway, is perceptible through the thickest boot or shoe' (RN 52), the spatial qualities of the vegetal recognised by the natives.

Even when the paths are followed by natives, they forward the disruptive plot. When Mrs Yeobright attempts to visit her son, Clym, newly married to Eustacia, 'she tried one ascending path and another, and found that they led her astray' (RN 231). Leaving without seeing him, 'in her anxiety to get out of the direct view of the house she had diverged from the straightest path homeward' (RN 238). This leads to her death, Clym and Eustacia's separation, and onwards to Eustacia and Wildeve's tragic ending. Later, when Clym is presented with three paths outside his house, he chooses the path to Johnny Nunsuch's house, who reveals the information that leads to Clym's understanding of Eustacia's role in the death of his mother.

Hardy also stresses how the whiteness of paths distinguishes them from the darkness of the heath. In the twilight 'the white surface of the road remained almost as clear as ever' (RN 11), whereas moonlight is 'powerless to silver such sable features' of 'the masses of furze and heath' (RN 114). Such whiteness, and its relationship to light, furthers Hardy's

problematization of light in favour of materialised darkness, as through such whiteness, Hardy symbolically links paths to Eustacia and Wildeve's transgressions. As they dance, they make the vegetation under their feet more reflective as 'the hard, beaten surface of the sod, when viewed aslant towards the moonlight, shone like a polished table'. Then as they walk home, the moonlight acts upon *them* and makes their faces appear 'like two pearls on a table of ebony'. Paths and their corresponding whiteness become symbols of how their actions on the night of the dance cause them to break social codes of fidelity to their marriage partners: 'the dance had come like an irresistible attack upon whatever sense of social order there was in their minds, to drive them back into old paths which were now doubly irregular' (RN 219-222).

Like paths, the bonfires are places of vegetal erasure and further the tragic plot. They act as romance signals between Eustacia and Wildeve: their first meeting in the novel is expedited by Eustacia's signalling bonfire, and her bonfire one year later precipitates their final tragedy. Their story therefore becomes framed by the destruction of vegetation. Moreover, the specific material qualities of the different vegetal species also play a role. Of the fifth of November bonfires at the beginning of the novel, Eustacia's is 'steady and persistent' (RN 47) as its fuel is 'hard pieces of wood [...] the knotty boles of old thorn trees' (RN 53) and therefore able to attract Wildeve's attention, whereas the other bonfires, made of furze or straw and beanstalks, are less long-lasting. Likewise, the bonfire one year later that again attracts Wildeve, is built with the long-lasting material of 'furze stumps, thorn-tree roots, and [...] other solid materials' (RN 281). Destruction of the vegetal, whether paths or bonfires, advances the plot, eventually ridding the heath of these disruptive outsiders.

II: HUMANITY

II(i) Thought as a 'disease of flesh'

In the second part of this chapter, I turn to Hardy's representation of humanity. I thereby echo Hardy's structure in which humanity does not appear until chapter two, after the description of the heath in chapter one. Hardy's structure is another reflection of the chronology of the biblical creation: only after creating land and the vegetal, does God make humankind. Through entitling this second chapter 'Humanity Appears upon the Scene, Hand in Hand with Trouble', Hardy indicates that unlike the 'imperturbable countenance' of the heath, humanity will be the cause of disquiet (RN 268).

It is the human mind that Hardy pinpoints as problematic, particularly a dualistic conception of it as a separate sphere that is in conflict with the body. Marder compares humanity with the vegetal in terms of the possession of such a separate inner sphere. For the vegetal there is no separate 'inner essence that would be hidden behind the surface level of its phenomenal appearances' (MM 80). In contrast, for humankind, he paraphrases Aristotle in claiming that 'what makes humans human is not their physical shape but *logos*' (MM 77). In many of his novels Hardy presents a life based on the mind alone as detrimental, dramatizing this through characters such as Clym Yeobright in *The Return of the Native*, Edred Fitzpiers in *The Woodlanders*, and Angel Clare in *Tess of the d'Urbervilles*. In Clym, Hardy explicitly illustrates the conflict between intellect and body through describing his face as 'ruthlessly overrun by its parasite, thought'. For Clym, thought is a 'disease of flesh' (RN 120).

Hardy entitles the chapter in which he outlines Clym's intellectual development as 'My Mind to Me A Kingdom Is', and it is this domination of the mind that Hardy presents as problematic. Both Schopenhauer and Marder consider this over-developed human mind.

Schopenhauer views the intellect as 'designed for comprehending those ends on the attainment of which depend individual life and its propagation' (*WWR2* 284). The intellect's function is to ensure the survival of the individual. Both Schopenhauer and Marder consider the brain as a development from earlier stages of evolution. Marder views a continuum from the irritability of plants to the sensibility of animals, evolving eventually into a brain, and in a similar way to Schopenhauer, he sees its primary purpose as survival: 'the brain and the central nervous system do not invent a new function but offer a novel solution to the old problem of life' (*MM* 156-7). Reading Hardy's *Clym* through these lenses suggests a character whose intellect has become divorced from the practicality of survival. It has become too dominant and used for purposes for which it was not intended.

Barad's reconceptualization of knowing as integral to being, a notion I discussed in the introduction, locates knowing in a materiality that is in direct engagement with the rest of the material world. But *Clym*'s knowing, or thought, is separate to the materiality of his body, illustrated through the thought-marks on his face being representations of thought rather than thought itself. *Clym*'s mind uses the face as a 'mere waste tablet' that becomes 'overlaid with legible meanings' (*RN* 120). His face is represented as a recording device separate to the physical body. It is seen not 'as a picture, but [...] as a page; not by what it was, but by what it recorded', and these recordings are mere 'symbols' (*RN* 143). This is not Barad's knowing as being but knowing as separate from being. It is also a reflection of Marder's contention that thinking 'is a defect or disease' that is 'an anomaly or a gap, within the order of existence' (*MM* 79).

Marder extends this point to suggest that thinking is a cause of dissatisfaction with life, stating that it demonstrates a 'disconnect between life and formal knowledge, between existence and the brooding about its meaning or purpose' (*MM* 80). Hardy does indeed show *Clym*'s dominating intellect as that which causes him unhappiness. He describes *Clym*'s face as showing 'the view of life as a thing to be put up with, replacing that zest for existence

which was so intense in early civilisations' (*RN* 143), implying that the intellect displaces enjoyment in mere life itself. It takes the reader back to his comment in the *Life* that I discussed in the introduction: that the extremity of development in humankind means that there can be no 'happiness' for 'higher existences'.⁵⁰

I have already considered how Hardy portrays an opposition between symbolic and metaphysical light and material darkness, and how he associates the transgressive Eustacia and Wildeve with light. I now want to extend this analysis of Hardy's use of the light/dark antithesis through his representation of the separate internal sphere of the mind as a symbolic light. Hardy portrays the mind as using or feeding off the body. He suggests that 'mental luminousness must be fed with oil of life, even though there is already a physical need for it'. The separate inner sphere, characterised here as light, must parasitically use the life that is already required to support the body. This damages Clym and his face shows 'the pitiful sight of two demands on one supply' (*RN* 120).

It is instructive to compare Hardy's representation of a symbolic light as destructive to humankind with the vegetal's use of light. Humanity's face is marred by light whereas the vegetal transforms light to create its own dynamically changing face. For Marder, 'whereas humans remember whatever has phenomenally appeared in the light, plants keep the memory of light itself' (*MM* 156). For Clym, light is destructive; for plants it is constructive. They absorb light to use in photosynthetic processes to construct more life and more material. Through my reading, this produces more darkness that then competes with light. In the vegetal then, materiality can use and dominate light; in Hardy's construction of humanity, light feeds off materiality.

⁵⁰ Thomas Hardy, *Life*, p.227 (entry dated 7th April 1889).

Hardy's use of humanity's symbolic light serves then to separate us from materiality. The vegetal's use of light is embodied, whereas humanity's inner light isolates us from embodiment. In considering how humanity uses vegetal movement towards light to symbolise a movement towards the light of the heavens, Marder suggests that we are elevated from the rootedness of the earth but that in the process, the literal plant is devalued (MM 57). My reading of *The Return of the Native* proposes that Hardy recognises the importance of materiality and uses the symbolism of the inner light within humanity, to denigrate dualistic models of humankind.

II(ii) Autonomy, Heteronomy and the Returning Native

Another way of exploring how Hardy problematises the mind is through the opposing modes of being of autonomy and heteronomy, or self-determination and lack of. It seems to me that the human yearning for autonomy is a theme that many Hardy scholars gesture towards in their analysis of how Hardy dramatizes a life framed through self-determination as detrimental. Mallett asserts that 'Hardy's most thoughtful characters [...] appear wounded by the very act of trying to "mould" themselves' and he includes Clym in this category.⁵¹ In *Plant-Thinking*, Marder explores the differences between heteronomous and autonomous modes of being. He argues that the vegetal's lack of self-determination has contributed to its denigration (MM 67-8), suggesting that to be autonomous is to be judged as superior. Using the vegetal's heteronomous mode of being as a contrast to humanity's perceived autonomy becomes a productive perspective for considering this aspect of humanity.

The vegetal's relationship to light is heteronomous, light being necessary to its existence and growth. However, humanity's attachment to a symbolic inner light 'emasculates [our] integral connection to the environment' (MM 168). Norman Wirzba suggests that in nineteenth

⁵¹ Mallett, p.30.

century literature, emancipatory themes were becoming important, with freedom seen as a way of transcending the constraints of material life. Consequentially, humanity leaves behind material entanglements with the natural world.⁵² In many respects, this is Hardy's very point with respect to Clym. Hardy suggests that a more heteronomous mode of life that befits our vegetal inheritance, would result in a less alienating and more connected relationship to the other.

In characterising both Clym and Eustacia as 'original', Hardy gestures towards their predilection for autonomy and individuality. He contrasts such characters to the natives who are portrayed as more heteronomous and as a collective. Similarly, and highlighting the connection between the natives and the heath vegetal, Hardy represents the vegetal en masse. The sound created by the heath-bells is produced by a multitude rather than individual flowers. It is the 'united products of infinitesimal vegetable causes', the collective emphasised through describing them as 'myriads' and 'combined multitudes' (*RN* 50). Unlike the natives and the vegetal, the tragedy of *The Return of the Native* is predicated upon the motivations of individual autonomy.⁵³

It is Eustacia's yearning for autonomy that makes her such an outsider on and to the heath. Hardy individualises her as a 'divinity' and a 'goddess', suggestive of a being that surpasses an earthbound nature. But the heath limits her impact. Her 'celestial imperiousness, love, wrath, and fervour had proved to be somewhat thrown away on netherward Egdon. Her power was limited' (*RN* 60-2). To live on the heath, implies Hardy, it is necessary to be in a heteronomous relationship with it: 'to dwell on a heath without studying its meanings was like wedding a foreigner without learning his tongue'. He continues, pointedly contrasting this to

⁵² Norman Wirzba, 'Transformation of Practical Life in the Nineteenth Century', unpublished paper delivered at the conference 'Ecology and Religion' (multi-site conference: Atlanta, Seattle, Waco, Washington DC, Lancaster, 18th-21st September 2019).

⁵³ The contrasting modes of individuality and the collective are important themes in the work of Schreiner, and I explore these modes more fully in the second part of this thesis.

Eustacia's nature: 'to have lost the godlike conceit that we may do what we will, and not to have acquired a homely zest for doing what we can, shows a grandeur of temper'. Eustacia is determinedly autonomous, unable to accept 'compromise' (RN 65-6), surely an attribute of heteronomy.

It is, however, through Clym, the returning native, that Hardy more fully compares autonomous and heteronomous modes of life. Clym's trajectory is from autonomy to heteronomy and then, problematically, a limited reversion to autonomy. Comparing *The Return of the Native* to eighteenth-century fiction, Gillian Beer notes that Hardy 'moves the return of the native from the end of his story to relatively near its beginning' and that this then 'becomes the generative act of his fiction'.⁵⁴ She therefore reads it as a challenge to a nineteenth-century emancipatory agenda. Hardy presents Clym as one of whom others expected autonomy: 'he had been a lad of whom something was expected [...] he would not stand still in the circumstances amid which he was born' (RN 143-4). But after his stint as manager to a diamond merchant in Paris, Clym bucks such expectations: aiming to be 'less useless', he returns to Egdon with an ambition to educate the natives (RN 146). However, although Clym frames this aspiration as a service to his community, his response shows, as Mallett suggests, an 'undercurrent of egotism'.⁵⁵ His motivation remains framed through his own intellect. Although he might seem to be rejecting personal success and his ethics collective, the motivation remains autonomous.

Through becoming partially blinded, Clym's plans are, however, thwarted. He is 'transformed into an invalid' with 'all thought of pursuing his work [...] given up for a long time to come' (RN 208). His partial sightedness has been caused by intensive intellectual work. The symbolic inner light causes his literal partial blindness.

⁵⁴ Gillian Beer, 'Can the Native Return?', *Open Fields: Science in Cultural Encounter* (Oxford, Clarendon Press, 1996), pp.31-54 (repr. in Thomas Hardy, *The Return of the Native* ed. by Phillip Mallett, 2nd edn. (New York, Norton & Co., 2006), pp.504-524 (p.509).

⁵⁵ Mallett, p.27.

But it is through such partial blindness that Clym gains a greater insight, discovering truths to which, until now, he has been blind, particularly the role played by Eustacia in his mother's death. Hardy's chapter titles explicitly link this insight to enlightenment: they move from 'Wherefore is Light Given to Him That Is in Misery' (quoting Job 3.20), to 'A Lurid Light Breaks in upon a Darkened Understanding'. These chapters conclude with Clym's insight becoming embodied:

his mouth had passed into the phase more or less imaginatively rendered in studies of Oedipus [...] Instead of there being before him the pale face of Eustacia, and a masculine shape unknown, there was only the imperturbable countenance of the heath [...] defied the cataclysmal onsets of centuries (*RN* 268).

Hardy's reference to the self-blinded Oedipus explicitly connects such blindness to a wider insight. Rather than focusing upon what is immediate, Eustacia and her lover, Clym's perspective expands out to encompass the heath's long-term temporality. Furthermore, through comparison with Clym's mother's 'intuition', Hardy suggests that such insight is embodied, further denying the superior efficacy of the separate intellect. He describes Mrs Yeobright as having 'a singular insight into life', and his examples of others who, like her, are 'without clear ideas of the things they criticise', are literally blind (*RN* 162). Representing Clym and Mrs Yeobright as in possession of an embodied insight, characterises them as participating in Barad's knowing as located within being, and as such, in tune with all material beings.

Forced to abandon intellectual pursuit, Clym begins work as a furze and turf cutter, finding a commonality with his fellow natives, many of whom have similar occupations. Rather than merely returning to live on the heath, Clym's real homecoming seems to be this more integral relationship with the heath, returning to his childhood being when he was 'inwoven with the heath' (*RN* 144):

He was permeated with its scenes, with its substance, and with its odours. He might be said to be its product. His eyes had first opened thereon [...] first

images of his memory [...] his estimate of life had been coloured by it; his toys had been the flint knives and arrow-heads which he found there [...] his flowers, the purple bells and yellow furze; his animal kingdom, the snakes and croppers; his society, its human haunters (*RN* 148).

Hardy emphasises Clym's bodily relationship to the heath. He is 'permeated' with its 'substance' and is its 'product' as much perhaps as is the vegetal. Even his mind had been formed by it, and his return is therefore understood as both a physical and mental return. He is akin to the ants that have a continuous existence on the heath, 'those of the old times [...] the ancestors of these which walked there now' (*RN* 241). Reading Clym as 'product' of the heath through Barad's notion that beings emerge through 'intra-action', with "environments" and "bodies" [...] intra-actively co-constituted', Clym's formation becomes relational, and his subsequent separation from the heath, becomes a period of severance from naturally-formed relationships, and the damage that ensues inevitable (*KB* 170). His return becomes a return to the materiality of his very being.

Hardy's description of Clym in his new occupation becoming part of the heath's ecology is therefore apposite:

The silent being who thus occupied himself seemed to be of no more account in life than an insect. He appeared as a mere parasite of the heath, fretting its surface in his daily labour as a moth frets a garment, entirely engrossed with its products, having no knowledge of anything in the world but fern, furze, heath, lichens, and moss (*RN* 231).

For Marder, the loss of reason, the 'distinguishing element' of humanity, makes humans 'ontologically akin to non-human beings' (*MM* 77). Hardy presents Clym here as a mere 'being'. His silence and the reduction of his knowledge to that only of his vegetal surroundings dehumanises him, emphasised through this description focalised through Mrs Yeobright who at this point fails to recognise her own son. Describing Clym as a 'parasite' recalls Hardy's earlier description of the effect of thought as a parasite upon Clym's face. Now he is a 'parasite' on the face of the heath. But his parasitic destructiveness is reduced to 'mere'. Compared to the earlier 'ruthlessly overrun' of the 'parasite, thought' on Clym's face,

alongside his 'fretting' of the heath's surface, Hardy suggests that his destructiveness as a furze cutter is minimal. Abstract thought seems more damaging than physical destruction.

The dehumanised Clym becomes an integral part of the natural world of the heath:

His daily life was of a curious microscopic sort, his whole world being limited to a circuit of a few feet from his person. His familiars were creeping and winged things, and they seemed to enroll him in their band. Bees hummed around his ears [...] The strange amber-coloured butterflies which Egdon produced, and which were never seen elsewhere, quivered in the breath of his lips, alighted upon his bowed back [...] Tribes of emerald-green grasshoppers leaped over his feet [...] Huge flies [...] buzzed about him without knowing that he was a man (*RN* 211).

Through defining the butterflies as those only ever seen on Egdon Heath, Hardy emphasises Clym's limited world. However, his blindness reduces this even further, to a 'microscopic' area of only a 'few feet'. Clym becomes embedded in an ecological niche, becoming enrolled in a band with what might be viewed as insignificant beings. But Hardy's prepositional language constructs Clym's importance not just as non-human, but non-animal. Like the heath, furze and fern that spatially create this ecological niche in which the animals move and act, Clym's function is spatial: the bees 'hummed *around* his ears', the butterflies 'quivered *in* the breath of his lips' and 'alighted *upon* his bowed back', the grasshoppers 'leaped *over* his feet' (my italics). The flies even buzzed 'about him without knowing that he was a man'. Clym is not just vegetally heteronomous, but vegetally structural.

Hardy further portrays Clym as part of the heath vegetal through colour. He is described as 'a brown spot' (*RN* 211) and 'of a russet hue, not more distinguishable from the scene around him than the green caterpillar from the leaf it feeds on' (*RN* 231). He has become part of the heath's 'antique brown dress' and, by implication, as timeless as the vegetal. Whereas Clym has 'rough and brown' hands and a 'rusty look', in comparing him with Wildeve, 'elegantly dressed in a new summer suit and light summer hat', Hardy recalls the antonymic whiteness

of the heath's paths and the transgressive whiteness of Eustacia and Wildeve on the night of the dance (*RN* 235).

Such a vegetal appearance allies him to the other natives. Hardy describes the furze-cutters for whom 'every individual was so involved in furze by his method of carrying the faggots that he appeared like a bush on legs' (*RN* 16). Venn, concealing himself with turves to overhear Eustacia and Wildeve's conversation, also becomes vegetal-like. As he drags them over him, 'the turves, standing upon him with the heather upwards, looked precisely as if they were growing. He crept along again, and the turves upon his back crept with him' (*RN* 76).

Clym's relationship with light is also heteronomous, linked to the external light of the sun rather than the internal light of reason. Like the other natives, he becomes, in Marder's terms, vegetally hetero-temporal – plant temporality being derived from the time of alterity. When furze-cutting, the rhythm of his day is determined by the sun: 'he rose with the sun [...] to work from four o'clock in the morning till noon; then when the heat of the day was at its highest, to go home and sleep' (*RN* 211). This seems beneficial: Wildeve envies Clym's 'sweet sleep' (*RN* 237). Furthermore, being a furze-cutter, Clym's time is wedded to the material growth of the vegetal, controlled by the time embedded within its spatiality.

But if we read Clym's heteronomous relationship with the heath as his true homecoming, Hardy implies that this is an impossible return for humanity due to the demands of the intellect. At the end of the novel Clym rejects a heteronomous way of being and reverts to a life based on intellectual pursuit, becoming an itinerant preacher and planning on keeping a night-school. One can surmise that there might be something of Hardy himself written into Clym here. Both Clym's and Hardy's boyhood homes are just off the heath that becomes Egdon in this novel. Like Clym, Hardy is a returned native, writing *The Return of the Native*

while living back in rural Dorset after periods in London. Also like Clym, Hardy fails to maintain his returned native status with his subsequent move back to London.⁵⁶

Clym also struggles to accept an equality with other lifeforms. When he observes the heath's 'oppressive horizontality' which 'gave him a sense of bare equality with, and no superiority to, a single living thing under the sun', the modifier 'oppressive' implies that a sense of equality is burdensome and dispiriting (*RN* 177). In contrast, at the end of the novel Clym preaches from the highest spot on the heath, the 'commanding elevation of Rainbarrow' (*RN* 335). Such positioning surely reinforces some sense of perceived superiority of humanity in possession of an intellect.

II(iii) The Vegetal Roots of the Emotions

Although Clym struggles to perceive an equality with other living beings, through representing the emotions as embodied, Hardy does link humanity with other lifeforms. Recognising that for Hardy the emotions are embodied and are the motivating force within humanity is no new insight. I have already indicated in the chapter introduction Mallett and Levine's views on this. Mallett contends that, for Hardy 'feeling rather than reason governs human life', and he indicates an entry in Hardy's own literary notebooks taken from Comte: 'Feeling – the great force of human life.'⁵⁷ However, I extend this to argue that in *The Return of the Native*, through such embodiment, Hardy connects humanity to all other lifeforms, specifically the vegetal of the heath.

To emphasise their embodied source, Hardy infers a similarity between emotion-led human utterances and the voice of the vegetal. After the sound of the heath-bells, he describes the involuntary sounds made by Eustacia:

⁵⁶ In later years, Hardy does return to live in Dorset for the rest of his life, to a house built within miles of his childhood home.

⁵⁷ Mallett, p.21; p.25.

there mingled [...] a sound which modulated so naturally into the rest that its beginning and ending were hardly to be distinguished [...] her articulation was but as another phrase of the same discourse as theirs. Thrown out on the winds it became twined in with them [...] What she uttered was a lengthened sighing [...] There was a spasmodic abandonment about it as if, in allowing herself to utter the sound, the woman's brain had authorized what it could not regulate (*RN* 51).

Eustacia's sighing is 'twined' with and is the 'same discourse' as the sounds of the heath-bells. Her similarity to the heath at this point is emphasised as 'the night revealed little of her whose form it was embracing, for the mobile parts of her countenance could not be seen' (*RN* 52). With her own face indistinct, she becomes less human and part of the material face of the heath. In fact, in terms of her physicality alone, Eustacia is often allied with the heath. When first seen by Venn, she is 'much like an organic part of the entire motionless structure' of the heath, and it is not until she moves that he realises that the form is a human figure (*RN*,15). Other descriptions of her physicality ally her with the darkness of the heath. Her hair is that in which 'a whole winter did not contain darkness enough to form its shadow: it closed over her forehead like nightfall extinguishing the western glow' (*RN* 61).

The sound Eustacia makes is further vegetal-like in that it is unmediated by rationality. It had a 'spasmodic abandonment about it' which her brain 'could not regulate'. Hardy reinforces this irrationality when, later that same evening and in response to the appearance of Wildeve, 'a low laugh escaped her'. This is the third of three 'utterance[s]': 'the first [...] had expressed anxiety; the second [...] had expressed impatience; the present was one of triumphant pleasure'. All these sounds are led by emotion. They are inarticulate and spontaneous: they 'escaped' her. Furthermore, when she does eventually reply to Wildeve, she 'repress[es] herself' and speaks 'artificially', Hardy going on to describe her mouth as 'formed less to speak than to quiver' (*RN* 56-61). Language moderated by reason seems alien to Eustacia. As vegetal language, in Marder's terms, is spatial and material, her utterances are similarly corporeal.

The emotions and the vegetal are also allied in the way they fuel the narrative. The tragic plot is framed by the bonfires then driven forwards by the emotions. The vegetal provides fuel for the bonfires and, through describing the embodied emotions of love, passion, and anger through a vocabulary of inflammation and heat, they are characterised as providing fuel for the body and the language redolent of the bonfires. Eustacia and Mrs Yeobright are 'two people with inflammable natures' who give back 'heat for heat' (RN 205-8). In Eustacia 'indignation spread through her like subterranean heat' and for Wildeve 'the curse of inflammability is upon me' (RN 58-9). In places, Hardy even more explicitly links the bonfires and the emotions. The feelings Eustacia inspires in Wildeve are as 'the revived embers of an old passion', her own soul is 'flame-like' from which 'sparks [...] rose into her dark pupils' (RN 60-1), and she responds to Wildeve with a 'suppressed fire' (RN 78). When Eustacia dreams of Clym as 'excellent fuel' for 'newly kindled fervour', reading the bonfire as romance signal seems apposite (RN 104).

Jennifer Gribble's feminist reading of *The Return of the Native* is useful here. She reads the bonfires on Egdon Heath as one of the heath's 'traditional fertility rituals' and goes on to refer to Eustacia's bonfire as her 'sexual call' to Wildeve. She asserts that Eustacia uses this 'silent language of the heath' as 'a way of expressing feelings that cannot readily be articulated in any other language'.⁵⁸ Reading the bonfires as 'language' recalls Eustacia's own inarticulate emotion-led sounds, and almost validates this use of a fellow inarticulate language to communicate her feelings. Moreover, returning to Marder's notion of vegetal language, this suggests that the destruction of the vegetal in the bonfire, releases its spatially inflected language as it colludes with Eustacia on a path to mutual destruction.

Hardy also uses the colour red to link the bonfires and the embodied emotions. As Mrs Yeobright argues with Clym over his relationship with Eustacia, he 'reddened like fire' (RN

⁵⁸ Jennifer Gribble, 'The Quiet Women of Egdon Heath', *Essays in Criticism*, 46(3) (1996), 234-57 (repr. in *The Return of the Native*, ed. by Phillip Mallett, 2nd edn. (New York, Norton & Co., 2006) pp.524-542 (p.529-531).

165), and Eustacia's face 'burnt crimson' when she conceals Wildeve's presence from Clym's mother (*RN* 226). Redness linked to emotions can also be traced through the romance of the reddleman, Diggory Venn, and Thomasin Yeobright. Although Venn's colour is due to his reddle-dealing, Hardy pointedly informs the reader that Venn has no mercantile reason for being on the heath as it contains no sheep that need marking with said reddle (*RN* 129). Instead, his red presence is due to his attachment to Thomasin. It is only when late in the novel he returns to the heath with his skin and clothes washed of reddle that Thomasin accepts his proposal of marriage. Such removal of redness and tragic emotions seem part of the restoration of normality on the heath and allied to the deaths of Eustacia and Wildeve.

I have already explored how Hardy represents rationality as light and as that which blinds Clym. But Hardy also characterises the emotions as a cause of blindness. Mrs Yeobright refers to Clym's developing attachment to Eustacia as being 'blinded' (*RN* 165), and he gradually grows 'accustomed to the first blinding halo kindled about him by love and beauty' (*RN* 171). However, it is not the emotions themselves that cause blindness, but that the rational mind is blind to the workings of the emotions, buried as they are in the darkness of the body. Hardy presents this conflict in Eustacia. Wildeve's effect on her is as 'a sigh which shook her like a shiver. Whenever a flash of reason darted like an electric light upon her lover' (*RN* 60). Rationally, Eustacia knows that Wildeve is not good for her, but her feelings clash with this reasoned judgement and dominate her response.

It is instructive to read this through Schopenhauer's interpretation of the emotions that drive reproduction as related to the 'unconsciousness of the plant [...] [which] remains the foundation' or 'the original and natural condition of all things' (*WWR2* 142), therefore allying the emotions and the body. Schopenhauer identifies our 'digestion, circulation, secretion, growth, and reproduction' as 'functions of our body which are not guided by knowledge' (*WWR1* 115), and as the 'vegetative part of our own life' (*WWR1* 275). Furthermore, in his

article on Schopenhauer and Darwinism, David Asher claims that Schopenhauer views sexual love as an expression of the will, suggesting that Nature implants an illusion in humankind that we perceive as 'love', with the aim of securing the next generation.⁵⁹ From this perspective, Hardy's characters are blind to the working of love and passion, such a drive being unconscious. The problem is that our minds hoodwink us into assuming that we are rational beings.

I am not claiming that Hardy's notion of the over-riding motivation of love is influenced by Schopenhauer's view, and instead concur with Mallett's view that although many of Hardy's views at this point might bear similarity to those of Schopenhauer, that does not mean that they are influenced by him. But it is not inconceivable that Hardy might have come across such Schopenhauerian ideas through the work of Darwin. Hardy's knowledge and appreciation of Darwin's ideas is well-known, and Schopenhauer's notion that the 'aim of all love intrigues [...] is really of more importance than all other ends in human life' (i.e. the 'composition of the next generation'), is outlined in Darwin's *Descent of Man*.⁶⁰ In fact, Darwin quotes these lines directly from (and attributes them to) Asher's 1871 article on Schopenhauer.⁶¹ Be that as it may, in *The Return of the Native*, Hardy shows that love cannot be overcome by mere rationality. Eustacia desires 'to be loved to madness' and longs 'for the abstraction called passionate love more than for any particular lover' (RN 64). But in the narrative comment that 'if she had had a little more self-control she would have attenuated the emotion to nothing by sheer reasoning' (RN 104), Hardy suggests a helpless and deluded rather Schopenhaurian love illusion. Moreover, through entitling the chapter in which Eustacia and Clym meet for the first time 'The First Act in a Timeworn Drama', Hardy presents love and sexuality as perpetual instinctive human drives.

⁵⁹ David Asher, 'Schopenhauer and Darwinism', *The Journal of Anthropology*, 1(3) (Jan 1871), 312-332 (p.323).

⁶⁰ Charles Darwin, *The Descent of Man and Selection in Relation to Sex*, (London, John Murray, 1901), p.893.

⁶¹ Asher, p.323.

Hardy's representation of humanity as non-dualistically embodied, driven by bodily drives, could almost be read as a lesson to humankind. Bennett suggests that a recognition of one's own embodiment might be beneficial to humanity as well as to our relationship with other lifeforms. She claims that '*to raise the status of the materiality of which we are composed*' would contribute to 'human health and happiness' and that 'a newfound attentiveness to matter and its powers [...] can inspire a greater sense of the extent to which all bodies are kin' (JB 12-13, emphasis in original). Clym in particular would perhaps gain from such a perspective. It would not only allow him to recognise the role of his body, but also perhaps engender a respect for the materiality of other lifeforms, and allow him to perceive his 'equality', rather than superiority, with beings that function without conscious reasoning.

Chapter Two - Entanglement, Imperfection and the 'Unfulfilled Intention': The Vegetal Challenge to the Metaphysical in Hardy's *The Woodlanders*

In its very being the plant accomplishes a lived destruction of metaphysics.
(Michael Marder, *Plant-Thinking*, p.11)

The FAILURE of THINGS to be what they are meant to be, lends them, in place of the intended interest, a new and greater interest of an unintended kind.
(Thomas Hardy, *Life*, p.127, emphasis in original)

In this chapter I explore how in *The Woodlanders*, published nine years after *The Return of the Native*, Hardy extends his challenge to the metaphysical. I read the novel as, in part, an exploration of the relationship between an underlying metaphysical idealism and a complex phenomenal reality. As in *The Return of the Native*, Hardy situates the challenge to the metaphysical in the vegetal, but rather than locate this in its darkness, he positions it in its complex spatiality. He extends this through creating entanglements between the vegetal and humanity which result in complex networks of beings and events, in which causality becomes non-linear. Evolutionary competition becomes part of this complexity in which all beings impact upon one another. Through locating the metaphysical viewpoint in the outsider character of Edred Fitzpiers, Hardy provides a mouthpiece for this perspective and through undermining this character, offers a critique of the efficacy of the metaphysical perspective.

I argue that Hardy uses the networked structure of the vegetal as a model for the webs and entanglements embedded in the structure of *The Woodlanders*. The vegetal's complex spatiality is predicated on the multiplicity, adaptability, and continuousness of its growth, which problematises a metaphysical notion of oneness and ideality. Reading it through the lens of Michael Marder's claim that the vegetal 'in its very being [...] accomplishes a lived destruction of metaphysics' (MM 11), entitling the second chapter of *Plant-Thinking*, 'The Body of the Plant; or, The Destruction of the Metaphysical Paradigm', vindicates such a role

for the vegetal. Furthermore, its heteronomous mode of being means that it cannot be isolated from alterity. Its plasticity and continuous adaptation to external conditions means that for the vegetal there can be no ideal being. Through using an woodland setting, Hardy makes use of the complex spatial relationships between vegetal beings and the human inhabitants of the wood to entangle the vegetal in the plot. Through the representation of evolutionary and ecological relationships, I argue that Hardy's resulting 'Unfulfilled Intention' (W 48) embeds imperfection and suggests that life itself is the result of such relationships.

Hardy's plot interweaves the worlds of vegetal and human. Entanglements between the vegetal and human worlds complicate and problematise notions of linear causality and agency, and embed unintended and unforeseen long-term consequences. In this novel, relationships are key and reading these through Marder's vegetal ontology, Bennett's assemblages, and Barad's intra-actions, highlights how these all foreground relationships and therefore challenge a metaphysical idealist notion of perfection. Through the use of the arboreal as the main representative of the vegetal, Hardy embeds a long-term stability. However, that is not to say that this also embeds immutability. On the contrary, Hardy represents the trees and other vegetal species as in a state of continuous vigorous growth and change and, as such, their vitality dominates that of humanity. Through blurring the boundaries between vegetal and human, not least in the title of the novel, Hardy denies human pre-eminence and highlights the material continuities between lifeforms.

There are some similarities between the characters and themes of *The Return of the Native* and *The Woodlanders*, namely that both are about the return of a native. In *The Return of the Native*, it is the returning native who is dominated by the intellect. In *The Woodlanders* the intellectual character is the outsider Fitzpiers, and it is through his intrusive impact on the 'woodlanders' that Hardy problematises both the intellect and his idealist metaphysics. Hardy also denigrates him through his failure to understand the vegetal world, and in this respect, pointedly contrasts him to the native, Giles Winterborne's economic and sympathetic

relationship to the trees, his knowledge of the arboreal, and his vegetal-like characteristics. The returning native, Grace Melbury, poised between these two suitors, must choose between the two sides of her own nature: intellectual and cultural interiority, or her native rootedness located in materiality and externality.

The remainder of this chapter is divided into five parts. In Part I, I consider how Hardy juxtaposes two different ways in which the connectivity of the world is revealed: the phenomenal and the metaphysical. I argue that, by centring the metaphysical perspective within an unfavoured character, he undermines that view in favour of a material understanding. I continue to explore Hardy's notion of material connectivity in Part II through examining his presentation of the close ontological similarities between all beings, predicated on materiality and exteriority. I also consider how he demotes the imagination by highlighting its illusory, contingent, and anthropocentric nature. In Part III, I consider Hardy's representation of the woodland setting as the location of energy and change, and how this enables it to dominate humanity and problematise human notions of ownership and hierarchy. In Parts IV and V, I go on to explore the complexity that Hardy embeds in the phenomenal world. In Part IV, I examine how he uses the complex networks of the vegetal to illustrate his web of entanglements between humans and non-humans. I assert that these webs problematise straightforward chains of causality and metaphysical notions of oneness. I also show how Hardy uses these networks to symbolically block the metaphorical realm of ideas. Finally, in Part V, I discuss Hardy's evolutionary 'Unfulfilled Intention' in which all beings impact on other beings. I argue that Hardy creates a world in which life *is* the resulting imperfections, refuting philosophical idealist notions of an underlying perfection and foregrounding the importance of relationships. For Hardy, there is no perfection and his characters have to learn to live in a world of constraints.

I. Metaphysical and Phenomenal Realities

In *The Woodlanders* Hardy uses a metaphorical web as his key organising principle. He suggests that the ostensibly 'isolated' and 'self-contained' lives of the 'woodlanders' are part of a larger system in which 'their lonely courses formed no detached design at all, but were part of the pattern in the great web of human doings then weaving in both hemispheres from the White Sea to Cape Horn' (W 20). Such a comment reflects his remark in the *Life*, from the period in which he was at work on *The Woodlanders*, that 'the human race to be shown as one great network or tissue, which quivers in every part when one point is shaken, like a spider's web if touched'.⁶² Although he retrospectively relates this comment to his later work, *The Dynasts* (1904-08), I contend that it is highly indicative of the 'great web' of *The Woodlanders*.

One of the important questions for me is where Hardy locates this 'web': in an underlying metaphysical reality or in the world of the phenomenal? At the time of writing *The Woodlanders*, Hardy seems to have been reading and reflecting upon an abstract reality behind the phenomenal. After his comment in the *Life* on humanity as a 'network' or 'tissue', he continues: 'the Realities to be the true realities of life, hitherto called abstractions. The old material realities to be placed behind the former'.⁶³ This implies the recognition of an underlying metaphysical 'reality'. In January 1887, the month before he completed *The Woodlanders*, in a comment on landscape paintings, he writes that 'I want to see the deeper reality underlying the scenic, the expression of what are sometimes called abstract imaginings'.⁶⁴ Again, Hardy seems to acknowledge an underlying metaphysic. Then in February 1887, shortly after completing the novel, he reinforces this understanding, writing that 'the material is not the real – only the visible, the real being invisible optically. That it is

⁶² Hardy, *Life*, p.183 (entry dated 4th March 1886).

⁶³ Hardy, *Life*, p.183 (entry dated 4th March 1886).

⁶⁴ Hardy, *Life*, p.192 (entry dated January 1887).

because we are in a somnambulistic hallucination that we think the real to be what we see as real'.⁶⁵

If we read *The Woodlanders* against this background, Hardy's 'web' might quite justifiably be recognised as located in the metaphysical. However, I argue that the novel should be read, at least in part, as more an exploration of the relationship between an underlying metaphysical reality and the phenomenal material world than a portrayal of the influence of an invisible connecting force. However, if there is any weighing up of these perspectives, through locating the philosophical perspective in the outsider character of Fitzpiers and representing the world of the material as dominant, energetic, and complex, Hardy undermines the importance of the metaphysical.

Hardy centres the philosophical point of view in the character of Fitzpiers who is 'primarily [...] an idealist' (*W* 120). I read him as a character who enables Hardy to examine how metaphysical ideas hold up in the world of the phenomenal. Lennart A Bjork suggests that in Fitzpiers, Hardy 'allows a generally not very attractive character to be an authorial spokesman'.⁶⁶ Fitzpiers is indeed unlikeable, which serves to undermine the metaphysical mindset that he espouses. But can we categorise him as 'authorial spokesman'? We would perhaps do well to heed Hardy's own warning, published in an essay the year after *The Woodlanders*:

a writer whose story is not a tract in disguise has as his main object that of characterising the people of his little world. A philosophy that appears between the inverted commas of a dialogue may, with propriety, be as full of holes as a sieve if the person or persons who advance it gain any reality of humanity thereby.⁶⁷

⁶⁵ Hardy, *Life*, p.192 (entry dated 13th February 1887).

⁶⁶ Lennart A Bjork (ed) *The Literary Notebooks of Thomas Hardy*, Volume 1 (New York, New York University Press, 1985), p.261.

⁶⁷ Thomas Hardy, 'The Profitable Reading of Fiction', *Forum*, March 1888, 57-70 (repr. in Thomas Hardy, *The Return of the Native*, (Norton & Co., 2nd edition, 2006)), p.394.

For Hardy, what is important is characterisation, not a consistent philosophy. The temptation to brand Fitzpiers as representing a particular philosophical perspective, let alone be an 'authorial spokesman', should therefore be tempered by an awareness of the exigencies of characterisation.

As well as making him unlikeable, Hardy undermines Fitzpiers through his status as an intellectual and an outsider. In describing his wide variety of intellectual interests – alchemy, poesy, astrology, astronomy, German literature, and metaphysics (W 111) - rather than praising this breadth of curiosity, Hardy constructs him as a dilettante. As an intellectual and outsider, he is alienated from the woodland and judged as strange by the woodlanders. Grace views him as 'a tropical plant in a hedgerow, a nucleus of advanced ideas and practices which had nothing in common with the life around' (W 46). The exoticness of vegetation is reinforced by his own sense of himself as 'a different species from the people who are working in that yard' (W 161). The reader's antagonism towards him is further exacerbated through his competition for Grace's affections with the favoured woodlander, Winterborne. In contrast to the steadfast Winterborne, Fitzpiers views Grace as an amusement to while away his time at Little Hintock and he even admits to, in the past, having had many 'infatuations at the same time' (W 189).

Hardy further problematises Fitzpiers's philosophical outlook through his division of the world into subjects and objects. Fitzpiers states that 'there's only Me and Not Me in the whole world' (W 45).⁶⁸ He illustrates this in his contention that 'human love is a subjective thing [...] it is joy accompanied by an idea which we project against any suitable object', going on to state that 'I am in love with something in my own head, and no thing-in-itself outside it at all' (W 106).⁶⁹ As well as reinforcing his flippant attitude to Grace, Fitzpiers here also illustrates

⁶⁸ According to this edition of *The Woodlanders*, this is an allusion to the idealism or transcendentalism of Kant and Spinoza. (See also the following footnote.)

⁶⁹ Hardy himself explicitly links this point to Spinoza.

something of Schopenhauer's understanding of love as a subjective delusion (see p.64-5). Although Hardy recognises that this is a characteristic of humanity rather than solely of Fitzpiers, through presenting an awareness of it through Fitzpiers, and by Fitzpiers using these ideas to comment specifically on Grace, Hardy extends his vilification of this character and undermines his perspective.

Fitzpiers's subject/object viewpoint is further problematised through the alternative point of view of the 'woodlander' characters of Winterborne and Marty South. Approaching this through the work of Karen Barad, Fitzpiers' view of the world is one in which there are gaps between 'human and nonhuman, subject and object, mind and body' (KB 185). In contrast, Winterborne and Marty's viewpoint, presented through their understanding of the vegetal, is non-objectifying. They perceive through the 'conjurer's own point of view' rather than that of the 'spectator', the 'conjurer' seemingly Nature itself. Their understanding is a 'clear gaze' (*W* 297-8) rather than filtered through a subjectivity, and much closer to Barad's conceptualisation of the relationship between knowing and being than is Fitzpiers'.

Barad asserts that 'knowing is a matter of part of the world making itself intelligible to another part [...] we don't obtain knowledge by standing outside the world; we know because we are *of* the world' (KB 185, emphasis in original). The trees are 'intelligible' to Winterborne and Marty as they too are part of that same world. For Barad, 'knowing is a matter of differential responsiveness [...] to what matters' (KB 149) and for Winterborne and Marty it is necessary to their living to understand the state of the trees. Their reading of the 'alphabet' of Nature, is through the touch of twigs or the sound of wind through the boughs. They can learn the state of health of a tree through its external appearance and from its upper twigs how far the roots have grown downwards (*W* 298). Their knowledge is of the tree's being and this non-objectifying viewpoint is rooted in a natural experiential understanding of the material. In contrast, Fitzpiers' understanding remains filtered through the subjective mind:

once he knows that 'the trees, the hills, the leaves, the grass' are owned by Mrs Charmond they become, to him, 'endowed and quickened with a subtle light' (W 176).

But there is further significance in Winterborne and Marty's viewpoint being presented through their understanding of the vegetal. Marder identifies the vegetal itself as a challenge to an objectifying perspective. He contends that the plant, bereft of interiority and self-identity, and with a heteronomous relationship to alterity, has a non-objectifying relationship to the world and that 'learning from plants is in the first instance unlearning the objectifying approach to the world' (MM 71). Reading Hardy's vegetal through this lens means that the setting itself is a challenge to Fitzpiers' relationship to alterity. In this respect, his alienation from the woodland is appropriate whereas Winterborne and Marty's perception is vegetal-like.

II: The Material Connections Between All Beings

Hardy further confronts the metaphysical perspective through his emphasis on externality and materiality. For Marder, the vegetal's 'absolute exteriority' (alongside its heteronomy) means that it is a '*living* reversal of metaphysical values' (MM 55-56, emphasis in original). I argue that Hardy uses his vegetal setting to extend his problematisation of Fitzpiers' idealist philosophy by foregrounding externality and a corresponding lack of interiority. As George Levine suggests, in *The Woodlanders* 'Hardy's own scepticism about philosophical thought' is subjected 'to the hard force of the material world'.⁷⁰

As well as the vegetal, Hardy positions humanity within this material world. Although the vegetal is only materiality or externality, by placing humanity within a similar material realm,

⁷⁰ George Levine, 'The Woodlanders and the Darwinian Grotesque', in *Thomas Hardy Reappraised: Essays in Honour of Michael Millgate*, ed. by Keith Wilson (Toronto, University of Toronto Press, 2006), pp.174-198 (p.190/1).

Hardy purports a similarity between vegetal and human. Such a similarity is not simply that of symbol or analogy, but ontological and material, as recognised by William A. Cohen and John Heaney.⁷¹ Heaney refers to Hardy's presentation of a resemblance between species as a 'blurring of boundaries' and an 'ontological continuity'. Although I concur with his idea of 'ontological continuity', I take issue with his claim that Hardy's anthropomorphisation of the trees, rather than diminishing humanity, works to elevate the organic realm to the human level.⁷² I argue that rather than elevating the vegetal to the human level, Hardy denies hierarchical superiority per se and equalises vegetal and human.

It is partially through descriptions of their externality that Hardy characterises Marty and Winterborne as vegetal-like. Marty's hair is 'chestnut' and to Barber Percomb (who wants it to create a hairpiece for Mrs Charmond) she is merely this tree-like hair; everything else is 'a blurred mass' (*W* 10-11). After she has cut it off, Winterborne views her head as 'an apple upon a gatepost' (*W* 21) and, to herself, she is a 'stubby poll', resembling a pollarded tree (*W* 37).

Like Clym Yeobright of *The Return of the Native*, Winterborne is vegetal-like in his economic dependence upon seasonal trades and the necessary hetero-temporality is reflected in his appearance:

He looked and smelt like Autumn's very brother, his face being sunburnt to wheat-colour, his eyes blue as corn-flowers, his sleeves and leggings dyed with fruit stains, his hands clammy with the sweet juice of apples, his hat sprinkled with pips (*W* 185).

His staining is due to his apple trade, but Hardy's description of the colouration of his face and eyes further link him to the vegetal. Even his name links him to seasonality:

⁷¹ William A Cohen, 'Arborealities: The Tactile Ecology of Hardy's *Woodlanders*', *Interdisciplinary Studies in the Long Nineteenth Century*, 19 (2014); John Heaney, 'Arthur Schopenhauer, Evolution, and Ecology in Thomas Hardy's *The Woodlanders*', *Nineteenth-Century Literature*, 71(4) (2017), 516-545.

⁷² Heaney, p.519-527. (This is part of Heaney's argument that Hardy's vegetal, 'ontological continuity' and evolutionary paradigm is Schopenhaurian which I consider more fully later in this chapter.)

'Winterborne' being indicative of streams that flow only during the winter months.⁷³ When he is later described as 'the fruit-god and the wood-god in alternation' (*W* 249), Hardy not only reinforces his vegetal hetero-temporality through reference to his two seasonally-enforced trades, but gestures towards the pagan blurring of boundaries between human and nature, reinforcing the notion of Winterborne as materially vegetal.

Hardy extends Winterborne's materiality, and concomitant lack of internality, when he describes him climbing Mr South's elm tree to cut down branches. Enclosed in tree spatiality, and in response to Grace telling him that she is breaking off their engagement, Winterborne climbs higher, 'cutting himself off more and more from all intercourse', eventually becoming an 'unconscious figure' with an 'enfeebled voice', who remains 'motionless and silent'. Those features that make him exclusively human or animal: consciousness, verbal facility, and movement, are all diminished as he climbs further away from humanity and becomes increasingly embedded in the materiality of the tree. His exteriority and curtailing of mind is emphasised by his subsequent decision that he 'would not allow this incident to affect his outer conduct' (*W* 85-87).

Hardy further ties together vegetal and human through his language choices. When Hardy describes Winterborne as he sat upon a bough and 'placed his elbow in a fork, and rested his head upon his hand' (*W* 86), he is not only enclosed by the tree's spatiality, but the language also intimately links them. His elbow is in a 'fork' and this not only physically allies him to tree spatiality, such arboreal morphology has earlier been itself described as an 'elbow': when Grace and her father walk in the woods, Hardy describes their progress as 'elbowed old elms and ashes with great forks', the syntax here obscuring whether 'elbowed' is a verb describing their progress or a noun describing the shape of the tree (*W* 48). If the

⁷³ Hardy would have been aware of this derivation of the word 'winterborne'. He was born and spent much of his life in close proximity to the series of villages in Dorset that are named after these streams: Winterbourne Monkton, Winterbourne St Martin, and Winterbourne Abbas to name but a few.

second is assumed, this suggests that Winterborne's elbow is in a tree's elbow. The fact that he rests his head upon his hand also gestures towards Winterborne's mind being burdensome. When he finally drops out of the tree, it 'seemed to shiver, then to heave a sigh', suggesting that it is losing a material part of itself (W 97).

In *The Woodlanders*, humans are not only tree-like, but trees are human-like, but I find this converse analogy more problematic. Hardy's characterisation of humans as tree-like is based upon a common materiality. However, the idea of trees being human-like is built upon shakier ground, as it necessitates trees possessing mind.

Hardy himself foregrounds the illusory nature of the imagination. When the young women of Hintock woods partake in rituals on Midsummer Eve that derive from the pagan, Hardy notes that the 'imagination could trace amid the trunks and boughs swarthy faces and funereal figures' (W 129-130). Such imaginary perception is contingent upon the state of the individual mind. When separated from all familiar contact, alone in Winterborne's rudimentary shelter on a stormy night, Grace had 'never before been so struck with the devilry of a gusty night in a wood', and she imagines a low swaying bough about to 'smite the roof in the manner of a gigantic hand smiting the mouth of an adversary' (W 277). Likewise, feeling guilty after having knocked Fitzpiers off his horse, Mr Melbury sees tree trunks and large branches 'in the forms of sentinels, gigantic candelabra, pikes, halberds, lances, and whatever else the fancy chose to make of them' (W 230). Anna Burton asserts that in this second passage Hardy pleads with the observer to imaginatively read the space and that the imagination is necessary to read this landscape.⁷⁴ However, I interpret Hardy as suggesting here that it is the anthropomorphisation of the arboreal that is fanciful.

Hardy contrasts these illusions with Winterborne and Marty's understanding of the woods:

⁷⁴ Anna Burton, *Trees in Nineteenth-Century English Fiction: The Silvicultural Novel* (London, Routledge, 2021), p.152-3.

They had been possessed of its finer mysteries as of commonplace knowledge; had been able to read its hieroglyphs as ordinary writing; to them the sights and sounds of night, winter, wind, storm, amid those dense boughs, which had to Grace a touch of the uncanny, and even of the supernatural, were simply occurrences whose origin, continuance, and laws they foreknew (*W* 297-8).

Winterborne and Marty demystify notions of an imaginative 'uncanny' or 'supernatural' world, reading the woodland space through 'commonplace knowledge' and straightforward events. Moreover, they can de-cipher it in terms of 'hieroglyphs': pictorial rather than representative writing, in which appearance is meaningful without the necessity for any further interpretative act. Drawing on Marder's notion that vegetal spatiality is its self-expression or even its language (see p.47), this suggests that Winterborne and Marty can understand such vegetal spatial communication. Furthermore, Barad's notion that 'knowing is a direct material engagement [...] with the world' bears some similarity to Marder's point here, both suggesting that representational modes of interpretation are unnecessary (KB 379).

Barad's 'direct material engagement' and Marder's concept of vegetal language, is anticipated in Winterborne and Marty's ability to not just understand vegetal language but to share this communication. Their 'intelligent intercourse with Nature' suggests a two-way process. As they 'could speak in a tongue that nobody else knew [...] the tongue of the trees and fruits and flowers themselves' (*W*, 297-8), they not only articulate the meaning of the vegetal or Nature itself, but also illustrate Marder's notion that the vegetal participates in language.

Yet Hardy does not fall into the trap of denying the otherness of the vegetal. Theirs is an 'intercourse' with Nature, and the 'tongue' they speak during this communication belongs to that of the vegetal. It does not require any further meaning to be imposed by the human mind. Hardy perhaps makes a similar point in his description of mosses. After comparing them to other beings: 'moss like little fir-trees, like plush, like malachite stars', he seems to

correct his anthropomorphism in his affirmation that they are 'like nothing on earth except moss' (W 280). Their otherness becomes absolute.

Hardy suggests additional close ontological connections between human and vegetal. He describes a sympathetic relationship between tree and human that is predicated on the recognition of a material connection. In describing Winterborne's ability to promote tree growth, Hardy explains that:

He had a marvellous power of making trees grow. Although he would seem to shovel in the earth quite carelessly there was a sort of sympathy between himself and the fir, oak, or beech [...] so that the roots took hold of the soil in a few days [...] Winterborne's fingers were endowed with a gentle conjurer's touch in spreading the roots of each little tree, resulting in a sort of caress under which the delicate fibres all laid themselves out in their proper directions for growth (W 58-9).

Winterborne's 'marvellous power' could be understood as based upon his knowledge and experience. However, the notion of 'sympathy' seems deeper than this. Andrew Radford argues that it indicates a 'quasi-mystical correspondence between woodlander and trees' and that Winterborne has 'a magical possession of the vibrant physical milieu'.⁷⁵ Phillip Mallett suggests that in this 'sympathy' 'the spiritual connection between humankind and nature, pushed out by materialist philosophy, is allowed to edge its way back'.⁷⁶ While recognising how Hardy's use of words such as 'conjurer' might imply the esoteric, I offer a more materialist reading, that calls into service Jane Bennett's notion of 'onto-sympathy'. Drawing upon Thoreau, Bergson, and Darwin, Bennett considers a 'recognition', 'affinity', or sense of 'kinship' between humans and plants to which she, tentatively, gives the name 'onto-sympathy'. Such a connection is, for Bennett, engendered through an 'overlap between materialities of humans and plants'.⁷⁷ As Hardy's sympathy seems to move in two directions:

⁷⁵ Andrew Radford, 'Dethroning the High Priest of Nature in *The Woodlanders*', in *A Companion to Thomas Hardy*, ed. by Keith Wilson (Chichester, Wiley-Blackwell, 2009), pp.313-327 (p.316-320).

⁷⁶ Mallett, p.27.

⁷⁷ Jane Bennett, 'Vegetal Life and Onto-Sympathy', in *Entangled Worlds: Religion, Science, and New Materialism*, ed. by Catherine Keller and Mary-Jane Rubenstein (New York, Fordham University Press, 2017) pp.89-110 (p.90-94).

the sympathy is 'between' man and roots, and the roots respond to Winterborne, rather than Winterborne alone being in possession of some form of magical understanding, I consider that a material ontological connection, recognised by both man and tree, is a convincing and less anthropocentric interpretation.

This materialist interpretation is perhaps validated through Hardy's representation of another close material relationship: the material transfers across bodies. In excusing the presence of a slug on Grace's plate at Winterborne's party, Robert Creedle makes two rationalisations. Firstly, that her winter greens 'twas his native home', and secondly, of slugs and caterpillars, that 'they were born on cabbage, and they've lived on cabbage, so they must be made of cabbage' (W 72). It is helpful to read this ontological connection through Stacey Alaimo's notion of material transcorporeality. For Alaimo, transcorporeality conceptualises the continuous exchanges of substances across bodies, such that all beings, including humanity, are intermeshed.⁷⁸ These interchanges of material suggest that the slug or caterpillar is corporeally linked, even the same as, the material upon which it feeds. Moreover, through vocalising this through Creedle, Winterborne's rustic servant, Hardy undercuts any potential interpretation of this as expressing an underlying metaphysical unity. Rather, it is a straightforward explanation of an exchange of substances. Extended to the wider novel, through Winterborne's 'sympathy' and Creedle's transcorporeality, Hardy establishes a radical ontological continuity between all beings. Read in this way, humans are not like trees, but are the same as trees.

III: Adaptability and Vitality in the Woods

As well as denying human superiority through material continuity, Hardy elevates the vegetal by making it the locus of vitality. He suggests that it has a greater energy, adaptability, and

⁷⁸ Stacey Alaimo, *Bodily Natures: Science, Environment, and the Material Self* (Bloomington, Indiana University Press, 2010).

ability to change, than humanity. Burton suggests that the trees in *The Woodlanders* are 'almost ahistorical in their seemingly perennial immutability'.⁷⁹ However, although writing about Hardy's *Under the Greenwood Tree*, Elizabeth Carolyn Miller's understanding of arboreal instability is, I think, a better reflection of how Hardy uses the vegetal background in *The Woodlanders*. Miller asserts that Hardy calls attention 'to the way that trees in particular, and the natural world more generally, are erroneously represented as a stable, unchanging backdrop against which the drama of human life plays out'.⁸⁰ In *The Woodlanders*, Hardy's vegetal shows the continuous change of growth, regeneration, competition, adaptation, and decay.

Helen Macdonald writes that winter woods are 'places of interpolated timeframes' that are 'able to show you the last five hours, the last five days, the last five centuries, all at once'.⁸¹ Hardy's vegetal shows such a variety of temporalities of growth. Short-term growth is shown in the 'arms of ivy [...] pushing in with such force at the eaves as to lift from their supports the shelves that were fixed there' (*W* 23-4). This almost intentional vigorousness seems redolent of Schopenhauer's 'blind irresistible urge' of the will (*WWR1* 275). Longer-term growth is illustrated when Grace becomes lost in the woods. As she had not 'traversed this the wildest part of the wood since her childhood [...] the transformation of outlines had been great' (*W* 216). Trees have been felled or blown down and what were small bushes are now larger. And then there are the changes that indicate much longer-term growth. Although these might be impossible to perceive from the limited temporal perspective of humanity, they are present in Hardy's descriptions of disfigurements that are the result of long-term competition for light and resources: 'branches disfigured with wounds resulting from their mutual rubbings and

⁷⁹ Burton, p.151.

⁸⁰ Elizabeth Carolyn Miller, 'Dendrography and Ecological Realism', *Victorian Studies*, 58(4), 2016, 696-718 (p.709).

⁸¹ Helen Macdonald, *Vesper Flights* (London, Jonathan Cape, 2020), p.72.

blows. It was the struggle between these neighbours' (W 280). Even the references to 'elbows' and 'forks' allude to growth processes that occur over decades or centuries.

Hardy uses the vegetal's ability to retain the past in its spatiality to comment on human social relationships, the vegetal expressing a greater adaptability than humanity. Suspecting illicit meetings between Fitzpiers and his wife, Timothy Tangs sets a mantrap for Fitzpiers. He places the trap between 'a pair of young oaks which, rooted in contiguity, grew apart upward, forming a V-shaped opening between; and, being backed up by bushes, left this as the only course for a foot-passenger'. Although it is Grace who wends this way and becomes the trap's victim, it is the spatial kinship architecture between these 'sister oaks' that provides the space for this to happen (W 318-20). But as well as providing spatial agency, these oaks provide a contrast to Fitzpiers and Grace's relationship. In what follows I draw on Ruth Livesey's analysis of two inosculated beeches in George Eliot's *Adam Bede* (1859). She argues that through the eponymous Adam paying attention to 'a curious large beech' which may be 'two trees wedded together', Eliot 'breaks open' the narrative and provides a 'counter-narrative' that is 'an alternative to the inequality and violence that characterises human generative desire'.⁸² Hardy's two oaks, however, 'grew apart upward' although remain 'in contiguity' at their roots. Their youth is retained in the continued connection at their base while adaptation to conditions has enabled them to grow into more beneficial spaces. Although Fitzpiers and Grace's marriage continues to tie them together (at the roots, as it were), underscored by the fact that while Tang is placing his trap, Grace is re-reading through the marriage ceremony, unlike the oaks, they cannot adjust to their new situation. The vegetal can grow and adapt to circumstances; the social law continues to tie Fitzpiers and Grace together.

⁸² Ruth Livesey, 'Arboreal Thinking: George Eliot and the Matter of Life in *Adam Bede*', in *Anticipatory Materialisms in Literature and Philosophy: 1790-1930*, ed. by Jo Carruthers, Nour Dakkak, Rebecca Spence (Cham, Palgrave MacMillan, 2019), pp.131-151 (p.145-6).

Similarly, Hardy uses seasonal change to comment on the linear trajectory of human relationships. Later that same evening, Fitzpiers and Grace wander into the 'great green vase' of an 'encircled glade'. In describing this glade, Hardy calls attention to vegetal cyclicity: it 'was just that transient period in the May month when beech-trees have suddenly unfolded large limp young leaves' (W 323). But, of course, in the autumn these leaves will die, the glade will be less green and the boughs, currently heavy with leaves, will rebound. Hardy suggests, however, that Grace and Fitzpiers' commitment will not similarly cyclically rebound but lead onwards to unhappiness.

Through these changes, linear and seasonal, Hardy suggests that the vegetal has a greater vitality, enabling it to dominate humanity. Spring growth is described as a sudden bursting forth of energy, when the 'rush of sap in the veins of the trees could almost be heard'. Such a 'sign of great undertakings on the part of vegetable nature' is contrasted to people who 'are not undertaking much themselves' (W 121). The new growth of leaves in the spring 'cast green shades, which disagreed with the complexion of the girls' (W 129). The boughs enable raindrops to ruin the seed plots in the gardens that the woodlanders have 'snipped out of the woodland' (W 7). Even the road has had to be diverted around the growth of a large chestnut-tree (W 227). In considering the modifiers she uses to describe matter: 'vibrant, vital, energetic, lively, quivering, vibratory, evanescent, and effluents' (JB 112), Bennett critically reflects upon 'the default grammar of agency [...] that assigns activity to people and passivity to things' (JB 119). In *The Woodlanders*, Hardy reverses this, locating activity in the vegetal and passivity in the human.

The vegetal dominates Mrs Charmond, the owner of much of Hintock woods, and her house:

To describe it as standing in a hollow would not express the situation of the manor house; it stood in a hole [...] The ashlar of the walls, where not overgrown with ivy and other creepers, was coated with lichen of every shade [...] below the plinth, it merged in moss. Above the house to the back was a dense plantation, the roots of whose trees were above the level of the chimneys [...] The situation of the house, prejudicial to humanity, was a stimulus to

vegetation, on which account an endless shearing of the heavy-armed ivy went on, and a continual lopping of trees and shrubs [...] its hollow site was an ocular reminder by its unfitness for modern lives, of the fragility to which these have declined [...] It was vegetable nature's own home' (W 53).

The vegetal usurps the supposedly superior position of humanity. The location of the house is 'prejudicial to humanity' and yet is a 'stimulus to vegetation', and covered with ivy, creepers, lichen, and moss. The vegetal's continuous growth requires constant 'shearing' and 'lopping': this is Francis Hallé's vegetal that must continue to grow or else will die.⁸³ Moreover, the contour of the land means that even the roots of the trees are above the level of the house: the house is not merely lower, it is 'in a hole'. Through this positioning, alongside the necessity for the continual cutting back of the vegetation, Hardy makes comment on the insufficiency and conceit of the notion of human ownership of the vegetal. Mrs Charmond might own the trees, but she can neither control nor dominate them.

Hardy extends such problematic notions of ownership through Mrs Charmond being neither part of the community, nor having any understanding of the very trees that she "owns". As Grammer Oliver states, 'she's the wrong sort of woman for Hintock – hardly knowing a beech from a woak' (W 222).⁸⁴ For Mrs Charmond, 'this place oppresses me' (W 55) and her lack of rootedness is epitomised by the fact that after her death, as she had only a 'life-interest' in the estate, the relative to whom it passes wants 'to blot out every vestige of her' (W 301). Appropriately, even her body is not returned to Hintock and its soil. Unlike the sessile rooted vegetal, rather than her home, this is 'vegetable nature's own home'. Its relationship to alterity is also different to that of Mrs Charmond. Marder asserts that as plants strive towards exteriority, rather than returning to an inward self, they 'let the other pass through them without detracting from the other's alterity', thereby showing an 'inherent respect for alterity' (MM 42). Mrs Charmond's attempt at ownership is conversely an attempt to control alterity.

⁸³ Hallé, p.97.

⁸⁴ 'woak' is dialect for oak.

Hardy suggests that the only way for humanity to dominate the vegetal is to be destructive, albeit a necessity in an economy that is dependent upon these practices. But he represents such destruction as humanising the trees, with a felled tree reduced to mere human stature: 'the weakest idler that passed could now set foot on marks formerly made in the upper forks by the shoes of adventurous climbers only' (*W* 94). In preparation for this felling, the cutting of lower twigs and moss is 'comparable to the "little toilette" of the executioner's victim', and as the bark is subsequently removed, he asserts that 'if a fine product of vegetable nature could ever be said to look ridiculous it was the case now, when the oak stood naked-legged, and as if ashamed' (*W* 122). The ravaged trees are reduced to a humiliating vulnerability.

In writing about the position of Hintock House, Hardy suggests that modern humanity is fragile and has 'declined' since the house was built, suggesting human enervation compared to the vigorous vegetal. Such enfeeblement is emphasised by the fact that there are few kinship relationships in the contemporary world of this novel. There are only two parent/child relationships (Marty South and Mr South, Grace Melbury and her parents) but these offspring are now adults and there are no young children. There are also no siblings; these exist only in the world of the vegetal with the 'sister oaks' and Winterborne characterised as 'autumn's very brother'. Conversely, there are frequent references to the ancestors of characters, reinforcing humanity as being in decline. Even the aged trees have a vitality denied to aging humans. As Fitzpiers goes to visit Mrs Charmond, the 'stout-trunked trees, that never rocked their stems in the fiercest gale', are still green even though they are 'wrinkled like an old crone's face and antlered with dead branches'. In contrast, after weeping, the ageing Mrs Charmond turns away from Fitzpiers as she fears the impact of him seeing her face (*W* 177-78).

IV: The Complex and Entangled Networks of Vegetal and Human

A further aspect of the vegetal that Hardy presses into service in his problematisation of the metaphysical perspective is its complex spatiality. For Marder, the modular growth of plants, that makes them a 'collective being' or an 'assemblage of multiplicities' (MM 85) with no central control, contributes to the vegetal being a living critique of a metaphysical oneness. This network-like ontology is reflected in Hardy's 'network of boughs' (W 212) that is both that of individual trees and the wood as a whole. This vegetal network reminds us of his metaphorical web: remember that in the *Life*, he explicitly allies networks and his analogic web. But Hardy's vegetal network is no mere metaphor. The participation and entanglement of the vegetal in the plot physically manifests his web and in vegetal and human interaction, reveals the complexity of the phenomenal world.

Although Hardy frames his web as focused on 'human doings', he represents all beings as participants, including the vegetal. Darwin's own use of the image of the web, in which all species are entangled in an 'inextricable web of affinities' cannot be discounted as an influence, particularly as Hardy knew his work well.⁸⁵ Gillian Beer points out that through such imagery, Darwin emphasises the 'complex interdependency' of relationships in the natural world: 'plants and animals, most remote in the scale of nature are bound together by a web of complex relations'.⁸⁶ Hardy recognises the evolutionary and ecological relationships between different species and kingdoms. However, in terms of the plot, his web of entanglements between vegetal and human, as well as being economic, are predicated upon vegetal spatiality. I have already considered how the spatiality of the 'sister oaks' is implicated in the plot. But when on Midsummer eve, Fitzpiers 'captured' Grace as she 'flew

⁸⁵ Darwin, Charles, *On The Origin of Species*, Chapter XIII.

⁸⁶ Gillian Beer, *Darwin's Plots: Evolutionary Narrative in Darwin, George Eliot and Nineteenth-Century Fiction* (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 2000), p.158-9. Quotation taken from Darwin, *Origin of Species*, Chapter III.

round the fatal bush where the undergrowth narrowed to a gorge' (W 133), it is the wider spatial network of the vegetal that creates this opportunity.

The vegetal network even imposes network-like behaviour onto humanity. After arguing with Mrs Charmond over Fitzpiers, Grace becomes lost in the woods. As a result, she 'zigzagged about' and struck out 'hither and thither in random courses' with 'no ideas as to direction at all', whereas 'the ground she had covered if in a straight line, must inevitably have taken her out of the wood'. Embedded in vegetal spatiality, Grace herself is forced into network-like patterns. There is even a sense that vegetal time is driving her. As she walks a track that is 'screened and roofed in from the outer world' by the 'network of boughs', it 'led her slowly on till in time she had left the larger trees behind her' (W 211-17). Reading this through Marder's notion that vegetal growth embeds time itself (MM 104), Grace seems to be conscripted into the temporality of the vegetal.

Pushing this analogy a little further, it can also be read as a critique of the philosophy of Fitzpiers and his non-vegetal-like being and behaviour. Grace's agitated state, the cause of her network-like ramblings, is, at least partially, caused by Fitzpiers's lack of straightforwardness in relation to herself and Mrs Charmond. In this sense, he is the cause of her becoming more vegetal-like. Moreover, his own duplicity suggests that his behaviour is at odds with his avowed interest in pure reasoning. Although in his own garden the vegetation is clipped to create straight paths with designated areas for specific species (W 101-2), symbolic of his idealist thinking, his actual behaviour, and that that he foists on others, seems closer to the entangled networks of the woodland vegetal. His purity of thinking cannot be maintained in the world of the phenomenal.

The entanglements between human and vegetal contribute to a web of causalities that are more complex than those Hardy creates in *The Return of the Native*. As an example, one of the most complex of these causal webs connects the mature elm tree outside Mr South's

house, Mr South's life, his death, and the events that follow. From the unwell Mr South's point of view, the elm tree and he are entangled in a malevolent relationship. He thinks that the elm, that 'sprouted up when he was born on purpose to rule him', will now kill him by falling onto his house. It does, in fact, kill him but not in the way that he expects. Due to its impact on his mental stability, the tree is cut down and it is through being now able to see a 'vacant patch of sky in place of the branched column so familiar to his gaze', that Mr South 'paralysed by amazement', dies (W 93-4).

If this appears to be a straightforward chain of events, when the wider plot is considered, it appears more web-like than linear. Through the loss of the tree and consequent death of Mr South, the houses held on life-leases, the last life being that of Mr South, revert to Mrs Charmond, the estate owner. Winterborne's house being one of these, this results in him losing it, and his lack of shelter leads onwards to his death. Winterborne's death leads to Grace's eventual reunion with her estranged husband, Fitzpiers, who is Mrs Charmond's former lover. Fitzpiers is the very doctor who had ordered Winterborne to cut down the tree to save Mr South's life, but that unintentionally kills him. It is useful to read this through Bennett's conceptualisation of the entangled bodies of the assemblage, the entanglement here being between the elm tree, Mr South, Winterborne, Grace, Mrs Charmond, life-leases, and Fitzpiers, as well as other characters. For Bennett, the properties that emerge from such an assemblage mean that 'efficient causality [...] will be impossibly rare' (JB 32). Indeed, Hardy's assemblage is a multifactorial and labyrinthine network of beings and events, in which causality is impossible to disentangle and from which emerge unforeseen and unintended consequences.

If these complex causalities are read through Marder's vegetal, it suggests a further critique of metaphysics. Marder contends that due to the plant's infinitely growing and modular body, it has no beginning or ending, and it therefore becomes a 'concrete refutation of the metaphysical yearning for the pure origins and first causes of life' (MM 86). Hardy's most

complex causal webs, like Marder's vegetal, lack straightforward originating causes. Marty's letter to Fitzpiers informing him that she was the original owner of the hair that Mrs Charmond claims as her own, and that was intended as an act of revenge, reaches further backwards and forwards in time than Marty intends or realises. We can even question if there is a beginning to such a chain of events. Does it originate in that fact that her father's illness causes her to sell her hair to earn money? Or further back when the copyholds were exchanged for life-leases? Or even further, in the germination of the elm sapling? These events also lack any conclusion and the consequences become distanced and unforeseen. Under the influence of Marty's letter, Fitzpiers parts from Mrs Charmond just before her death and therefore escapes 'being dragged into the inquiry'. Hardy suggests that this letter is therefore 'the tiny instrument of a cause deep in nature' (W 301). As well as highlighting the impossibility of teasing out any straightforward beginning or ending of such chains of causality, Hardy here surely gestures back to his musings on the nature of reality. But the phenomenality of his web, however complex it is, indicates that such connections lie within the world of the concrete rather than in a hidden underlying reality.

Hardy also uses the networked spatiality of the vegetal as a challenge to light itself. In the previous chapter I explored how in *The Return of the Native* Hardy uses the darkness of vegetal materiality to defeat the light of the sun, the biblical creation, and reason. In *The Woodlanders*, Hardy once again uses the vegetal to challenge the light of the sun as well as the symbolic light of reason and metaphysics. However, rather than the darkness of the material vegetal, in *The Woodlanders*, it is the vegetal's spatial network that Hardy emphasises as the challenge: in the summer, the density of the network blocks the sun with 'scarce a crevice existing by which a ray could get down to the ground' (W 268).

Hardy suggests that exposure to the sky is antagonistic to the woodlanders. When the trees are in full leaf, glimpses of the sky through the canopy are malevolent: there are 'strange faces and figures [...] that had somehow wandered into the canopied obscurity' and 'cloven

tongues' on the tips of the bough (W 268-9). When Winterborne's house is destroyed a 'piece of sky [...] where his walls and chimneys had formerly raised their outlines' (W 168) is revealed, and this is part of the chain of events that leads onwards to his death. Likewise, the death of Mr South is caused by replacing the tree with a view of the sky and, significantly, it is Fitzpiers, the metaphysician, who had ordered the tree to be cut down.

In blocking the light of the sun and view of the sky, the woodland also blocks the realm of ideas and the location of metaphysics. Through Fitzpiers' house being positioned on a hillside above the woods, he is symbolically nearer to this realm and above the woods that block it. This is reinforced by the 'solitary point of light' that radiates from his house symbolising the single-minded certainty of reason. His activities are also out of temporal sync with the natural world with the light produced by his nocturnal studying 'dissociated' from the 'normal sequences' in Little Hintock that are the result of the 'regular terrestrial roll' (W 44). Furthermore, if Fitzpiers is connected to the realm of ideas in the sky, Winterborne is, in contrast, 'arisen out of the earth' (W 186), the source of his humanity being materiality. Marder argues that the 'metaphysical project [is] bent on leaving the darkness of mere life behind' but that this 'undercuts the conditions of its own existence' (MM 177). From such a perspective, it is this from which Fitzpiers is detached, undercutting his 'own existence' and contributing to his downfall. Or perhaps this is better expressed as his fall to earth as he eventually realises that he must adapt to living in the material world.

V: Evolution, Imperfection and the 'Unfulfilled Intention'

What must inevitably follow from the complex, networked and entangled causalities that Hardy portrays in *The Woodlanders*, is a lack of perfection for the individual. In fact, Beer suggests that 'maladaptation [...] obsesses Hardy'.⁸⁷ Hardy indicates that this theme will be

⁸⁷ Beer, p.232.

key on the very first page of *The Woodlanders*: 'the contrast of what is with what might be' (W 5). Ostensibly this comment is used to compare the deserted highway to its potential busyness. However, I interpret it as having a wider significance in this novel and an issue with which Hardy's characters are forced to tussle. Such a perspective is the antithesis of Fitzpiers' idealist thinking, believing 'that behind the imperfect lay the perfect' (W 120). It is perhaps significant that the light from Fitzpiers's window, symbolising the light of reason, 'blinked as the tree-twigs waved to and fro before its beams' (W 44), materiality intruding upon his reasoning. Hardy's complex phenomenal world thwarts the realisation of perfection.

Hardy manifests this imperfection in a vegetal image:

Here, as everywhere, the Unfulfilled Intention, which makes life what it is, was as obvious as it could be among the depraved crowds of a city slum. The leaf was deformed, the curve was crippled, the taper was interrupted; the lichen ate the vigour of the stalk, and the ivy slowly strangled to death the promising sapling (W 48).

Hardy illustrates here the effect of the competition amongst beings for resources. Leaves compete for light, as do branches which become 'crippled' and their growth 'interrupted'. The lichen, striving to survive, feeds on the stalk, and the ivy, using the sapling to grow towards the light, strangles it.

Although it is widely accepted that Hardy's 'Unfulfilled Intention' is a statement related to evolutionary competitiveness, interpretations vary. Beer reads it as an expression of Darwin's emphasis on 'imperfect adaptation' referring to his comment in *Origin of Species* that 'natural selection will not produce absolute perfection'.⁸⁸ Levine also interprets it as Darwinian, framing it within a discussion of the contrast in *The Woodlanders* between the material world and the world conceived by consciousness. For Levine, Hardy sees the woods 'against an ideal': 'there are [...] the material woods [...] but there is too the human dream of the fullest fruition [...] In the ideal woods, each organism comes to full growth

⁸⁸ Beer, p.232. Quotation taken from Darwin, *Origin of Species*, Chapter VI.

without encroaching on its neighbours'.⁸⁹ In Hardy's phenomenal world of complex causal entanglements, with all beings impacting on one another, whether through evolutionary competition or through other forms of impact, there can be no perfect being.

Although my own interpretation of Hardy's 'Unfulfilled Intention' is Darwinian, Heaney contends that it is closer to Schopenhauer's evolutionary paradigm, and he certainly offers some compelling evidence. He suggests that Hardy chose to use vegetal nature as the principal metaphor for evolution because in Schopenhauer's evolutionary system 'vegetable nature is allotted a central significance'.⁹⁰ This is indeed so, but I argue that more important is the fact that due to the vegetal being able to preserve visual evidence of earlier growth processes, and therefore competitive pressures, Hardy is enabled to use it to illustrate evolutionary effects. Heaney also draws attention to the energy and vitality that Hardy embeds within the vegetal. For Heaney, this is evidence of Schopenhauerian evolutionary processes that recognise the driving force as being the internal force of the metaphysical will, as opposed to Darwin's mechanistic model in which it is external forces, namely a changing environment, that provides the impetus for change.⁹¹ I would concur that Hardy presents the vegetal as vigorous and energetic and recognise the temptation to interpret this as Schopenhauerian.

However, I do take issue with Heaney's argument that Hardy's use of the word 'Intention' implies a Schopenhauerian 'teleological understanding of the life process' that is evoked in his, albeit non-conscious, purposive will.⁹² While being aware of Schopenhauer's rather tortuous rationalisation of the will as teleologically purposive, as well as recognising that Hardy's use of the term 'Intention' could perfectly logically be interpreted as similarly

⁸⁹ Levine, 'The Woodlanders and the Darwinian Grotesque', in *Thomas Hardy Reappraised: Essays in Honour of Michael Millgate*, ed. by Keith Wilson (Toronto, University of Toronto Press, 2006), pp.174-198 (p.185).

⁹⁰ Heaney, p.520.

⁹¹ Heaney, p.525.

⁹² Heaney, p.527.

purposive, Hardy himself, in an admittedly much later poem, refutes a teleological purpose to his use of this word. In 'A Philosophical Fantasy' (1928), when the first cause is questioned as to the meaning of '*unfulfilled intention*', it states that its creation was a '*purposeless propension*' (CP 893-7, 18; 142, emphases in original). Nevertheless, Hardy's 'Unfulfilled Intention' does suggest an incomplete or a flawed existence.

Hardy's suggestion that this 'Unfulfilled Intention' 'makes life what it is' calls to mind Schopenhauer's claim that life only exists because of the contest between beings:

everywhere in nature we see contest, struggle, and the fluctuation of victory [...] Every grade of the will's objectification fights for the matter, the space, and the time of another [...] This contest can be followed through the whole of nature; *indeed only through it does nature exist* (WWR1 146-7, my emphasis).

Reading Hardy's description from such a Schopenhauerian perspective suggests that the very existence of the trees, lichen, and ivy is due to evolutionary competition. A later image of 'trees close together, wrestling for existence' (W 280) likewise evokes the struggle as emblematic of existence.

Hardy's competitive diverse wood is predicated on relationships and by reading this through Schopenhauer and Barad I establish a connection between their relationship-based insights. Schopenhauer asserts that life exists because of the contest. Barad contends that matter 'entails entanglements – that is its very nature' (KB 160) and 'individuals emerge through and as part of their entangled intra-relating' (KB ix). Both Schopenhauer and Barad's conceptualisations are predicated on relationships rather than individual existence, and I argue that this is reflective of Hardy's point of view, not just amongst the contest in the natural world, but throughout the whole web, including humanity. His 'Unfulfilled Intention' is 'as everywhere' and 'was as obvious as it could be among the depraved crowds of a city slum'.⁹³ Life is everything impacting on everything else.

⁹³ Hardy makes a similar point in his poem, 'In a Wood' which I consider in detail in the following chapter.

If Hardy's wood is re-read from the perspective of life as a whole rather than through the lens of the individual being, instead of being a world of imperfections, it becomes a biodiverse, and therefore successful and thriving, ecological community that exists because of the competition for resources. Andrew Radford notes that Hardy's description of the wood immediately before the 'Unfulfilled Intention' passage is one of 'pastoral prettiness' only to degenerate into 'myriad disturbing features'.⁹⁴ This interpretation is of course anthropomorphic – nature itself is neither pretty nor grotesque. But Hardy's description of the wood immediately preceding and including the 'Unfulfilled Intention' passage is of a thriving community that includes a variety of species: moss, elm, ash, fungi, lichen, and ivy (W 48). In a later description of the woods Hardy includes 'yellow fungi [...] and tall fungi with more stem than stool', and 'rotting stumps' of dead trees 'rising from their mossy setting like black teeth from green gums' (W 280). Although this could also be anthropocentrically interpreted as a grotesque image, it is one in which decay is part of a burgeoning ecosystem.

Through the vegetal Hardy also evokes a continuity in life. An old and damaged beech tree nevertheless remains alive even though it has 'great pocket holes in its sides, where branches had been removed in past times' (W 280). The loss of branches is not catastrophic for the tree. As plants are modular, and the modules 'not internally related to each other, let alone to the individual vegetal being they comprise, and that are mutually indifferent to each other's existence' (MM 132), the loss of a module is merely that. The individual tree can survive and the ability to survive such loss attests to the beech's success rather than its failure. Hardy goes on to suggest that the dead branches were 'scattered about like ichthyosauri in a museum' (W 280). Rather than an image of extinction and death, I read this as indicative of the long-term continuousness of life. However, Fitzpiers interprets this damage differently. Discontented with his marriage to Grace and having begun a secret

⁹⁴ Andrew Radford, *Thomas Hardy and the Survivals of Time* (Aldershot, Ashgate Publishing Ltd., 2003), p.148.

affair with Mrs Charmond, when he observes a large limb that had snapped off a beech-tree, he exclaims, 'my good God [...] This is life!' (W 198), relating it to his own self-inflicted diminished life. His focus is upon the individual life whereas Hardy's beech trees show the survival of life as a continuum. They also embody a further challenge to his idealist views, showing that there is no perfect unchanging tree but continuous adaptation to conditions. This is further shown in the apple trees in Winterborne's garden: 'even now retaining the crippled slant to north-east given them by the great November gale of 1824' (W 167).

Hardy extends such a whole life perspective with its inevitable and necessary imperfections to that of humanity. In the *Life*, he notes that 'a perception of the FAILURE of THINGS to be what they are meant to be, lends them, in place of the intended interest, a new and greater interest of an unintended kind' (emphasis in original).⁹⁵ He illustrates this in *The Woodlanders* (and in his other novels) with the story or 'greater interest' predicated on imperfect relationships. In fact, at the point in the novel where Hardy considers the 'Unfulfilled Intention', Grace, promised to Winterborne, has just become entranced by Fitzpiers, and so begins the triangular plot, that results in the 'unfulfilled intentions' of many characters. Grace even, like Hardy, allies the imperfection in the human situation to that in the vegetal. As she watches Fitzpiers ride to an illicit meeting with Mrs Charmond, she observes acorns and chestnuts and notes that 'some kernels were unsound as her own situation, and she wondered if there were one world in the universe where the fruit had no worm, and marriage no sorrow' (W 184).

In *The Woodlanders*, all the main characters need to learn to accept the constraints of the world, even Fitzpiers. Like everyone and everything else, he must experience the 'Unfulfilled Intention'. In considering marrying Grace, and comparing himself with the woodlanders, Fitzpiers surmises that 'the secret of happiness lay in limiting the aspirations; these men's

⁹⁵ Hardy, *Life*, p.127 (entry dated 1st January 1879).

thoughts were conterminous with the margin of the Hintock woodlands, and why should not his be likewise limited'. He realises that being limited by circumstances might not, in fact, be unfulfilling. Such a limitation is even situated within the materiality of the woodland, dispelling his antipathy to the material. As he later 'dreamed and mused till his consciousness seemed to occupy the whole space of the woodland round, so little was there of jarring sight or sound to hinder perfect mental unity with the sentiment of the place' (*W* 123-6), Hardy suggests that Fitzpiers' consciousness becomes bounded within the material confinement of the woods. By the end of the novel, he even leaves behind his single-minded philosophical beliefs and becomes a 'practical man' (*W* 310).

Grace also changes as the novel progresses, increasingly accepting constraints and a vegetal-like rootedness. Hardy uses vegetal imagery to describe these changes, reinforcing the vegetal as location of change as well as showing how the woodlands and woodlanders revitalise her. He describes her earlier education as 'cultivation' and refers to her being forced into unnatural ways as being 'mentally trained' (*W* 40) and 'tilled into foreignness of view' (*W* 100). But as she comes to realise the value of the woodland community, she tells her father that 'cultivation has only brought me inconveniences and troubles' (*W* 201) and comes to crave even the 'defects and inconveniences' of the 'homely sylvan life' (*W* 212). Her responses to the woodlander, Winterborne, change as she empathetically also becomes vegetal as 'her heart rose from its late sadness like a released bough, her senses revelled in the sudden lapse back to Nature unadorned' (*W* 186). Moreover, when she wants to escape from her estranged husband Fitzpiers, her childhood 'Daphnean instinct' (*W* 268) is revived and she transforms into a tree to escape his amorous intentions.

By the end of the novel, both Grace and the reader must accept an imperfect resolution, settling for Hardy's flawed existence. As Beer writes, in Hardy's world of imperfection 'the

shadow plots of achievement and joy [...] can never fully manifest themselves'.⁹⁶ At the end of the novel, Grace's situation is somewhat reminiscent of Clym's at the end of *The Return of the Native*. Clym leaves behind his renewed pastoral life and returns to intellectual pursuit. Likewise, with Winterborne's death and her renewed acquaintance with Fitzpiers, for Grace the woods once again become 'uninteresting'. She retreats indoors and becomes 'quite a student, reading more than she had done since her marriage' (W 309). Fitzpiers' influence is again in the ascendant and Winterborne's diminished. If Winterborne is viewed as tree-like and read through Marder's contention that 'the loss of every tree [...] equals the passing away of meaning bound up with the particular spatial extension of that very tree' (MM 75-6), then Winterborne's death means that this vegetal model is lost to Grace. With Winterborne's death, even the two most suitably matched characters, Winterborne and Marty, cannot be united, and the novel ends with Winterborne's 'true complement in the other sex' (W 297) able only to tend his grave. All intentions remain unfulfilled.

⁹⁶ Beer, p.232.

Chapter Three - Life Lessons from Hardy's Vegetal Poetics

The mortal moan | Begot of sentience
(Thomas Hardy, 'The Aerolite' (*CP* 769-70))

I do not expect much notice will be taken of these poems: they mortify the human sense of self-importance by showing, or suggesting, that human beings are of no matter or appreciable value in this nonchalant universe.
(Thomas Hardy, *Life* p.408-9)

In this chapter I explore the vegetal poetics of Hardy and argue that he purports the vegetal mode of being as in many ways preferable to that of humanity. Rather than emphasising the connections between vegetal and human, as he does in the two novels I have explored, it is the vegetal as 'other' that is prominent in his poetry, and he implies that its different ontology might offer us lessons in how to live. He recognises that the vegetal has its own vitality, agency, and voice, and does not require humanity in the form of poetic speakers to impose these attributes onto it. In his problematising of consciousness, Hardy seems to admire, or envy, the vegetal's lack of a separate internal sphere which, he suggests, is what causes humanity so much trouble and heartache: existential worries, the ability to exist outside the temporal present, and the awareness of burdensome feelings. In recognising a continuing need to account for meaning and purpose, he relocates it to life itself. Life *is* meaning, the vegetal indicates, and this is one of the lessons that it offers humanity: that meaning is not limited to that that can be found in human existence, in the mind, and in the memory. In 'Yell'ham Wood's Story' he perhaps expresses this in its most straightforward terms: 'we come to live, and are called to die' (*CP* 298-9, l.10).

I consider seven of Hardy's poems in detail, and my selection is based upon those in which Hardy uses the vegetal to show that there is an alternative, and perhaps better, mode of existence than that of humankind; a mode of being in which material existence is sufficient and the human mind framed as a problematic and complicating addition. I begin with three poems that Hardy explicitly links to *The Woodlanders* and that extend some of the ideas

from that novel. I commence by exploring 'In a Wood', published in Hardy's first volume of poetry (CP 64-5). I argue that in this poem Hardy's speaker fails to find a Wordsworthian-type solace in vegetal nature and instead is faced with a disillusioning material embodiment of evolutionary competition. I go on to consider 'The Pine Planters (Marty South's Reverie)' in which this character from *The Woodlanders* is given space in which to voice her own concerns (CP 271-3). However, my reading of this poem problematises how she attempts to impose her voice and an existentialist perspective onto the trees she plants. I contend that Hardy resists such appropriation by interpolating the vegetal's own ontological agency. I next explore how, in 'Yell'ham-Wood's Story', Hardy returns to a similar idea to that of the 'Unfulfilled Intention' of *The Woodlanders* (CP 298-9). In this poem, Hardy's representation of the vegetal shows that organic transience means that although life must always be 'thwarted', meaning is in material existence. Following this, I examine 'A Backward Spring', recognising Hardy's appreciative presentation of vegetal hetero-temporality (CP 498). I argue that he contrasts this with the human ability, through memory, to exist non-contemporaneously, framing this as detrimental to human equanimity. My fifth poem, 'At the Royal Academy' is, I assert, a critique of how landscape paintings falsely represent permanence (CP 627-8). I examine how Hardy suggests that rather than avoiding the fact of mortality, humanity should reconcile itself to transience and change. Finally, I consider two poems about consciousness, 'Before Life and After' and 'The Aerolite' (CP 277; 769-70). Although these poems do not comment on the vegetal, Hardy's direct questioning of the benefits of consciousness in them, continues the argument that I have established, as does his suggestion that non-consciousness is both normal and a preferable mode of being.

Free from the exigencies of narrative form, in his poetry Hardy engages with his ideas and philosophy more directly. The fact that most of the poems were written after he had stopped writing novels, his first volume of poetry being published in 1898 and his final novel, *The Well-Beloved*, in 1897, suggests that many of his poems represent his mature thinking. However, this must be tempered by the knowledge that Hardy wrote poetry throughout the

time when he was writing and publishing his novels and so we cannot assume that the drafting or final versions of many of the earliest published poems in particular, post-date the novels. Indeed, many do not. The suggestion in his novels that vegetal ontology makes it a better or preferable mode of being is more prominent and directly addressed in his poetry. Furthermore, with no necessity for characterisation, his vegetal poetics reveal a much less anthropocentric worldview.

Hardy wrote over nine hundred poems that were published in eight volumes between 1898 and 1928 and his subjects range widely from war poems, relationships and lost loves, to poems about place, landscape and nature. Although he chose to publish some of his poetry in thematic groupings within the volumes, in his Apology in *Late Lyrics and Earlier with Many Other Verses* (1922) he claims that many juxtapositions are unintended, and in his Introductory Note in *Winter Words* (1928) states that ‘no harmonious philosophy is attempted in these pages – or in any bygone pages of mine, for that matter’ (CP 559; 834). As I have outlined in previous chapters, scholars have long recognised Hardy’s exploration of the disadvantages of consciousness in his poems but, with little scholarship on his vegetal poetics, few have investigated how Hardy juxtaposes the vegetal and human. However, through analysing his poems that foreground the world of vegetation, I establish that a cohesive vegetal poetics is evident.

I contend that in his vegetal poetics, Hardy writes against Wordsworthian conceptions of nature as a place of consolation and rejuvenation. I am not the first to read Hardy’s poetics in this way. As part of his argument about Hardy’s modernity, John Paul Riquelme suggests that Hardy’s ‘Nature’s Questioning’ ‘specifically rejects the consolation that Wordsworth’s speaker experiences’ in the ‘Immortality Ode’.⁹⁷ Addressing the same Hardy poem, Linda Shires asserts that the participants are ‘non-Wordsworthian’ and show that there is ‘no

⁹⁷ John Paul Riquelme, ‘The Modernity of Thomas Hardy’s Poetry’, in *The Cambridge Companion to Thomas Hardy*, ed. by Dale Kramer (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1999), pp.204-223 (p.208).

reason to link man and nature'.⁹⁸ I too argue that Hardy writes against Wordsworth's notion of nature as restorative, such as is to be found in poems such as 'Lines Written a Few Miles Above Tintern Abbey, on Revisiting the Banks of the Wye during a Tour, 13 July 1798' (hereafter 'Tintern Abbey'). In this poem, nature provides 'tranquil restoration' (l.31), encouraging his 'purest thoughts' (l.110) and informing 'The mind that is within us' (ll.126-7).⁹⁹ In contrast, for Hardy, nature is not a consolatory resource or a place of escape and renewal. The speaker of 'In a Wood', retreating into Nature, finds 'no grace [...] Taught me of trees', instead, to him, they are 'combatants all!' (CP 64-5, ll.33-34; l.20).

There are nearly fifty years between Wordsworth's final published poems and Hardy's first.

Jennifer Gribble suggests that Hardy's 'historical moment' is where 'the wisdom of Wordsworth's Nature confronts the impassive indifference of Darwin's'.¹⁰⁰

Wordsworth's poems in some ways respond to the visual picturesque that preceded them, whereas Hardy's poetics are influenced by the scientific, particularly evolutionary, developments of his own age and so the divergence between his and Wordsworth's vegetal poetics cannot be unexpected. That is not to say that Wordsworth's representation of nature negates or devalues its materiality. Wordsworth recognised the value of lifeforms other than the human and his representation of human responses to nature, although mediated through the imagination, are emotional and felt, and therefore also corporeal. My point is that Hardy's late nineteenth-century poems work to decentre humanity and in his framing of nature and other lifeforms, he attempts to minimise the voice of the intercepting mind; such that Keats critically terms Wordsworth's 'egotistical sublime'. However, for Hardy, a search for meaning persists in a world that lacks any consolatory transcendent significance and in which nature

⁹⁸ Linda Shires, 'Matter, Consciousness, and the Human in *Wessex Poems*', *Studies in English Literature*, 55(4) (2015), 899-924 (p.904).

⁹⁹ William Wordsworth, 'Lines Written a Few Miles above Tintern Abbey, on Revisiting the Banks of the Wye during a Tour, 13 July 1798', in *Romanticism, An Anthology*, ed. by Duncan Wu (Oxford, Blackwell Publishers Ltd, 1994), pp.240-244.

¹⁰⁰ Gribble, p.527.

is indifferent to humanity. Hardy finds this meaning in a material existence that spreads across all lifeforms, including the vegetal.

Scholars have diverged between reading Hardy's poetry as linked to the Victorian age, to the fin de siècle, or to an early modernism. This is hardly surprising when we consider the period over which Hardy was writing poetry which stretches from about the 1860s to the late 1920s. I argue that his poetry certainly possesses elements of a nascent post-humanism that looks forwards to modern perspectives. Riquelme recognises Hardy's non-anthropocentric poetics as developing towards modernism and locates this in his refusal to humanise nature through personification, the lack of human comfort in his elegies, and his use of ambiguity and multiple viewpoints.¹⁰¹ Likewise, in her article on Hardy's *Wessex Poems*, Linda Shires sees his use of images in association with the poems' text as 'witnessing a retreating humanness', one that is 'not hierarchically superior to the rest of the universe'.¹⁰² In her revised edition of *Victorian Poetry: Poetry, Poetics and Politics* (2019), Isabel Armstrong locates his poetry within an 'alternative fin de siècle', reading in it 'the ache of modernism' (making use of Hardy's own term from *Tess of the d'Urbervilles*). She sees this in his Darwinism and in his representation of a world where 'human agency is not at the centre'.¹⁰³ I extend these arguments by showing how by turning his perspective to the vegetal and stressing its inherent value, he moves our viewpoint away from the human and encourages us to read in a less anthropocentric mode. Jane Bennett suggests that it is a habit that we view matter as dull and passive (JB vii), and I suggest that reading Hardy's poetry challenges this manner of thinking and invites us to recognise the vibrancy of the vegetal. When, on the publication of *Moments of Vision and Miscellaneous Verses* (1917), he writes that 'I do not expect much notice will be taken of these poems: they mortify the human sense of self-importance by

¹⁰¹ Riquelme, p.206; p.208; p.217.

¹⁰² Shires, p.920.

¹⁰³ Isabel Armstrong, *Victorian Poetry: Poetry, Poetics and Politics*, 2nd edn. (London, Routledge, 2019), p.461.

showing, or suggesting, that human beings are of no matter or appreciable value in this nonchalant universe', I suggest that he recognises the challenge.¹⁰⁴

Hardy's poems can seem almost obsessed by time, particularly its physical and emotional effects upon humankind: he is the 'time-torn man' of his own poetic phrasing.¹⁰⁵ But in his vegetal poems he contrasts human and vegetal experiences of temporality. In 'A Backward Spring' Hardy recognises the vegetal's integral temporal relationship with alterity and he contrasts this to the problems caused by the non-contemporality of humanity. Through the human capacity for memory and imagination, we can become non-contemporaneous with the present and experience what Marder terms 'temporal dissociation' (MM 104). In contrast, the hetero-temporal vegetal has no separate interiority in which to disassociate from its environment. Hardy's vegetal poetics evoke the alienation caused to humans by such non-contemporality. In 'Freed the Fret of Thinking', he suggests that humans would be better off if they could be 'Measuring but the moment', as then 'Loosed from wrings of reason, | We might blow like flowers' and 'Sense of Time-wrought treason | Would not then be ours' (CP 753-4, l.12; ll.15-18). For Hardy, vegetal reliance upon the temporality of alterity is beneficial rather than restrictive.

In terms of form, I argue that Hardy structures some of his vegetal poems to allow vegetal vitality to dominate at the very centre of them. For Marder, the way that plants grow in two directions at once: upwards towards the light and downwards towards the darkness, means that the middle is the location of their vitality (MM 63). In 'In a Wood', it is at the centre of the poem that vegetal competition is at its most combative. In 'The Pine Planters', the seed is positioned where it can grow up and down through the poem. In 'At the Royal Academy', the sap is placed where it can rise up through the poem. In all three poems, this vegetal vitality,

¹⁰⁴ Hardy, *Life*, p.408-9 (entry dated 1917).

¹⁰⁵ The phrase 'time-torn man' is taken from Hardy's poem 'A Broken Appointment', published in *Poems of the Past and Present* (1901).

located as it is in the middle of the poem, reinforces the efficacy of vegetal agency, and drives human agency to the outer edges of the poems.

I: The Competitive World of 'In a Wood'

'In a Wood' was published in Hardy's first volume of poetry, *Wessex Poems and Other Verses* (1898) (CP 64-5). In this poem, Hardy presents an enervated speaker who has left his urban environment in a quest to find peace within the natural world of the wood. However, contrary to expectations, what he discovers is an intensely competitive environment with vegetal species battling for the available space and light. By the end of the poem the speaker returns with relief to his fellow humans.

Hardy dates this poem '1887:1896'. It seems that 1896 alludes to the year the poem was written. 1887 was the publication date of *The Woodlanders* and Hardy subtitles the poem: 'See "*The Woodlanders*".' There are certainly features in this poem that speak directly to *The Woodlanders*, not least the representation of woodland and competition between vegetal species. In this poem, Hardy undermines the assumption, such as Wordsworth presents in 'Tintern Abbey', that nature will carry out 'psychological work' for 'alienated urban man'.¹⁰⁶ Instead, Hardy emphasises the vitality of vegetal competition. The outsider character, like Fitzpiers in *The Woodlanders*, is again in conflict with the reality of the material world.

Hardy uses his speaker to illustrate the movement from an idealised imaginary Romantic view of the natural world to one of material and evolutionary reality. In the first stanza he expresses the speaker's bewilderment, asking why the trees 'mar sweet comradeship' by 'blighting' (ll.6-7) each other. In stanza two the reader comes to understand his misapprehension. 'City-opprest' (l.10), he has projected his own needs onto the wood,

¹⁰⁶ Jonathan Bate, *The Song of the Earth* (London, Picador, 2000), p.146.

assuming that the wood would be 'as to a nest', and 'Dreaming that sylvan peace | Offered the harrowed ease' (ll.12-14). The expectation of the urban speaker reflects the language of Wordsworth's 'Tintern Abbey', in which in 'lonely rooms, and mid the din | Of towns and cities' (ll.26-27), the speaker recalls nature and the 'sylvan Wye' (l.57) which provides him with 'tranquil restoration' (l.31).¹⁰⁷ Through using such similar language, Hardy suggests that the speaker has been influenced by a romanticised and anthropocentric view of nature's beneficence. However, unlike for Wordsworth's speaker, in stanzas three and four of Hardy's poem, the speaker's expectations are dashed by the material reality of vegetal competition. Through Hardy's representation of the moment of the speaker entering the wood, there is no distancing through memory. The reader experiences his shock at the contrast between his romanticised expectation and material actuality, reflective of a nineteenth-century adjustment to the devastating reality of an evolutionary understanding of the natural world.

In the very middle of the poem, Hardy's description of the trees' competition for space creates a claustrophobic and crowded atmosphere:

But, having entered in,
Great growths and small
Show them to men akin –
Combatants all!
Sycamore shoulders oak,
Bines the slim sapling yoke,
Ivy-spun halters choke
Elms stout and tall. (ll.17-24)

The speaker who hopes for 'comradeship' is faced, in the line at the very epicentre of the poem, with 'Combatants all!'. The destructive active verbs that describe the vegetal: 'shoulders', 'yoke' and 'choke', represent aggressive competition, and the syntax that reduces grammar to subject – verb - object: 'sycamore shoulders oak' and 'ivy-spun halters choke | elms', creates a forceful forward-moving rhythm. Bennett suggests that we tend to view the world as consisting of 'active human subjects who confront passive objects' (JB

¹⁰⁷ Wu, p.241.

xiv). In this poem Hardy counters this idea by locating the action in the vegetal. The centre of the poem is dominated by the vegetal's competitive vitality, such spatiality reflecting its assertive take-up of space in the wood. It also symbolically reflects the central position of materiality in new scientific understandings of life: humanity and an anthropocentric perspective has lost its central position and been pushed to the edges of the poem.

In the final stanza of the poem, the speaker returns to the human world with an altered perspective, although not the one for which he had hoped:

Since, then, no grace I find
Taught me of trees,
Turn I back to my kind,
Worthy as these.
There at least smiles abound,
There discourse trills around,
There, now and then, are found
Life-loyalties. (ll.33-40)

Rather than finding relief from 'men's unrest' in the wood (l.16), the speaker is brought to the realisation that human relationships are, in fact, less combative than those between vegetal species. Humans are now as 'worthy' as the trees. There 'at least smiles abound' and 'discourse trills around' with loyalties 'now and then'. In 'Tintern Abbey', Wordsworth's speaker discovers that his understanding of human weaknesses - the 'evil tongues', 'rash judgements', and the 'dreary intercourse of daily life' (ll.129-132) - are mollified by nature's teachings, as, through nature, he is brought to realise the 'little, nameless, unremembered acts | Of kindness and of love' (ll.35-36).¹⁰⁸ In Hardy's poem, however, rather than being restored by nature, the speaker finds that he prefers humans and human relationships. Unlike Wordsworth's speaker, he finds 'no grace [...] Taught me of trees'. He moves from a position in which the vegetal and human are 'akin', to one in which only humanity is now 'my kind'. He rejects the evolutionary position and returns to a safer world of human separation.

¹⁰⁸ Wu, p.241-243.

Yet the human relationships seem weak in comparison with those of the vegetal. Hardy uses energetic and vigorous verbs to describe the relationships between vegetal species. The vegetal species 'shoulder', 'yoke', 'choke', and 'sting', whereas the human relationships are diminished by modifiers: 'at least smiles abound', and the 'discourse' merely 'trills'. Even the 'life-loyalties' with which Hardy ends the poem are minimised: they are only to be found 'now and then'. Moreover, these human relationships are of the mind and dwarfed by the huge spatial relationships of the vegetal. Hardy suggests that material spatiality is more powerful than the mere mind. Furthermore, it is this mind that has produced the misguided Romantic ideals that are undermined in this poem. This is all structurally reinforced through the weak human relationships being pushed to the end of the poem by the dominant spatial vitality of the vegetal at its centre.

In describing the active and energetic vegetal, Hardy's speaker uses the language of intentionality, removing this from being located exclusively within humankind. The vegetal is made to seem intentionally malicious: the ash is described as a 'wych' and its 'Touches' will 'Sting you like scorn!' (ll.25-6). The language is also aggressive and warlike, vegetal species being 'combatants' and the 'rival' poplars line up in 'rank' (l.29-30). This could be read as anthropomorphic, but it is also reflective of both Marder's vegetal 'non-conscious intentionality' (MM 153) and Schopenhauer's 'blind irresistible urge' (*WWR1* 275) in which 'everywhere in nature we see contest, struggle, and the fluctuation of victory' (*WWR1* 146). In fact, Hardy's description of vegetal competition notably resembles that of Schopenhauer: 'on the banks of the Missouri one sometimes sees a mighty oak with its trunk and all its branches so entwined, fettered, and interlaced by a gigantic wild vine, that it must wither as if choked' (*WWR1* 147-8). Hardy even co-opts the rain into the vegetal's intentional competitive strategy. As it rains, he suggests that the trees are 'blighting' their competitors with 'poison-drip'; the 'poison' sounding deliberately malevolent. The positioning of these drops at the end of a line in the first stanza allows them to drip down through the poem, further destroying any notion of benevolent relationships. The length of this line also enables

these drops to destroy any potential for 'neighbourly spray' (ll.7-8) in the following shorter line. Rather than mutually supportive, Hardy's neighbourliness is indicative of rivalry.

Although the speaker seems to recognise vegetal intentionality, what he fails to recognise is that in comparing the relationships within the wood with those within humanity, he is not comparing like with like. The human relationships are intra-species; the vegetal relationships are inter-species with Hardy listing beech, pine, sycamore, elms, ash and poplars, ivy, and bine climbers. These cannot be expected to demonstrate even the weak intra-species connections that the speaker calls 'life-loyalties'. In *How Forests Think* (2013), Eduardo Kohn claims that the human mind works through creating generalities and categories.¹⁰⁹ I suggest that it is the anthropocentric categorisation embedded in the term 'wood' that leads the speaker astray. Such a term suggests a singular concept, and perhaps camouflages the many-species complexity that not only *is* the wood but that has created (and continues to create) the wood. It is the speaker who alliteratively joins 'pale beech' and 'pine-tree blue' in one line and characterises them as 'set in one clay'. Whereas the speaker sees the competitive processes as destructive, in an ecological sense the wood is successful because of the competition. As Schopenhauer asserts, it is only through competition that 'nature exist[s]' (*WWR1* 147) (see p.93). If the viewpoint is changed to one that views the wood as a whole rather than merely individual beings and their imperfections, or the 'Unfulfilled Intention' to use Hardy's language from *The Woodlanders* (and his subtitle surely encourages the reader to do so), the success of the biodiversity in this wood can be appreciated.

The speaker does, however, recognise that vegetal beings are processes rather than static things. He perceives what Karen Barad terms the process of 'worlding' (KB 179). Rather than simply recognising the snapshot of vegetal life as it is at that moment, the speaker

¹⁰⁹ Kohn, p.157.

perceives the processes that have created that moment. Hardy shows this altered perspective through using the present tense for describing vegetal competition ('shoulders', 'chokes'), suggesting that these are happening in the moment, whereas in reality, the speaker can only perceive the spatial consequence of these processes: the sycamore is now in the space that should be due to the oak. Hardy anticipates and poeticises Marder's notion of the vegetal as time itself, and its ability to embody the past in the present, suggesting that the speaker can read the vegetal's spatial language. In this sense, Hardy places the reader within vegetal temporality.

II: Existential Suffering in 'The Pine Planters (Marty South's Reverie)'

In 'The Pine Planters (Marty South's Reverie)' (hereafter 'Pine Planters'), published in *Time's Laughingstocks and Other Verses* (1909), Hardy again returns to *The Woodlanders* (CP 271-273). Marty South from *The Woodlanders* is the speaker and is therefore given a voice in which to express her feelings; a voice that she was rather denied in the novel. However, I argue that in this poem she projects her own feelings onto the vegetal, therefore denying its own voice. Although the poem therefore has an anthropocentric perspective, Hardy inserts elements of vegetal subjectivity and agency, problematising the speaker's attempt to impose upon it her own existentialist woes.

'Pine Planters' revisits the episode in *The Woodlanders* in which Marty South helps Giles Winterbourne plant trees. It is divided into two parts. The poem begins with a human focus: South ruminating upon her unreciprocated love for Winterbourne. The second part, still spoken by South, is ostensibly an elegy for the plight of one pine-tree that will suffer simply through being alive. The first part is in ballad form with eight quatrains and a predominantly regular rhythm and a regular abcb or abab rhyme scheme. However, although the second part largely maintains this rhythm and rhyme, the stanzas of twelve lines each are longer,

creating a denser and more sombre mood, reflective of the coniferous plantation that the tree represents. These longer stanzas also embody the height of the tree, and the varying line lengths visually resemble its silhouette, reflecting that the focus in this second part is on the tree. It is this second part of the poem that is most interesting from a vegetal perspective, and it is this part on which I concentrate.

In the first part of the poem, to indicate her love to Winterborne, South wonders 'Shall I not sigh to him' (l.25) but instead decides to 'bear it ever' (l.31). However, in part two, once the tree is planted, South projects onto it her repressed despair and hears *it* 'sighing' (l.41). In part one she feels like sighing but does not; in part two she appropriates the voice of the tree in which to articulate her sighing. She can perhaps be read as the archetypal nineteenth-century woman who must repress her feelings and voice; indeed, this is her position in *The Woodlanders*, and she can only release them in indirect ways. It is significant that she does this through the tree whose voice is also dismissed by a patriarchal culture.

South imposes her suffering onto a being that cannot itself suffer. For South, it is her imagination that causes her anguish as she thinks about Winterbourne's love for another. Marder suggests that the vegetal, with its 'freedom from the constraints of selfhood', has an 'ontological freedom'. With no separate interiority, it is 'unperturbed and indifferent', free from such concerns, and he reminds us that 'across the philosophical and literary traditions, the idealisation of the indifference of plants has been rampant' (MM 132-33). Indeed, in many poems, Hardy seems to rather envy plants this lack of consciousness and therefore suffering. In 'To a Tree in London' (1928), Hardy suggests that the tree is satisfied with its life in an urban landscape because it cannot imagine existence anywhere else: it is 'blind' (CP 867-868, l.22). South's 'subjective interiority' (MM 32) enables her to hide her feelings. She can decide to simply 'bear it' and 'make no sign' (ll.31-2), needing to displace her

feelings onto a being that cannot hide any such needs. Its own sighing can be only external and spatial.

South further extends the sorrow that she imposes onto the tree to a wider plight: an existentialist melancholy engendered through merely being alive. The tree suffers the 'fear | Of Life unreckoned' (ll.38-39). This reflects her comment in *The Woodlanders* that 'it seems to me [...] as if they sigh because they are very sorry to begin life in earnest – just as we be' (W 59). In the poem she expands this to all time as the tree will:

[...] sigh in the morning,
Will sigh at noon,
At the winter's warning,
In wafts of June; (ll.45-48)

For South, the tree voices *all* existentialist sorrow. However, if we read this from the perspective of the vegetal, as Michael Pollan asks us to do in *The Botany of Desire* (2001), we can recognise the pine-tree as gaining rather than suffering from its planting.¹¹⁰ Pollan views plants as active subjects that have (in a non-conscious and evolutionary sense) used humanity to create their own success. Through this lens, pine trees spread and colonise areas through what we might otherwise view as merely human economic gain from their use of timber. Through being useful to humankind, pine trees increase their chances of success.

South's anthropocentric perspective also fails to recognise the different ontology of the vegetal. Although South has a knowledgeable and non-objective relationship to the trees in *The Woodlanders*, in this poem her interiority overrides this. However, Hardy overcomes this by inserting the vegetal's own agency and subjectivity into this poem even though it is ostensibly 'Marty South's reverie'. He calls attention to the double beginning of the life of the tree. Although the human planters have set the tree in place, they are merely transplanting

¹¹⁰ Michael Pollan, *The Botany of Desire* (London, Bloomsbury, 2001).

what is already a sapling as they 'take each tree' (l.34). It is an anthropocentric notion to imagine that they are 'Beginning' (l.40) the life of the tree when they merely transplant the saplings. They cannot create vegetal life. Hardy reminds us of the real beginning of the life of the tree through his reference to the pine-tree 'seed'. This he embeds in the very centre of part two of this poem, positioning the seed where it can grow bi-directionally upwards and downwards through the poem. Read through Marder, this middle position also shows vegetal being as denying the importance of the human planting, positioned at the top of part two of the poem. As such, it also symbolises South's erroneous assumption that the tree can suffer existentialist woe, located in the mind at the top of the human body. It is only South who needs to 'shun the welter | Of things without' (ll.53-4). The tree can remain 'unknowing | For whom or what' (ll.57-8) it is there.

Read through the perspective of vegetal ontology, South's assumption that the tree is disadvantaged by its positioning is also an anthropocentric point of view. Being a sessile organism, once the human planters have decided upon its position, South sees the tree as condemned to 'this bleak spot' as it is 'Unable to leave here' (l.60-63). This is emphasised in this second part of the poem: through the repeated use of the word 'here', especially when rhymed with 'fear', South suggests how difficult it must be to remain in one place. It is instructive to return to the episode in *The Woodlanders* to which this poem alludes in which South herself is portrayed as sessile. As she stands still to support the trees while Winterbourne plants, her pose is tree-like with 'her outstretched hand [...] chill as a stone' (W, 59). To recover, she must be mobile: 'Mr Winterbourne, can I run down the lane and back to warm my feet?' (W 59). But this reflects an animal's need for movement, so however much her sessility equates her to the tree and allows her licence to transfer her feelings, she neglects to recognise the tree's ontological embrace of sessility. Furthermore, conifers are adapted to such 'bleak' conditions. It is only South whose positioning, in her closeness to Winterborne, is the cause of woe.

Hardy suggests a further reason why the trees might be more successful than humanity when he compares their lifespan to that of South and Winterbourne. At the end of the poem, South mourns that the pine-tree will be unable to:

[...] tell the story
Of us today
When, halt and hoary,
We pass away. (ll.65-68)

South's mourning is less that she and Winterborne will pass away, but that the tree will not pass on their story into the future. Through ending the poem with the loss of their story, Hardy implies its relative unimportance. The tree will outlive them, and their story will be forgotten. South's appropriation of the voice of the tree to tell her story is, in the end, denied.

III: The Meaning of Life in 'Yell'ham-Wood's Story'

In 'Yell'ham-Wood's Story' (hereafter 'Yell'ham-Wood's'), published in Hardy's third volume of poetry, *Time's Laughingstocks and Other Verse* (1909), Hardy questions the very meaning of Life (I follow Hardy's own capitalisation of 'Life' here) (CP 298-9). In fact, Dennis Taylor contends that one of the 'great Hardy-esque questions which he helps make so central to the later Victorian period' is 'what is the meaning of human life in a universe which has lost its moorings?'.¹¹¹ Although he is specifically writing about 'Neutral Tones' which was published in *Wessex Poems* (1898), I would argue that this question continues to be relevant to Hardy's later poetry and certainly to 'Yell'ham Wood's'. It is the vegetal that answers this question and the reply is that there is meaning in simply being alive. In 'Pine Planters', a human speaker imposes a voice on the vegetal and expects the trees to tell her story, whereas in 'Yell'ham-Wood's' it is the vegetal's own voice that speaks and, through its own story, offers this lesson to humanity.

¹¹¹ Dennis Taylor, 'Hardy as a nineteenth-century poet', in *The Cambridge Companion to Thomas Hardy*, ed. by Dale Kramer (Cambridge, Cambridge University Press, 1999), pp.183-203 (p.190).

The poem begins with two different woods explaining what 'Life' is. In the first line, in which 'Coomb-Firtrees say that Life is a moan', Hardy establishes a jaunty rhythm, and this, along with the single syllable words, makes this beginning seem story-like, reflecting the poem's title. The affirming 'And Clyffe-hill Clump says "Yea!"' of the following line reinforces such a tone. However, the third line beginning with 'But' indicates that 'Yell'ham' will undercut this, and here the tone becomes more sombre. Hardy goes on to withhold Yell'ham's own pronouncement for the following six lines, using this space to reveal only what it does not assert. It does not confirm that Life is "'Gray, gray' (l.4), as Coomb-Firtrees has claimed, and the reader might therefore expect a more optimistic explanation of Life after the tension of waiting for the response.

It is not until after the stanza break that Hardy reveals Yell'ham's answer and the whole of stanza two is devoted to this, suggesting that it is of greater importance and complexity than the responses of the other two woods:

It says that Life would signify
A thwarted purposing:
That we come to live, and are called to die
Yes, that's the thing
In fall, in spring,
That Yell'ham says:-
"Life offers – to deny!" (ll.8-14)

Yell'ham says that Life is a 'thwarted purposing'. Hardy goes on to rework this complex phrase twice. The first rephrasing clarifies that it means 'That we come to live, and are called to die', affirmed by the satisfied 'Yes, that's the thing'. The second clarification is that "'Life offers – to deny!'". This bitterness of this short explanation, ending in 'deny', is reinforced through this being the final line of the poem. The potential optimism of 'Life offers' is cut off by the dash and the final 'deny!' is crushing.

This 'thwarted purposing' bears some resemblance to the 'Unfulfilled Intention' of *The Woodlanders*. In his 'A Philosophical Fantasy' (1928) (a poem I also considered in the previous chapter) Hardy explicitly links his 'Unfulfilled Intention' to the idea of 'thwarting' (CP 893-7). The speaker asks the God-like first cause about 'this *unfulfilled intention*' (l.18, emphasis in original). He asks 'why [...] let your aim be thwarted, | Its glory be diminished, | Its concept stand unfinished?' (ll.22-25), to which the first cause responds that he fails to see it as 'unfulfilled intention' (l.126) as had been 'unconscious in my doings' (l.128). He claims that his creation was of '*purposeless propension*' and 'not intention' (ll.142-143, emphasis in original). Such a clarification removes purpose from life, and even from 'intention'.

Reading this notion in 'A Philosophical Fantasy' through Schopenhauer is helpful, particularly as Hardy's '*purposeless propension*' seems reflective of Schopenhauer as does his reference to the first cause as "'blind force persisting'" (l.52). In this poem Hardy seems to gesture at a teleological understanding of life, albeit one that is 'thwarted', and yet he also seems to refute it, and in some ways, this is similar to Schopenhauer's own ambiguous teleology. Schopenhauer asserts that 'every individual act has a purpose or end' and yet that 'willing as a whole has no end in view'. The will has an 'absence of all aim, of all limit'; it just exhibits an 'endless striving' which 'can always be impeded only, never fulfilled or satisfied' (WWR1 164). Although the will moves towards ends, it does not foresee those ends.

In returning to 'Yell'ham Wood's' through such Schopenhauerian notions, Hardy's 'thwarted', as well as his clarifications that one lives then dies, reflects Schopenhauer's notion that although each individual manifestation of the will might have an end or purpose, this can only be transitory. Hardy's statement at the end of stanza one, that Yell'ham says 'Nor that Life is for ends unknown' (l.7), reflects the ambiguity of Hardy's own teleology in this poem. The double negative deliberately obscures any definite meaning. Is Yell'ham saying that there are ends even though they are unknown or that there are no ends? It seems that

twenty-two years after the ambiguity of the 'Unfulfilled Intention' of *The Woodlanders*, Hardy seems no closer to resolving this.

Reading Hardy's 'thwarted purposing' through Bennett's vital materiality offers an alternative interpretation. Bennett argues that her conception of matter denies any purposive dimension or notion of a blind mechanism as it embraces the unexpected: it envisages 'paths that could not have been foreseen, for they are governed by an emergent rather than a linear or deterministic causality' (JB 112). Using this as a lens suggests that his 'thwarted purposing' reflects an unexpectedness or randomness in nature, in which 'ends' must indeed be 'unknown'. This would justify a lack of teleology or purpose. I suggest that Hardy's ambiguity in this poem permits both Schopenhauerian and Bennettian interpretations. It also allows us to see the bifurcation between a deterministic Schopenhauerian and an emergent New Materialist conception of nature.

It is the transience in nature that Hardy uses to imply that life is 'thwarted' or that 'we come to live, and are called to die'. Yell'ham Wood is deciduous and can therefore show seasonal cycles of renewal and decay 'In fall, in spring'. In fact, its full name, 'Yellowham Wood' (and Hardy is using real woods in this poem), reflects the appearance of senescent leaves in autumn. In contrast, 'Coomb-Firtrees' and 'Clyffe-hill Clump' are coniferous. Their assertion that Life is 'a moan' (invoking their continuous sound) or 'gray', suggests that the non-transience of the coniferous is deadening, perhaps reminding the reader of Hardy's earlier poem, 'Neutral Tones' in which 'gray' is suggestive of the lack of any renewal (CP 12). Through using the cycles of renewal and senescence that are expressed in Yell'ham's seasonality, Hardy suggests that transience demonstrates vitality.

The symbolic use of seasonality in vegetation to express transience is common. As Marder notes, 'various discussions of the philosophical problem of time have elevated the plant and its "life-cycle" to the status of exemplarity' (MM 94). Using 'Yell'ham Wood's' as an example,

Adrian Tait comments on how leaf fall provides Hardy with 'the perfect metaphor for life's transience' but that there is also a 'counterbalancing recognition that trees themselves do not die with each leaf fall. Rather, that leaf fall becomes part of a larger cycle of renewal'.¹¹² Indeed, the seasonal transience of the vegetal cannot strictly be compared to human life and death. It reflects a different ontology and, in fact, deconstructs a life/death dualism (MM 11). Unlike animals which are individually either dead or alive, for the vegetal, a 'continual death of used organs has replaced death of the plant itself'.¹¹³ They are changes, not deaths. Using this to reflect human transience must therefore be a flawed analogy that is, as of all analogies, filtered through human interpretation.

However, my reading of 'Yell'ham Wood's' suggests that Hardy is doing something more than merely using the vegetal as an analogy for transience. That he not only extends vegetal transience to Life's meaning – that meaning is to be found in the acceptance of transience – but that being alive is itself meaning. I propose that in the rather intrusive three-syllable 'signify' ('It says that life would signify' (l.8)), Hardy gestures towards Macbeth's soliloquy on Life's meaning. Upon hearing of the death of his wife, Macbeth bitterly comments that 'Life's but a walking shadow' that tells 'a tale' that is 'signifying nothing'.¹¹⁴ In contrast, Hardy's vegetal messenger, instead of asserting that life signifies nothing, suggests that life *is* meaning. Hardy's following this with 'we come to live, and are called to die' becomes a positive rather than negative message. As Hardy affirms, 'Yes, that's the thing'. Merely being alive is what counts. For Barad, 'matter and meaning are mutually articulated' and this is Hardy's point (KB 152). That as 'we are a part of that nature that we seek to understand', in being alive, like the plants, we too have meaning (KB 26).

¹¹² Adrian Tait, 'Seeking Signs Amongst 'Sylvan Phenomena': Trees in the Work of Thomas Hardy', *Green Letters: Studies in Ecocriticism*, 25(4) (2021), 377-389 (p.385).

¹¹³ Hallé, p.122.

¹¹⁴ William Shakespeare, *Macbeth*, Act 5, Scene 5.

IV: Hetero-temporality in 'A Backward Spring'

Hardy's 'A Backward Spring' (hereafter 'Backward Spring') was published in the collection *Moments of Vision and Miscellaneous Verses* (1917) (CP 498). In this poem Hardy considers the hetero-temporality of plants, inextricably connected as they are to external temporality. However, rather than using its temporal dependency as an analogy for human temporality and meaning as he does in 'Yell'ham Wood's', in 'Backward Spring' Hardy expresses a sympathy with the vegetal's lack of self-determination in its reliance upon externality. But he also recognises that the vegetal's lack of a conscious memory is an advantage and therefore suggests that hetero-temporality might also be of benefit.

In 'Backward Spring', Hardy considers the responses of various plant species to a late Spring. In the first stanza, the vegetal is fearful of the inclement weather: the trees are 'afraid'; the grass shows 'timidity'; the barberry is 'fret' (ll.1-5). But however much they might delay their spring growth, Hardy does not suggest that they will not grow at all. Though the barberry is 'fret', it is merely 'waiting to bloom'. He makes this clear in the following stanza where the snowdrop 'betrays no gloom' and 'the primrose pants in its heedless push' (ll.7-8). All plants must grow to survive.

Hardy only mentions each of these species once. However, he devotes at least five lines in this poem to the myrtle. Its struggle to cope with this tardy Spring is perhaps reflective of its Mediterranean heritage, in contrast to the better adapted snowdrop and primrose:

Though the myrtle asks if it's worth the fight
This year with frost and rime
To venture one more time
On delicate leaves and buttons of white
From the selfsame bough as at last year's prime, (ll.9-13)

The myrtle's response to this late Spring is one of weighing up options, veering between hesitancy and bravery. After asking if 'it's worth the fight', the following couplet presents two

options: hesitancy or fortitude. Hardy suggests its fragility in its 'delicate leaves and buttons of white', reinforced through the skipping rhythm of this line after the slow hesitancy of the decision-making couplet. This is then contrasted in the following line where exhaustion is evoked in the triple stresses of 'selfsame bough' and 'last year's prime' expressing a heavy weariness. If we view the poem as gesturing towards the form of the Shakespearian sonnet with its three quatrains followed by a couplet (apt for the myrtle as symbol of love), the extending of this third near-quatrain to five lines, with no punctuation, extends and exhausts the sonnet structure, drawing attention to the myrtle's tiredness and continuing battle. It seems an almost insurmountable hurdle to add further growth onto the already extended 'selfsame' branch from 'last year's prime'. The length of the bough is reflected in this line being visually the longest of the poem, visually illustrating Marder's conceptualisation of linear plant growth as the 'temporalisation of space and spatialization of time' (MM 96).

This long line represents linear growth, but the myrtle's response to the Spring is also cyclical – it must generate this year's leaves and flowers. For Marder, vegetal temporality is 'both linear, insofar as it tends to infinity, and cyclical [...] as occurring in the midst of, and permeated by, the changing of the seasons' (MM 112-113). In 'Backward Spring', Hardy evokes the complex trade-off between continuous growth and cyclical seasonal renewal. The myrtle must risk growing in the inclement conditions due to its necessity for spatial increase. But it must also respond to this year's specific conditions – the late Spring, enduring the 'frost and rime' to 'venture one more time'.

Reading this as a sonnet, the extended third quatrain causes a delay to the volta, creating tension and expectation. The volta responds to this with a sudden change in tone, suggesting that this poem is not simply about plant responses to the late Spring. But the final rhyming couplet is problematic in terms of its ambiguity:

And never to ruminate on or remember
 What happened to it in mid-December. (ll.14-15)

The prominent 'never' early in the first line creates an ominous tone, as does the drawn out 'ruminates' and the falling metre of 'remember', making this first line of the couplet the longest line in the poem. In terms of meaning, as Hardy has evoked both cyclical and linear time in this poem, the reader is unsure whether what 'happened to it in mid-December' is a regular cyclical occurrence or a specific event. If it is read as representative of cyclicity, obviously mid-December's short days are difficult for plants and would be particularly so for the Mediterranean myrtle. But perhaps Hardy is indicating in this portentous volta that something more specific occurred last December?

There is a further level of ambiguity in that the syntax makes it unclear as to whether the couplet is about the myrtle or about humanity. If it is continuing the myrtle's question begun five lines earlier: 'the myrtle asks', the lack of a question mark at the end is problematic. But this would invite a reading in which these bitter final lines become a statement and one that is reflective of a human sensibility. The 'ruminates' and 'remember' are also suggestive of human consciousness; even if plant research suggests that plants have some form of memory, it is unlikely that they 'ruminates'!

I propose that this volta should be read as a comment on humanity and one that reflects Marder's notion of human 'temporal dissociation' (MM 104): that through the imagination, humans can exist outside of the present time. Hardy's 'ruminates' suggests that this causes discomfort through awakening sombre memories that impinge on the present. This is also implied in the poem's title: as well as the tardiness of a late Spring, it may indicate a springing backwards in time with 'spring' used as a verb rather than a noun. Such a reading reinforces my argument that aspects of Hardy's poetry show him writing against a Wordsworthian veneration of the recalling of experiences in the imagination. For Hardy, such

'temporal dissociation' causes suffering rather than 'tranquil restoration' (l.31), to once again quote 'Tintern Abbey'.¹¹⁵

Through reading this volta as relating to humanity, a further reading is possible. Hardy dates this poem 'April 1917'. Although *Moments of Vision* contains a section entitled 'Poems of War and Patriotism' in which this poem is not included, a work of poetry published in 1917 and specifically dated to 1917 cannot but be tinged with war themes. In fact, Armstrong claims that 'Hardy was a war poet from the beginning'.¹¹⁶ Furthermore, April 1917 may not even merely be a general reference to World War One but more specific. The previous 'mid-December' (precisely 15th December 1916) is the date of the beginning of the final offensive of the Battle of Verdun, one of the costliest battles in terms of human life of the whole War. This would certainly be a cause for rumination.

Whether this poem is read as a comment on humanity or merely about the vegetal, Hardy does recognise the vegetal's hetero-temporality and its corollary lack of Marder's 'temporal dissociation'. The vegetal can only grow and regenerate in relation to the temporality of alterity. If it is read as a comment on humanity or the war, there is a sense in which Hardy views the vegetal's regenerative ability, without the encumbrance of consciousness or memory, as an asset. Its existence only in the present, rather than a hindrance, is advantageous.

V: Static Representations of Reality in 'At the Royal Academy'

'At the Royal Academy' (hereafter 'Academy') was published in *Late Lyrics and Earlier with Many Other Verses* (1922) and concerns landscape paintings of summer vegetation (CP 627-8). It is another poem in which Hardy addresses the problematic human relationship to

¹¹⁵ Wu, p.241.

¹¹⁶ Armstrong, p.460.

transience and death. I read this poem as an extension of the point he makes in 'Yell'ham Wood's': that humankind struggles to understand the meaning of transience and, to avoid this reality, we create false images of permanence. In fact, the poems printed immediately before and after 'Academy' in *Late Lyrics*, 'The Children and Sir Nameless' and 'Her Temple', also concern failed attempts to defeat death through the construction of permanent memorials (CP 627; 628). In 'The Children and Sir Nameless, in years to come children ask "Who was this old stone man beneath our toes?" (l.24), while in 'Her Temple', 'None now knows' the name of the man who built it (l.8). In 'Academy' then, Hardy contrasts the vitality of reality with such deadening representations. Like in 'In a Wood' and 'Pine Planters', he shows that mediated through human consciousness, the vegetal becomes static and therefore unreal. He forces the reader to reject such illusory permanence and recognise that life and vitality is to be found in the transient.

Structurally, the poem consists of five tercets with rhyming triplets and an iambic pentameter rhythm. Such conventional regularity reflects the formality of the Royal Academy's landscape paintings. But Hardy creates a tension between this regularity and an alternative mode, embedded in his vocabulary, of temporal fluctuations ('season', 'last noonday', 'yester's', 'last year', 'May to Michaelmas term') which enact change, demonstrating a clash between the representational and actual plant vitality. The first four tercets of the poem concern the paintings and although Hardy leads the reader on to assume that they contain fresh greenery, they do not. He delays this revelation until the end of the fourth tercet and 'real' transient vegetation is only present in the final stanza.

In the first three stanzas, the use of a single sentence evokes the fullness of herbage at its summer peak:

These summer landscapes – clump, and copse, and croft –
Woodland and meadowland – here hung aloft,

Gay with limp grass and leafery new and soft,

Seem caught from the immediate season's yield
I saw last noonday shining over the field,
By rapid snatch, while still are uncongealed

The saps that in their live originals climb;
Yester's quick greenage here set forth in mime
Just as it stands, now, at our breathing-time. (ll.1-9)

The abundance in the paintings is intensified by the listing of different vegetal landscapes and freshness is evoked in the 'leafery new and soft'. But already there are signs that all is not as it appears, such an impression initiated by the tentative 'seem' at the beginning of the second stanza. The ensuing 'caught', implying entrapment, adds to feelings of unease, and the aggressive 'rapid snatch' two lines hence, although potentially depicting the spontaneity of painting, also gestures towards something being stolen.

Indications of the unreality of the paintings continue. The enjambment at the end of the second stanza leaves the meaning of 'uncongealed' hanging. It can be read as indicating that the oils of the painting are still fresh and yet will congeal and become immobile. But in the following stanza, Hardy reveals that the 'uncongealed' relates to the vegetal 'saps'. As part of the 'live originals' that will 'climb', rather than congeal, these will continue to flow. The word 'climb' being positioned at the end of the line, while also adding an extra syllable to the iambic pentameter, gives the 'saps' the potential to rise through the poem, suggesting that such vegetal movement cannot be contained within the paintings' static regularity. Like the vitality of the vegetal in the middle of 'In a Wood' and the seed in the middle of the tree section of 'Pine Planters', Hardy inserts vegetal vitality into the middle of this poem.

Moreover, once the oil paint congeals the paintings will become permanent while the saps will be renewed every year. The paintings will become immobile while the vegetal retains its vigour.

Although stanza four begins with 'but', it then seems to continue with the pretence that the vegetation described is vital and fresh, with the 'young foils so fresh upon each tree' (l.10), whereas this is, in fact, still about the vegetal within the paintings. It is not until the final line of this stanza that Hardy abruptly puts an end to such misconceptions in the short clause 'Are not this summer's,' (l.12). The reader realises they have been somewhat hoodwinked. As the line continues, Hardy makes this clear: the vitality represented has been false: 'they feign to be' (l.12). In the paintings, the vitality of the vegetal is stilled and the representation static.

These landscape paintings alter our understanding of what is, in reality, a process of constant change. Barad claims that '*discursive practices are causal intra-actions*' that participate in reconfiguring the world. She asserts that 'in its causal intra-activity, part of the world becomes determinately bounded and propertied in its emergent intelligibility to another part of the world' (KB 149, emphasis in original). Although she is discussing discourse here, I argue that this could equally apply to visual representations. They too have impact on how we view the world, and in the case of 'Academy', Hardy addresses the consequence of such a misconception. In *The Old Ways* (2012), Robert MacFarlane writes of how 'landscape' as a concept is 'often understood as a noun connoting fixity, scenery, an immobile painterly decorum'.¹¹⁷ I suggest that, likewise, vegetation is also often perceived as fixed rather than dynamic. In fact, this is partially what causes the misunderstanding of the speaker of 'In a Wood'. Although in 'Academy' Hardy uses poetic structure to mislead his reader, in doing so he shocks them into feeling animosity at the falsity of the paintings and an understanding as to how such paintings reconfigure our mental image of the world.

By the time the reader gets to the final stanza of 'Academy', they are prepared for the reality of transience, but it is a harsh reality that Hardy presents:

¹¹⁷ Robert MacFarlane, *The Old Ways*, (London, Penguin, 2012), p.255.

Last year their May to Michaelmas term was run,
Last autumn browned and buried every one,
And no more know they sight of any sun. (ll.13-15)

This sobering stanza is the only one in the poem that fully focuses on real vegetation but, ironically, in contrast to the imitative summer vegetal of the paintings, it is dead. The leaves are now 'browned and buried' and their lack of chlorophyll means that they can no longer convert sunlight into materiality. This, as well as their positioning at the base of the poem, means that they 'no more know the sight of any sun'. Hardy implies that their deaths bear relation to that of humans: the leaves are 'buried', human notions of individuality are implied in 'every one', and the single syllable words of the final line slow down the rhythm and create a mournful tone, Hardy reminds us that life for all living beings must end in death.

Yet vegetal transience is not comparable to that of humanity. In my exploration of 'Yell'ham Wood's', I pointed out how this is due to the vegetal's ability to constantly renew itself. In 'Academy' the difference is that the decomposing leaves can materially contribute to new growth. The sunlight that is buried at the bottom of the poem, embedded in their materiality, will become part of a 'material "resurrection"' (MM 67). The paintings that are 'hung aloft' at the top of the poem cannot suppress the vitality of the real vegetation, even when it is symbolically located at the base of the poem, within, and part of, the darkness of the soil. Furthermore, each vegetal regeneration is new. Drawing upon the ideas of Derrida, Marder makes the point that each reiteration is a singular event 'with 'inexorable alterations' (Marder 116). The leaves in the paintings might 'Seem caught from the immediate season's yield' but Hardy makes it clear that they 'are not this summer's'. Each leaf that grows is the first iteration of that leaf. However, this year's leaves might incorporate the regenerated materiality of the leaves that are represented in the paintings.

VI: The Problematic Possession of Consciousness in 'Before Life and After' and 'The Aerolite'

To conclude this chapter, I want to examine two poems in which Hardy explicitly problematises human consciousness: 'Before Life and After' (hereafter 'Before Life'), published in *Time's Laughingstocks and Other Verses* (1909), and 'The Aerolite' (hereafter 'Aerolite'), published in *Human Shows, Far Phantasies, Songs and Trifles* (1925) (CP 277; 769-70). Although in these two poems Hardy does not compare or contrast vegetal and human, his recurring use of the vegetal in his poetry to highlight the advantage of a lack of consciousness makes these poems of interest to this study. In both poems, Hardy considers the development of human consciousness, the problems it causes, and concludes that a return to a state of 'nescience' or 'normal unawareness' would be beneficial.

'Before Life' consists of four quatrains, the first three of which are about life on Earth 'Before the birth of consciousness' (l.3). These stanzas evoke a rather paradisaical life. In stanza two, Hardy establishes a world that is free from suffering and pain. Using the anaphoric 'none': 'None suffered', 'None knew', 'None cared', Hardy lists the feelings from which no one suffers distress, including 'love', 'loss', 'regret', 'starved hope', and 'heart-burnings' (ll.5-7).

It is not that nothing harmful occurs, but that there is no conscious awareness of these harms and therefore no emotional response to them. It is not that there was no 'sickness' or 'crash or cross' or that 'something winced and waned' but that without feelings 'none suffered', 'no heart was wrung', 'no sense was stung' (ll.4-11). Even mortality brings no pain: 'if something ceased, no tongue bewailed' (l.9). In the lack of 'regret' and 'starved hope' Hardy also suggests that humanity's ability to divorce itself from the present, its 'temporal dissociation' that I discussed in relation to 'Backward Spring', is also a cause of distress.

With the first three-quarters of the poem set in a world that lacks consciousness, Hardy normalises nonconsciousness. But the anaphora and listing create a tension or expectation which is resolved in the final stanza where Hardy presents the world as it is. It is here where he specifically pinpoints 'feeling' as the problem:

But the disease of feeling germed,
And primal rightness took the tinct of wrong;
Ere nescience shall be reaffirmed
How long, how long? (ll.13-16)

Rather than thought as a 'disease of flesh' (RN 120) as Hardy suggests in *The Return of the Native*, now it is feelings that are the 'disease'. This is a theme that Hardy repeatedly addresses in his tragic novels and that I explored in relation to *The Return of the Native*, but here he explicitly explores the destructive nature of the emotions.

In this final stanza, Hardy expresses a yearning for a return to what he frames as normality: 'nescience'. In this respect, he seems to concur with Schopenhauer that 'unconsciousness is the original and natural condition of all things' (WWR2 142). Schopenhauer suggests that before the evolutionary development of animals, the world was a place of a 'long and profound peace' until the development of animals put an end to 'that plant paradise'.¹¹⁸ Perhaps it is this 'plant paradise' that the speaker of 'In a Wood' hoped he might encounter. But there is a mixture of optimism and pessimism in Hardy's expectation that 'nescience shall be reaffirmed'. The use of the auxiliary verb 'shall' implies that this will happen but the yearning tone of the following and final 'How long, how long?' with its repeated question, creates a sense of desperation and, of course, returning to 'nescience' is impossible.

Sixteen years after the publication of 'Before Life and After', Hardy returns to this theme in 'The Aerolite'. This poem is framed as a thought experiment, stanza one beginning with 'I thought' and a parenthetical '(Or so I dreamed)' at the end. This lack of realism allows Hardy

¹¹⁸ Arthur Schopenhauer, 'On Philosophy and Natural Science', in *Parerga and Paralipomena: Short Philosophical Essays. Vol 2*, trans. by E.F.J Payne (Oxford, Clarendon Press, 1974), p.143.

to develop an even more fantastical proposition than in 'Before Life': that 'Consciousness' arrived on Earth via an 'aerolite' (a meteorite) from 'some far globe'.

Although there are many similarities between these two poems, in 'Aerolite' Hardy emphasises a slightly different aspect of the effect of the emotions, as well as expanding his problematisation of consciousness to other aspects of the mind. He suggests that it is not the emotions per se that are the problem, but that they reveal the difficult conditions of life on Earth. On the 'far globe', consciousness and the emotions existed, it is just that the conditions there were ideal and so there was 'no distress' (l.4). As a result, 'the power to feel' was 'a gift uncloyed' (l.7) and the only 'emotions' felt are those of being 'loved, desired, enjoyed' (l.10).

However, when consciousness arrives on Earth, where there are 'stains and stings' (l.18), consciousness 'showed to us the worm | That gnaws vitalities native here' (ll.14-15), and the 'mortal moan | Begot of sentience' (ll.33-34) commences. Hardy returns here to the imperfect nature of life on Earth, as he has done in *The Woodlanders*, where Grace wondered 'if there were one world in the universe where the fruit had no worm, and marriage no sorrow' (W 184). Perhaps this world could only be on the 'far globe' that Hardy imagines here. The other development that Hardy makes in this second poem is that he problematises other aspects of the mind. Although he begins the poem by stating that it is 'consciousness' that arrives on the aerolite, he later includes other elements of the mind. In referring to the world's previous 'ignorance' (l.17) and lack of the 'opined', as well as to things that 'tax intelligence' (ll.19-20), he also seems to include reason as detrimental to humanity. It maybe that he is using such concepts connected with the mind quite loosely here, allying these with consciousness, but he has specifically criticised these other aspects of the mind in *The Return of the Native* and in others of his novels, so he maybe deliberately widening his criticism of the human mind here.

In both of these unrealistic poems Hardy tries to grapple with the problem of consciousness. Although he self-proclaims that he was 'as a young man [...] among the earliest acclaimers of *The Origin of Species*', in these poems there is a sense of difficulty in accepting that consciousness has developed through evolutionary processes.¹¹⁹ In the 'earth's testimonies tell' (l.2) of 'Before Life', Hardy refers to the deep time of epochs on earth before humanity, or perhaps before any life. In writing that consciousness or 'the disease of feeling germed', he seems to indicate its subsequent evolutionary development. But in these poems, he also indicates that this is a difficult development to acknowledge. Of course, this could be attributed to his proximity, at least earlier in his life, to the radical and disturbing impact of evolutionary theory. But as Michael Pollan points out, even when one's views are consistent with an evolutionary viewpoint, a materialistic acceptance often breaks down when considering human consciousness.¹²⁰ Although consciousness is not an exception and there is no evidence of any break in the evolutionary chain, Hardy suggests that in the development of consciousness, life has extended itself too far. In the introduction I referred to his comment in the *Life* that 'the human race is too extremely developed for its corporeal conditions' and that 'this planet does not supply the materials for happiness to higher existences'.¹²¹ This seems to me an apt summary of his thinking in these two poems and indicates why he feels the need to create an alternative, perhaps consolatory, explanation for consciousness: that it might be an aberration and 'unawareness' ('Aerolite', l.35) normality. The sudden and fantastic nature of the arrival of the 'untoward gift' (l.27) of consciousness in 'Aerolite' enables an avoidance of perceiving it as a natural evolutionary development and instead its origin becomes an unaccountable mystery.

¹¹⁹ Hardy, *Life*, p.158 (entry dated 1882).

¹²⁰ Pollan, p.165.

¹²¹ Hardy, *Life*, p.227 (entry dated 7th April 1889).

Another explanation for consciousness is of course a religious or teleological one and Hardy gestures towards this in both these poems. In 'Before Life' the 'primal rightness' that 'took the tinct of wrong' (l.14) implies the disruptive impact of knowledge in the Genesis story, as does the 'unblind | Earth's old-established ignorance' of 'Aerolite' (ll.16-17) which the 'seer' wishes to 'oust' (ll.21-22). The 'worm | That gnaws vitalities native here' (ll.14-15), recalls the serpent that tempts Eve to eat of the Tree of Knowledge, removing humanity's ignorance and blindness. If we read these poems from this perspective, Hardy suggests that our awakening to the nature of humanity is also destructive to humanity's equanimity. Although having lost his own faith, Hardy cannot find any consolation in a religious perspective, the fact that in 'Aerolite' consciousness has been sent 'For ends unknown' (l.28) suggests that although humanity may not know their end, there is at least a teleological destination. Hardy returns us here to the exact same phrase that he had used in 'Yell'ham Wood's' but where any notion of a teleological end was more ambiguous. The final line of 'Aerolite': 'Normal unawareness waits rebirth' (l.35) does suggest some form of renaissance or renewal, and in this way, Hardy can avoid the bitter conclusions of evolutionary theory – that there is no ameliorating teleological end for humanity.

Although Hardy is not satisfied with dualistic notions of humanity – he is in essence a non-dualist – he admits to struggling with the materiality, and material development of, consciousness. In a late poem, 'Our Old Friend Dualism', published in *Winter Words in Various Moods and Metres* in 1928, Hardy's final volume of poetry that was published in the year of his death, Hardy addresses the persistence of dualistic understandings of humanity (CP 892). He refers to dualism as 'A tough old chap' (l.1) even though 'We pound him with our 'Truth' (l.3). The personified Dualism asserts that 'I must live; for flamens plead I am all that's worth believing!' (l.6). In 'Before Life' and 'Aerolite', as well as elsewhere in his work, Hardy articulates the struggle to maintain a materialist viewpoint that does not have the ameliorating consolatory beliefs of religious, teleological or fantastical explanations. Consciousness, for Hardy, only makes life difficult and bleak, and he fully understands the

temptation to surmise that mind and consciousness might be located somewhere other than the physical. But the solution he purports in both poems is equally untenable: to return to 'nescience' or 'unawareness'. Ultimately, he has no resolution for such a dilemma. From this perspective, his envy of the vegetal's non-conscious, mind-free life seems understandable.

Chapter Four - The search for meaning: Individual Transience and the Universal Life in Schreiner's *The Story of an African Farm*

We walk in the great hall of life, looking up and round reverentially. Nothing is despicable – all is meaningful; nothing is small – all is part of a whole.

(Olive Schreiner, *African Farm*, p.154)

Mankind is only an ephemeral blossom on the tree of time; there were others before it opened; there will be others after it has fallen [...] We are sparks, we are shadows, we are pollen, which the next wind will carry away.

(Olive Schreiner, *African Farm*, p.217)

In this chapter, I consider how *The Story of an African Farm* (hereafter *African Farm*) addresses the themes of multiplicity, connectivity, and the human search for meaning. Schreiner represents the individual as relatively insignificant in comparison to the continuousness of life as a whole. She positions individual characters within a world of multiple lifeforms and deep time and implies that the progress of life is of greater importance than the transient individual. For Schreiner, all lifeforms are connected and of value. She presents humankind's search for meaning and suggests that it is to be found in a recognition of the connectedness and continuousness of life. However, as individuals are trapped in their own consciousness, humanity is unable to perceive this wholeness. She identifies reasoning and consciousness as a barrier to such a perception and purports that it is only through other modes of perception that the underlying metaphysical connectivity across life can be accessed and meaning restored to life.

It is useful to compare and contrast Schreiner and Hardy's representation of some of these issues. Although they both consider how the individual relates to the whole, this is a more prominent theme in the work of Schreiner and it is embedded into her notion of progress across life over an extended temporal perspective. Hardy presents materiality as a challenge to a metaphysical perspective and that connectivity is to be found solely within the phenomenal. Schreiner, however, develops a model of connectivity that combines the material and metaphysical and asserts that it is through this that meaning is to be found.

Schreiner's problematisation of consciousness and an overdependence on the reasoning mind is in some ways comparable to Hardy's. They both view these aspects of the mind as fostering an existential search for meaning, as well as separating humanity from material life. For Hardy the mind is in conflict with the emotions that he locates in corporeality whereas for Schreiner, the conflict is between reasoning and embodied dreams, intuitions and feelings, and she suggests that these modes of perception engender a greater understanding of how humanity and individuals are connected to the material world as a whole.

In earlier chapters I explored how Hardy uses his vegetal settings to embed his notions of connectivity, entanglement, and the importance of materiality. Although Schreiner also uses the literal vegetal in *African Farm* to establish some corresponding ideas, its use as setting is less important. However, I argue that a vegetal mode of being is a productive model for examining how Schreiner represents the relationship between the individual and the collective and Marder's understanding of how the plant 'transcend[s] the distinction between "part" and "whole" (MM 84) is a useful lens for exploring this. I use the vegetal's transient mode of being as a model to reflect upon Schreiner's understanding of the necessity for death for the continuance of life as a whole. In fact, in *African Farm* Schreiner herself uses the ontological vegetal as a model for her notion of a continuous connected life when she represents the connectivity across all life across all time through a 'tree of life' image. Schopenhauer's notion of the survival of the will across successive individual manifestations encompasses some similar features and a Schopenhauerian perspective adds the notion of progress across successive generations to the vegetal model and is therefore helpful for exploring Schreiner's proposition that life and humanity progress as a whole and that this progress is ultimately of greater importance than is the individual life.

The chapter is divided into four parts. In the first, I examine Schreiner's use of form and structure. I consider how she expands the parameters of the realist novel by inserting abstract philosophical sections that break with the linear narrative. These enable Schreiner

to universalise the stories of the individual characters and model her approach to the relationship between individual and whole. In Part II, I explore how Schreiner articulates the relative unimportance of the individual in favour of the multiple and the collective. I examine her portrayal of the difficulty for humanity of accepting the transience of the individual but how this can be ameliorated through an understanding of a metaphysical and material force that connects all beings. Part III links these ideas to Schreiner's depiction of character. I predominantly examine how through the character of Waldo, Schreiner portrays how a mode of being framed by consciousness causes dissatisfaction, and how a more vegetal mode of life brings content. Finally, in Part IV, I examine Schreiner's portrayal of connectivity across the natural world. I argue that she purports that the human search for meaning is thwarted by a reliance on rational analysis, and that meaning in life can be found through an intuitive understanding of a metaphysical connectivity behind material connectivity.

While downplaying the role of the individual, *African Farm* is a novel and so must be about individual characters. The main narrative drive is shared amongst three characters: Waldo, Lyndall, and Em. I suggest that Waldo is the character who best reflects Schreiner's concerns about the position of the individual and the search for a meaning behind life. Much scholarship on *African Farm* has focused upon the character of Lyndall and her struggle for female emancipation. It is this element of the novel that led to W T Stead's 1894 evaluation of it as the 'forerunner of all the novels of the Modern Woman' and subsequent scholarship that has read it as a New Woman novel, and this continues in the twenty-first century.¹²² Nevertheless, there are many other potential readings of *African Farm* and scholarship has widened over the latter years of the twentieth and early twenty-first centuries to consider aspects such as Schreiner's representation of landscape and colonialism, her early use of

¹²² W.T. Stead, 'The Novel of the Modern Woman', *The Review of Reviews*, 10 (July 1894), p.64.
<https://www.proquest.com/docview/3915306/3A78643956C84A44PQ/9?accountid=8318&imgSeq=1>
[accessed 31st December 2022].

literary modernist techniques, and the influence of evolutionary, Transcendental, and philosophical ideas. My own reading of the novel is closest to these latter interpretive stances.

In *African Farm*, Schreiner presents Waldo's development from a child to his early death. At the beginning of the novel, this humble herder of sheep experiences a crisis of faith and, after much mental struggle alongside close observation of nature, develops a quasi-scientific understanding of material connectivity. Following his father's death and his subsequent mistreatment by the new overseer of the farm, Waldo leaves to explore the wider world. His existential journey, however, only brings him dissatisfaction. He returns to the farm and learns of the death of Lyndall. Struggling to come to terms with this, he eventually arrives at an understanding of the necessity for material death in a world of connectivity that embraces both the material and metaphysical.

Waldo shares many similarities with Clym Yeobright of *The Return of the Native*. Both go on existential journeys, although perhaps Waldo's can be more securely defined as existential reflecting the proto-modernism of Schreiner's text. Both returning natives move from a position of relative autonomy and self-determination to a realisation of the value of a vegetal-like heteronomous and rooted mode of life, and their connection to all other lifeforms. Unlike Clym, who in the end returns to a more intellectual mode of being, Waldo recognises that a heteronomous and rooted life is beneficial and meaningful, rather than restrictive.

Schreiner extends her representation of the importance of the whole in relation to the individual at the level of form and structure. She creates an innovative and experimental structure in which the realist linear narrative is radically interrupted by two abstract sections: the 'Times and Seasons' chapter, the first chapter of Part II, and the Hunter allegory

embedded in the following chapter. These abstract sections do not further the linear narrative about individual characters but instead depict a collective humanity. They are therefore separate from the linear narrative and yet inextricably linked to it. Although the 'Times and Seasons' chapter is an account of the development of thinking within a universalised individual, many elements of it echo Waldo's story. The Hunter allegory traces the progressive development of humanity's understanding through a series of individuals but is embedded within the linear narrative through being told by a 'stranger' to Waldo. Waldo tells the stranger afterwards that 'all my life I have longed to see you' (AF 170) and it has some, if amorphous, influence on Waldo's subsequent development. I argue that reading such formal and structural patterns through the lens of Marder's vegetal ontology demonstrates their resemblance to elements of vegetal spatiality and growth and that these patterns are therefore embedded within the very structure of this novel.

I. Experimental Form as Ontologically Vegetal

Schreiner's use of a radical fragmentary form expands the capacity of the linear realist novel. Such a strategy has been read as modernist and demonstrative of the openness of the novel form. Jed Esty contends that despite its nineteenth-century publication date, *African Farm* anticipates many modernist techniques.¹²³ Jade Munslow Ong asserts that Schreiner exploits the 'openness of the novel form to integrate radical modernist allegory as part of her 'cultural resistance.'¹²⁴ In describing Schreiner's use of form as in the vanguard of modernist techniques that push the novel genre forwards into the twentieth-century, Doris Lessing suggests that Schreiner 'does the work of an earthworm "making new soil where things can grow"'.¹²⁵ Lessing's description characterises the novel form as organic, able to adapt to new

¹²³ Jed Esty, 'The Colonial Bildungsroman: *The Story of an African Farm* and the Ghost of Goethe', *Victorian Studies*, 49(3) (2007), 407-430 (p.407).

¹²⁴ Jade Munslow Ong, *Olive Schreiner and African Modernism: Allegory, Empire and Postcolonial Writing* (London, Routledge, 2017), p.14.

¹²⁵ Ruth Parkin-Gounelas, 'Afterword' in Olive Schreiner, *The Story of an African Farm* (London, Virago Press, 1989), p.286.

circumstances. This is perhaps echoed in Erin James' later assessment of the ability of narrative 'to shift and change as does the world in which it is produced'.¹²⁶ It is not such a stretch then to read Schreiner's use of form and structure through a vegetal lens, modular vegetal growth enabling the plant to constantly adapt to changing environmental conditions. Her portrayal in the linear narrative of the stories of individuals and of collective experience in the abstract sections emulates a vegetal blurring of the boundaries between individual and collective and enables her to universalise human experience.

Through my organic vegetal interpretation of Schreiner's use of form and structure, I demonstrate how Schreiner's novel undermines ecocritical assessments of the novel form as unable to incorporate ecological and environmental issues. Dominic Head criticises the 'tendency of the novel to focus on personal development, and on social rather than environmental matters'.¹²⁷ I assert that Schreiner's use of form means that she can generalise rather than solely individuate human experience. Amitav Ghosh extends such criticism to the novel's focus on short-term temporality (see p.10-11).¹²⁸ I have already explored how Hardy embeds the long-term in his novels, and I argue here that Schreiner's use of abstract sections enables her to extend the temporal viewpoint further.

Before I take this argument further, I want to make the point that it is not only in the abstract parts of the novel that Schreiner extends her temporal framework. In the linear narrative Waldo observes cave paintings, fossil evidence of life before humankind, and earlier geomorphological changes. He even recognises the perspective of the stars which will have 'seen the earth when it was young' (AF 120). Schreiner also stretches temporality into a future beyond humanity. Lyndall suggests that 'mankind is only an ephemeral blossom on

¹²⁶ Erin James, 'Narrative in the Anthropocene', in *Environment and Narrative: New Directions in Econarratology*, ed. by Erin James and Eric Morel (Columbus, Ohio State University Press, 2020), pp.183-202 (p.186).

¹²⁷ Dominic Head, 'Problems in Ecocriticism and the Novel', *Key Words: A Journal of Cultural Materialism*, No.1, 1998, 60-73 (p.65).

¹²⁸ Ghosh, p.61.

the tree of time; there were others before it opened; there will be others after it has fallen' (AF 217). The use of a vegetal image here is key. This 'tree of time' conceives vegetal growth as continuous over an extended period while humankind is ephemeral – mere 'blossom'. This not only diminishes the importance of the individual, but also humanity itself. Humankind merely becomes part of the continuousness of life. Timothy Morton contends that to think ecologically, we need to expand our idea of space and time.¹²⁹ Schreiner's perspective seems to come at this from the other way around: through using an extended perspective, one is compelled to observe life as a whole.

In the abstract sections, Schreiner embeds a more radical temporal framework, one that even appears to be outside of time itself. In the 'Times and Seasons' chapter, she rejects anthropocentric timescales and asserts that as 'in the world to come time is not measured out by months and years' so the universal journey of the soul in this world has 'seasons of its own; periods not found in any calendar, times that years and months will not scan' (AF 137). Such temporality gestures towards eternity. Likewise, in using an allegory to portray the history of humanity's search for meaning, Schreiner utilises that form's inherent timelessness, appropriate for a story that tells of an eternal metaphysical search. These sections are therefore not only conceptually separate from the linear narrative; they are also separate from all concrete temporal frameworks and reach towards a metaphysical timelessness. Schreiner's temporality in this novel therefore embraces both an extended material and metaphysical continuousness.

Until the 'Times and Seasons' chapter, *African Farm* follows a linear trajectory focused on character development. Then at the beginning of Part Two, with the insertion of the 'Times and Seasons' chapter, Schreiner marks a sudden change with this universal account of a

¹²⁹ Timothy Morton, *The Ecological Thought* (Cambridge, Massachusetts, Harvard University Press, 2010), p.135.

child's 'individuation'.¹³⁰ The chapter begins with Waldo's situation three years after the events of Part One. The reader might logically think that this chapter will follow his story. But after two sentences, Schreiner indicates a change by using a more generalised statement: 'they say that in the world to come' (AF 137). The chapter then outlines over seven parts with no mention of Waldo, the development of a soul from infancy until a mature understanding of connectivity across life. The account seems both impersonal and particular: 'there rises, perhaps a warm summer's evening; we are seated on the doorstep' (AF 137). The first-person plural suggests specificity but the conditional 'perhaps' counters this. Some of the experiences of the anonymous child are similar to those of Waldo and they are also like Waldo in their introverted and curious nature: 'suddenly it strikes us, Who are we? This I, what is it?' (AF 139, emphasis in original). However, this self-recognition is also presented as a universal stage of development.

Is the 'Times and Seasons' chapter then an account of the universal development of all individuals or specifically Waldo's? Dorothy Driver alludes to the 'Times and Seasons' chapter as one which 'shows Waldo as a child in a spiritual crisis'.¹³¹ However, Voss's view, that it 'recapitulates Part I as one child's individuation', blends the individual Waldo of Part I with a generalised 'child'.¹³² If we interpret it from Marder's notion of the plant as both individual and collective, a 'provisional unity of multiplicities' (MM 84), the question perhaps becomes a moot point and in this sense I concur with Voss's view. As vegetal modules are independent, 'each shoot and part of root pursues its own trajectory of intentionality', and yet are part of the whole plant, this chapter is both separate to the linear narrative and yet intrinsically related to it, blurring the boundaries between these two modes.¹³³ Furthermore,

¹³⁰ Tony Voss, "'How Are These Things Related That Such Deep Union Should Exist Between Them All?': The Textual Integrity of *The Story of an African Farm*", *Journal of Literary Studies*, 27(1) (2011), 43-64 (p.59).

¹³¹ Dorothy Driver, 'Invoking indigeneity: Olive Schreiner and the poetics of plants', *The Journal of Commonwealth Literature*, 56(1) (2021), 61-76 (p.66).

¹³² Voss, p.59.

¹³³ Michael Marder, 'Plant Intentionality and the Phenomenological Framework of Plant Intelligence', *Plant Signalling and Behaviour*, 7.11 (2012), 1365-1372 (p.1370).

as elements of Waldo's story are reiterated in the 'Times and Seasons' chapter, this emulates the vegetal's repetition of form with each material reiteration being different (see p.21). Schreiner draws attention to this within humanity:

As man differs from man, so differ these souls' years. The most material life is not devoid of them; the story of the most spiritual is told in them. And it may chance that some, looking back, see the past cut out after this fashion (AF 137).

Only 'some, looking back' see the development of the soul as Schreiner articulates in this chapter and yet all will experience something akin to this, even 'the most material life'. Such a juxtaposing of same and yet different reflects Schreiner's emphasis at the end of the chapter on the similarities between beings: 'all is part of a whole' (AF 154).

The Hunter allegory in the following chapter, extends this vegetal-like theme of same but different. It reiterates some of the themes of the 'Times and Seasons' chapter but it is also different. Like the 'Times and Seasons' chapter, it combines individual and collective development. But it is different in that it presents the gradual discoveries of humanity as a collective endeavour that progresses over time, achieved through the efforts of individual after individual. The relationship between the two can perhaps best be expressed by Lyndall: one can 'trace the analogy there always is between the progress and development of one individual and of a whole nation, or again, between a single nation and the entire human race' (AF 198). Moreover, the Hunter allegory is both part of *African Farm* and yet has its own independent meaning, evident in the fact that it was also published separately in Schreiner's first collection of allegories (1890).

In the Hunter allegory Schreiner explicitly articulates that collective achievement is of greater importance than that of the individual, although that for the individual, this is difficult to appreciate. The allegory portrays humankind's progression, stage by stage, in its discovery of the 'Truth'. A series of 'hunters' cut steps into the mountainside, each step representing

the progression of knowledge. Upon these steps the following man can mount and add his contribution, and so on, and so on:

Where I lie down worn out other men will stand, young and fresh. By the steps that I have cut they will climb; by the stairs that I have built they will mount. They will never know the name of the man who made them [...] they will mount, and on *my* work; they will climb, and by *my* stair! [...] And no man liveth to himself, and no man dieth to himself (AF 168, emphasis in original).

The allegorical anonymity of these hunters stresses the relative unimportance of the individual and yet the repeated and emphatic '*my*' of this specific 'Hunter' shows a human urge to proclaim his own achievement. But the final recourse to St Paul (Romans 14.7) implies that he can justify the sacrifice of his body in aid of the progress of the collective body of humanity. Fittingly, Schreiner is using an allegory to articulate what is inherent in the form itself: that through the story of individuals, it represents a greater meaning.

Schopenhauer's philosophy is a useful lens for reading the relationship between individual and collective in the Hunter allegory. In fact, Schreiner recognises a passage of Schopenhauer's work as reading 'like a paraphrase of my allegory in the African Farm' and this seems refer to the Hunter allegory.¹³⁴ In this letter, Schreiner is commenting on a passage in Helen Zimmern's life of Schopenhauer and the passage to which it is likely that she is referring is 'on the search for philosophic truth', in which Schopenhauer characterises philosophy as 'an alpine road' with a 'precipitous path'. As the philosopher climbs, 'the lonelier, the more desolate grows the way' but he must 'know no fear' and 'leave everything behind him', having 'to cut his own path' until he 'stands amid clear fresh air' where he can 'behold the sun when all beneath is still shrouded in the blackness of night'.¹³⁵ This resembles Schreiner's lonely Hunter who climbs until he 'stepped into the broad sunshine' while 'far below rolled the white mist over the valleys of superstition' (AF 166). Schreiner

¹³⁴ Olive Schreiner, letter to Havelock Ellis, 2nd March 1885, <https://oliveschreiner.org> [accessed 29th August 2022].

¹³⁵ Zimmern, p.37.

recognises Schopenhauer's philosopher as akin to her hunters who strive through hardship to attain truth and extend humanity's knowledge.

The Hunter allegory can also be read as an allegorical reworking of Schopenhauer's development of the will. Schopenhauer asserts that the will progresses through a series of individual manifestations, the individual being merely a conduit for it. In Schreiner's allegory, each successive individual hunter contributes to the progress of the 'will', but what is of prime importance is the progress of the whole. Reading the Hunter allegory from this perspective highlights how Schreiner conceptualises a linear progression over time across a series of individuals. Schopenhauer's notion of the will as a 'blind' force that has no knowledge of itself is also a useful perspective. In the Hunter allegory, the figure of Wisdom states that although each hunter is 'the child of The-Accumulated-Knowledge-of-Ages', in striking out 'a path for himself [...] my voice he hears no more.' (AF 163). The blind hunter cannot foresee or benefit from his contribution to truth, he can only participate.

Through her use of form and structure Schreiner incorporates complex structural patterns throughout *African Farm* that include linearity, cyclicity, and repetition. Scholars have variously interpreted such patterns. In his article on the 'textual integrity' of *African Farm* (2011), Voss says that the sequences that he traces 'are offered as illustrations of the integrity of the text, that the novel has a plot', taking on board critique of its structure as 'desultory'.¹³⁶ Cherry Clayton views *African Farm*'s structure as 'built on a pattern of repetition and variation, parallels and contrasts, at every level'.¹³⁷ I extend this to argue that these patterns can be read as ontologically vegetal, reflective of Marder's conceptualisation of vegetal growth as both linear and cyclical, with repetitions that are yet different each time.

¹³⁶ Voss, p.59.

¹³⁷ Cherry Clayton, *Olive Schreiner* (New York, Twayne Publishers, 1997), p.48.

These structural patterns exist within the linear narrative and within the abstract sections as well as forming complex patterns that cut across these two narrative modes. The seemingly linear narrative of Waldo's development incorporates cyclicities. The development of his thinking is not a straightforward journey from loss of faith to a recognition of material connectivity across all lifeforms but incorporates loops and diversions. On returning to the farm after his journey, his relationship to the material world is different to that of before in that it now incorporates a more mature understanding of connectivity. The linear development of his thought through the novel is partially recapitulated in the final two chapters, and yet this is different in that it is rooted in Lyndall's death and extends further. Waldo and Lyndall's stories contain elements that are similar to each other and yet are different. Both are dissatisfied with life's limitations, go on journeys to search for a better way of life, and perish. Yet their dissatisfactions, journeys and deaths are distinctive: Lyndall's journey is that of a feminist striving for emancipation whereas Waldo's is a search for the truth.

Across the linear narrative and abstract sections, Schreiner interweaves events, themes, and ideas. Waldo comes to a similar conclusion in the penultimate chapter about the relative unimportance of the individual in favour of the whole that Schreiner has already articulated in the Hunter allegory. The development of Waldo's thinking, with its cyclical back and forth between spirituality and materiality is similar to that of the universalised soul of the 'Times and Seasons' chapter. In both accounts it is not until an understanding is reached that incorporates both material and metaphysical connectivity that any satisfaction is experienced. Yet these models of unity are different. I could continue: such an account of the cyclicities and reiterations in *African Farm* is by no means exhaustive. All is connected yet all is singular.

Although Schreiner uses an omniscient narrator, she also employs other voices. Waldo's stranger tells the Hunter allegory, Waldo tells the story of his journey in a letter, Gregory

Rose tells the story of Lyndall's final days and within that story, Lyndall's landlady tells some of the story to Gregory Rose. I read these voices as emulating Marder's vegetal's 'dispersed intentionality' in which each vegetal module has its own intentionality and yet contributes to the unity of the whole plant.¹³⁸ Schreiner's use of multivocality enables her to complicate simple notions of truth: each voice presents its own individual truth as each growing part of the plant pursues its own course. It is only when these intentionalities are unified by the whole book (or plant), that an overarching unity is achieved.

Another structural feature of *African Farm* that reflects vegetal spatiality is the importance of the middle. Schreiner positions the two abstract sections at the centre of the novel. Although they begin Part Two, they are chapters fourteen and fifteen of twenty-nine chapters and as such, occupy the very middle of the novel. I have already explored the importance of the vegetal middle in Hardy's poetry. I now offer a reading of *African Farm* in which the structural middle also emulates vegetal growth.

It is not causally necessary that these sections are placed in the middle of the novel. The events of the 'Times and Seasons' chapter do not lead on sequentially from events at the end of Part One. While this chapter does reiterate Waldo's development up to this point, it also goes on to foreshadow his subsequent progress. The concluding material and metaphysical image of the 'Times and Seasons' chapter is not reflected in a comparable image in the linear narrative until the penultimate chapter. The Hunter allegory with its message of the importance of collective endeavour is likewise not narratively essential at this specific point in the novel.

¹³⁸ Michael Marder, 'Plant Intentionality and the Phenomenological Framework of Plant Intelligence', *Plant Signalling and Behaviour*, 7.11 (2012), 1365-1372 (p.1369).

Schreiner's positioning of these sections at the middle of *African Farm* permits a more organic and less linear reading of the novel which works from the central axis outwards. The two abstract sections can be seen as a trunk from which the story branches in two directions. In Part One of the novel, Waldo moves from religious faith towards materiality. In Part Two, his development is in the opposite direction, moving away from a marked reliance on materiality towards a synthesis of materiality and metaphysics. Reading from the centre outwards then, these branches extend from materiality towards the metaphysical beginning and end of the book (albeit with much back and forth along the way). The pivotal 'Times and Season's' chapter at the centre reiterates this movement in a universalised individual and the rest of the novel shows how this plays out in the individual life of Waldo. Consistent with this interpretation is Schreiner's placing of her tree of life image at the very centre of the novel, at the end of the first of the two abstract sections. Moreover, this image itself considers the connectivity across life as 'the fine branches of one trunk' (AF 153). I examine this tree of life image in detail later in this chapter, but for current purposes I note that it is a model of connectivity that amalgamates the material and the metaphysical. Schreiner therefore structurally reinforces this fusion at the centre of *African Farm*. The Hunter allegory likewise embeds at the centre of her novel her other central concern: the relationship between individual and collective.

II. Death, Transience, and the Individual

In the Hunter allegory, Schreiner asserts the relative unimportance of the individual life in comparison with the collective human body. Akin to this, in the linear narrative Schreiner portrays Waldo's journey towards an acceptance of the necessity for life to be transient. In *African Farm* death is pervasive. In the first chapter Waldo lies awake at night obsessed by the sheer number of human deaths that have occurred throughout human history, and the constantly ticking clock reminds him of the relentless movement towards finality. There are many individual deaths: the two heroes, Waldo and Lyndall; Waldo's father; Lyndall's baby.

Before the novel begins many close relatives have died: Lyndall's parents, Waldo's mother, Em's father, and Tant' Sannie's two husbands. Death also pervades the natural world. The rocks 'are built up of a life that was' (AF 290), the ground spider's enemy falls into its trap (AF 152), and the dung beetle is killed by Waldo's dog (AF 107). Yet the movement in *African Farm* is towards an acceptance of these individual deaths, gained through an understanding that for life as a whole to continue, the individual must die.

In the penultimate chapter Schreiner portrays Waldo's struggle to reconcile himself to the death of Lyndall. He contemplates the 'dreams' (belief systems) through which humanity has tried to accept the horror of death. The first two of these metaphysical 'dreams' reflect Christian notions of life after death and a third is that of the 'Transcendentalist's high answer' (AF 288).¹³⁹ These all assure Waldo that 'you shall see her again' (AF 288). But the problem for Waldo is that these dreams locate the dead Lyndall in the metaphysical realm. An immortal spiritualised Lyndall is not sufficient for the bereft Waldo; he craves her material manifestation. For Waldo, 'change is death' and 'immortality is annihilation' (AF 289). Even the biblically evoked material flow between living organisms, the notion that 'the body never dies, because it turns again to grass and flowers', is problematic as it is as much a transformation as the doctrine that 'the spirit never dies' (AF 289).

At this point in Waldo's story, his perspective is material. He struggles to accept that Lyndall can no longer participate in the cycles of the material world: 'in none of them all would she have part! [...] She would exist no more' (AF 287). His quasi-scientific understanding of the

¹³⁹ The transcendentalist, Ralph Waldo Emerson, was an important influence on the young Schreiner. It is generally assumed that the name 'Waldo' is rooted in this influence and Schreiner's decision to publish *African Farm* under the nom de plume of Ralph Iron may also show Emerson's impact. Many scholars have traced his ideas in Schreiner's work generally, and *African Farm* in particular, and these include: Jade Munslow Ong in *Olive Schreiner and African Modernism: Allegory, Empire and Postcolonial Writing*, (Abingdon and London, Routledge, 2017); Ruth Knechtel in 'Olive Schreiner's Pagan Animism: An Underlying Unity', *English Literature in Translation*, 53(3) (2010), 259-282; and Simon Lewis in 'The Transnational Circulation of Dissent: Olive Schreiner and the Colonial Counter-flows of Unitarian Freethinking' *The Journal of South African and American Studies*, 14(1) (2013), 1-15.

world, gained through close observation of materiality, means that he struggles to accept the ameliorating 'dreams' of immortality due to the lack of evidence for them. It is therefore unsurprising that his attitude to these metaphysical dreams is that they 'blind reason, and crush out thought' as they 'take any lie, any creed' to provide a 'Bridge over Death' (AF 287). To accept such dreams would mean that he would have to reject his scientific rationalism.

He concludes that humans have created a 'hereafter' as, trapped within the perspective of their own lifespan, they cannot perceive any value in transience:

There must be a hereafter because a man longs for it? [...] There must be a Hereafter because we cannot think of any end to life. Can we think of a beginning? [...] where were we ninety years ago? (AF 289-90).

Humankind's limited temporal perspective blocks their ability to imagine a longer-term perspective and traps them into thinking that the beginning and end of life is framed by their own existence.

However, the scientifically inclined Waldo is eventually able to rationalise the necessity for death. Although he has previously rejected material flows, now he reassesses such ideas through scientifically rational thought based upon material evidence:

All dies, all dies! the roses are red with the matter that once reddened the cheek of the child; the flowers bloom the fairest on the last year's battle-ground; the work of death's finger cunningly wreathed over is at the heart of all things, even of the living [...] The rocks are built up of a life that was (AF 290).

In connecting the redness of the roses with the redness of the child's cheek, Waldo accepts the flow of material elements between vegetal and human. Cognisant of the fact that some flowers flourish on battle-grounds, he appreciates the vegetal's ability to reuse matter and perform, what Marder terms, "material 'resurrection'" (MM 67). So instead of seeing change as death, Waldo now acknowledges that change is essential to life and that change involves death: 'the work of death's finger [...] is at the heart of all things'. Schreiner here anticipates

Morton's reflection that 'all life forms are the mesh, and so are all dead ones, as are their habitats, which are also made up of living and non-living beings'.¹⁴⁰

This acknowledgement of the necessity for change is, however, still not enough to reconcile Waldo to Lyndall's death. But eventually, *in extremis*, as 'his soul passed down the steps of contemplation' and 'loses all consciousness of its little self', Waldo is enabled to leave behind pure rationality and acknowledge the efficacy of such dreams. However, material evidence is not entirely discounted. For Waldo, what is important is that 'the dream be not in too glaring discord with the thing they know' (AF 290).

The penultimate chapter concludes with one of the clearest accounts across all of Schreiner's work of her conception of 'Universal Unity'. Waldo finally understands that it is in the synthesis of the phenomenal and the noumenal that unity can be found, and through this he is enabled to realise:

the old mystery of Universal Unity that surrounds it. "No death, no death" [...] there is that which never dies – which abides. It is but the individual that perishes, the whole remains. It is the organism that vanishes, the atoms are there. It is but the man that dies, the Universal Whole of which he is part re-works him into its inmost self [...] that of which he is but the breath has breathed him forth and drawn him back again. That abides – we abide. For the little soul that cries aloud for continued personal existence for itself and its beloved, there is no help. For the soul which knows itself no more as a unit, but as a part of the Universal Unity of which the Beloved also is a part; which feels within itself the throb of the Universal Life; for that soul there is no death (AF 290).

This model of connectivity and an immortality that is not of the individual, is both material and metaphysical. The movement of atoms describes material flows between lifeforms and is therefore acceptable to the scientific Waldo. But Waldo goes further and recognises a metaphysical realm behind such flows. As such, Schopenhauer's philosophy which also amalgamates materiality and metaphysics, is a helpful lens for interpreting Schreiner's own

¹⁴⁰ Morton, p.29

synthesis. For Schopenhauer, the metaphysical will is the underlying force behind reality, and material phenomena its manifestation. The death of the individual provides the matter necessary for the continuation of life, and the will, in successive manifestations (*WWR1* 277). The will exists separately to materiality, and yet supplies the metaphysical impetus behind all existence. Schreiner also purports a metaphysical force, but hers is in the realm of the 'soul' and the 'Beloved'. Rather than a continuous force that moves on from one life to the next as does Schopenhauer's, Schreiner's metaphysic seems located in a region, the 'Universal Whole', to which the soul returns after death. This is the Schreiner who, having lost any conventional faith, retains a belief in a God-like noumenal; Schopenhauer famously dispenses with the need for such a figure in his philosophy.¹⁴¹

It is only through leaving behind consciousness and self that Waldo is enabled to perceive the noumenal behind the material. In this sense, he becomes more vegetal-like: without consciousness or self. There is some closeness here between Hardy and Schreiner's problematisation of consciousness. In both *The Return of the Native* and *The Woodlanders*, Hardy infers that the mind is a barrier to an understanding of our material connectivity to other lifeforms. Schreiner suggests something comparable although for her, what it prevents is the understanding of a noumenal connectivity. It is only when there is no 'personal existence' or seeing oneself 'as a unit', that one can recognise a plant-like continuity and connection across life. However, even then, Schreiner contends that we can only 'almost' gain access to the 'mystery' of 'Universal Unity'. It remains tantalisingly out of reach of the thinking mind.

In an analogous point to that made by Hardy in 'At the Royal Academy', Schreiner purports that art and books are attempts to transcend human ephemerality. It is through books that Waldo discovers that others in the past have thought like him, appreciating their ability to

¹⁴¹ I explore Schreiner's conception of God in more detail in the following chapter.

communicate over time. Likewise, the continued existence of the Bushman paintings continues to communicate. However, Schreiner's emphasis on the materiality of books serves to undermine their permanence. When Waldo finds a store of books, before reading them, 'he felt them, thrust his fingers in among the leaves, and crumpled them a little' (AF 109). Lyndall reminds us that 'the books that our grandmothers fed on the mould is eating' (AF 217), and when Blenkins and Tant' Sannie burn Waldo's book, they do so to ensure that it has 'gone out of existence' (AF 114).

The image of book pages as 'leaves' emphasises their materiality and allies them to the vegetal. But the vegetal is also used metaphorically with respect to books. Waldo surmises that 'when great men blossom into books [...] the world of men too opens beautifully, leaf after leaf' (AF 299). In this way, Schreiner links the materiality of the leaves of the book with the metaphorical image of the gradual development of the ideas that these leaves embed. Both images, the literal leaf and metaphorical blossom, embed transience. And yet their materiality enables the ideas they contain to be transmitted over periods of time longer than the human life. Schreiner therefore characterises the book as vegetal-like in its blurring of the boundary between ephemerality and permanence.

Schreiner further implies that the relative longevity of books, as compared to their authors, can also be problematic in that they preserve ideas that would perhaps be better superseded. Lyndall asserts that 'we know that no man's work is great and stands for ever. Moses is dead, and the prophets [...] they are milestones that the world has passed' (AF 217). Schreiner suggests that the 'dreams' of humankind are and should be temporally bound: 'so age succeeds age, and dream succeeds dream' and 'the generation that follows will have its own' (AF 291). Knowledge and ideas progress and the 'milestones' become supplanted. Vitality lies in transience and progress, and the perishable nature of books is perhaps apt.

III. Waldo Becomes Rooted and Heteronomous

In Part II I considered how, through the death of Lyndall, Waldo realises the lack of importance of the material individual and the 'Universal Unity' to be found in a material and metaphysical wholeness. In this part, I consider another journey towards understanding undertaken by Waldo. The journey is both physical – he leaves the farm to discover the wider world – and an existential search for meaning. However, what he comes to understand is the importance of rootedness and his place within the material connectivity across all lifeforms.

Waldo's journey incorporates elements of the bildungsroman genre. However, his explorations bring him no answers, his experience of the wider world is consistently negative, and at the end he rejects society rather than finding his place within it. Other scholars have also assessed Waldo's journey as a problematic bildungsroman. Elizabeth Hope Chang suggests that Waldo and Lyndall's 'unnaturally elongated youth terminated by abrupt death marks a world unreceptive to [...] progressive futures'.¹⁴² Esty reads it as a modernist revision of the 'protocols of the nineteenth-century bildungsroman' that demonstrates the lack of progress of the subject peoples of imperial capitalism, being unready for self-government.¹⁴³ I concur with both Chang and Esty that Schreiner's bildungsroman embodies a lack of individual progress, but argue that Schreiner's use and undermining of this genre reflects a more radical position. Waldo's journey leads to him eventually finding his place within the wider world of connectivity across all living beings and through his story, Schreiner critiques the very notion of individualistic progress, particularly that of the isolated human. Furthermore, I read Waldo's journey as one in which he moves towards finding satisfaction in a vegetal mode of being in which rootedness and a heteronomous relationship with alterity takes the place of egoistic ambition. I suggest that

¹⁴² Elizabeth Hope Chang, *Novel Cultivations: Plants in British Literature of the Global Nineteenth Century* (Charlottesville, University of Virginia Press, 2019), p.129.

¹⁴³ Esty, p.407; pp.410-15.

Schreiner offers this mode of being as an alternative to human desires to strive for individual progress and development, values inherent in the genre of the bildungsroman.

Even before his existential journey, Waldo is presented as vegetal in his rootedness at the farm, in materiality, and within nature. His role as a herder means that he spends most of his time outside. In his first appearance in Part Two of the novel, he is represented as surrounded by materiality: sand, thorn-trees, ostriches, and the 'brown serene earth'. This is intensified through physical contact: he 'lay on his stomach on the red sand'. Prepositions also embed him within this material world: 'the small ostriches he herded wandered *about him*'; '*on his right* lay the graves; *to his left* the dam; *in his hand* was a large wooden post'; Doss lay *before him*' (AF 155, my emphases). In this same chapter, the stranger recognises the value of Waldo's rooted existence, noticing that 'it seemed that as the fellow's dark eyes looked across the brown earth they kindled with an intense satisfaction' (AF 157). In contrast, he bitterly describes his own rootless existence as 'a man who believes nothing, hopes nothing, fears nothing, feels nothing [...] no criterion of what you should be who lives here among your ostriches and bushes' (AF 159).

Rootlessness in *African Farm* is also associated with colonialism as a cause of displacement from the land. Em, the only one of the three main characters who remains on the farm throughout the novel, and who might be viewed as illustrating the benefits of rootedness, is a beneficiary of colonialism. She will inherit the farm 'and everything that is upon it for [her] own' (AF 46). Such ownership has displaced or uprooted, the indigenous population and the black characters in the novel exist only in servitude to the colonial population. Most of the other characters are also colonials or immigrants. Waldo and his father are German, Tant' Sannie is a Boer, Gregory Rose is English, and Em herself is at least half-English. In fact, Schreiner satirises exaggerated claims to nationality with the absurd and yet contemptible Bonaparte Blenkins changing his nationality to suit circumstances, and the ridiculing of

Gregory Rose's noble descent. However, all the rootless immigrants seem to lead rather dissatisfying lives.

We could even read humanity as orphaned from the land. If we rethink rootedness in terms of genetic connections, no family is intact and the three main characters are or become orphans: Lyndall is an orphan, Em only has a step-parent, and by chapter eight Waldo is also an orphan. Surnames are missing with only those of Blenkins and Rose disclosed. Schreiner's humanity is therefore unrooted in more than one sense. It is only when Waldo returns home, that rootedness is presented as a source of satisfaction. Yet as Waldo is himself an immigrant, from a colonial perspective this remains problematic.

Allied to rootedness is heteronomy and I have already explored a heteronomous mode of being with respect to Clym's return to Egdon Heath in Chapter One. It is productive to similarly assess Waldo's journey from self-determination to heteronomy. Before his journey, Waldo is dissatisfied with life at the farm. The stranger advises him that 'you are happy to be here! Stay where you are', but Waldo wonders 'was his delightful one ridiculing him? Here, with this brown earth and these low hills, while the rare wonderful world lay all beyond. Fortunate to be here!' (AF 171-2). Marder asserts that 'the human sets itself over and against its environment, driving a wedge in the unit of survival, wherein it participates', and therefore 'undermines itself', resulting in 'alienation' (MM 167). Consciousness indeed alienates Waldo from an appreciation of alterity and causes dissatisfaction with what he sees as his limited existence on the farm. As a result, he *uproots* himself in search of experience, meaning and truth. The ensuing failure of this physical and existential journey and his cyclical return to the farm is framed through his growing understanding of the value of a rooted and heteronomous relationship with that environment and his connection to all other lifeforms.

The wiser, but no less alienated, Lyndall articulates this plight. She sees Waldo's yearning to gain knowledge and an understanding of life's meaning as a 'poison, not a food' (AF 217). She recognises the same problematic yearning within herself even though her own journey is to escape from patriarchal norms. Before she leaves the farm for the second and final time, she kneels at Otto's grave and laments: 'There is light, there is warmth, [...] why am I alone, so hard, so cold? I am so weary of myself! It is eating my soul to its core – self, self, self! [...] Will nothing free me from myself?' (AF 241). Her focus on 'self' prevents her from accessing the 'light' and 'warmth' that is available in her surroundings, and which a vegetal being could and must access.

It is not until Waldo has tried and failed to satisfy the demands of consciousness, that he realises that self-determination does not create satisfaction, and on his return to the farm, has learnt the value of a more heteronomous and connected mode of being. In the final chapter, he becomes part of the scene of chickens, flowers, butterflies, and goats, as he 'looked at it all and smiled'. He also experiences joy in the nowness of hetero-temporal existence: 'to live on so, year after year, how well! Always in the present; letting each day glide'. As he 'chuckled with intense inward satisfaction as the old hens had done', he also rejects any sense of superiority and accepts equality with the materiality that surrounds him. He offers a 'friendly greeting' to the ice-plant and characterises the chickens as 'brother life' (AF 297-300).

He also observes humanity's material similarities to the natural world. He sees how in the thorn-pods 'the little seeds suck their life through the delicate curled-up string, and how the little embryo sleeps inside!'. In looking 'deep into the hearts of flowers', he observes 'how lovingly the pistil and the stamens nestle there together' (AF 299). Rather than reading these as anthropomorphic, they show Waldo's recognition of the same material processes across lifeforms.

Waldo therefore comes to a different ending than does Clym in *The Return of the Native*. Clym struggles to disregard his superior position in a hierarchy of lifeforms, reflecting the difficulty of this for humankind. However, Waldo becomes able to accept this. Perhaps it is that Waldo's awareness of both a material and metaphysical connectivity enables a more profound understanding of the equality of all living beings. Certainly, unlike Clym, he is able 'to raise the status of the materiality of which we are composed' (JB 12, emphasis in original). In this sense, Waldo's death at the end of this chapter is also a completion as he joins the long-term continuity of life itself.

In fact, Lyndall has always recognised Waldo as allied to the vegetal. Although he is judged by most other characters as of little worth, Lyndall perceives his value and characterises him as 'like a thorn-tree, which grows up very quietly, without any one's caring for it, and one day suddenly breaks out into yellow blossoms' (AF 231). Blossom can be viewed as the culminating achievement of the tree and Marder reflects upon how such analogies have often been used to link the flower, spatially positioned at the top of a plant, to idealism, spirituality or even consciousness (MM 61). But Marder also reminds us that these are anthropocentric interpretations (MM 62) and likewise, I read Lyndall's image differently. For a plant the flower is no more important than any other part of its lifecycle. The flower will produce seeds which will produce a new plant which will produce flowers, and so on *ad infinitum*. When Lyndall's image is read as a whole, it is reflective of process and continuous, often unnoticed, growth. In this sense, 'blossom' is reconceived as a verb - 'to blossom' - rather than a noun that indicates attainment. Lyndall's image sees Waldo as part of the material world's continuing process rather than enacting a culminating achievement. Such a reading also reflects Schreiner's commitment to collective processes rather than individual achievement.

Schreiner suggests, however, that Lyndall, the feminist, cannot thrive through a heteronomous relationship to alterity. For women, alterity is a repressive patriarchal society.

In her diatribe against such societal oppressions, Lyndall links adaptability to the environment to the female plight:

It is not what is done to us, but what is made of us [...] that wrongs us. No man can be really injured but by what modifies himself. We all enter the world little plastic beings [...] and the world tells us what we are to be, and shapes us by the ends it sets before us. To you it says – *Work!* and to us it says – *Seem!* [...] And so the world makes men and women (AF 188, emphasis in original).

Schreiner uses the idea of plasticity to articulate how humans are shaped and modified by the social world. For the vegetal, modular growth enables plasticity and adaptation to environmental conditions. But for women, a heteronomous relationship to social externality only serves to restrict as it does not supply the conditions under which to flourish. In fact, her subsequent use of the terms ‘atrophied’ and ‘compressed’ (AF 189) to describe women’s responses to oppression, recalls the response of plants to poor environmental conditions. In this sense, vegetal being and heteronomy is untenable for Lyndall.

IV. Restoring Meaning to the Material

In both Waldo’s story and the ‘Times and Seasons’ chapter, Schreiner addresses humanity’s search for meaning. In both contexts, after the character rejects a conventional Christian faith, they find solace in the recognition of a connectivity across material nature. But what this fails to replace is meaning. I have already explored how Hardy grapples with this, and how, for him, meaning becomes located within the material and the recognition of material connectivity without the need for anything more. However, for Schreiner, it is through a recognition and understanding of the lifeforce as that which connects all beings that she comes to realise that there is meaning in materiality.

In the ‘Times and Seasons’ chapter the processes that connect all lifeforms are noticed. The corresponding shapes of rock patterns, blood vessels and tree shapes are understood as formed by growth processes. The ‘delicate silver tracery’ in the rocks resembles ‘leaves and

branches.' Blood vessels possess similar shapes. When a gander is dissected, its blood vessels seem like 'a trunk, bifurcating and rebifurcating', resembling 'that same exact shape and outline [as] our thorn-tree seen against the sky in mid-winter' (AF 152-3).

Close observation reveals ecological relationships between lifeforms. Plants are seen as dwelling places for insect species. The heart of the bitto flower that had been 'a mere blur of yellow' is now seen to be not only 'a hundred perfect flowers' but also 'the homes of the tiny black people with red stripes, who move in and out of that little yellow city'. Likewise, 'every bluebell has its inhabitant'. On a 'karroo-bush a green fly is laying her silver eggs'. The ground-spider must 'make its trap, bury itself in the sand, and then wait for the falling in of its enemy' (AF 152). These ecological interactions show the processes of reproduction, nourishment, and death that occur across lifeforms.

Process becomes synonymous with life. Bennett's exploration of two meanings to 'nature' is useful here. She draws upon Spinoza's distinction between *natura naturata* and *natura naturans*. The first of these characterises matter as passive, as thing, and the second, as active, and that which creates new forms. Bennett refers to this second meaning as 'universal creativity' and affirms that it is akin to her own concept of 'vibrant matter' (JB 117). Schreiner's recognition of the processes occurring across nature demonstrate her understanding to be closer to Spinoza's *natura naturans* and Bennett's 'vibrant matter' than passive conceptualisations of matter.

Such a reading is reinforced in the stranger's comment to Waldo. He states that 'whosoever should portray truly the life and death of a little flower – its birth, sucking in of nourishment, reproduction of its kind, withering and vanishing – would have shaped a symbol of all existence' (AF 169). It is useful to read this image through Marder. Like Bennett, Marder characterises 'nature' as active. For Marder, the term expresses the 'internal determination of the natural entity' and he argues that in this sense, existence becomes 'an emergence out

of itself'. Extending this understanding, he contends that a plant is a 'synecdochic instantiation of universal growth', or a 'miniature mirror' of nature as process (MM 120). This is the point that Waldo's stranger is expressing by using the image of a flower to show that its processes of birth, nourishment, reproduction, and death constitute 'a symbol of all existence'. Material processes therefore become the foundation of existence, rather than this being located within a 'higher' realm. In fact, in this illustration he reflects Schopenhauer's own use of plant life to illustrate how the will can exist without knowledge.

But a conception of existence as merely materiality and material process with no need for a 'higher' realm, and therefore potentially no meaning, is difficult for Schreiner. Although she perceives a life force, how it is expressed in materiality seems meaningless. This is evident in her description of an interaction between Waldo's dog (Doss) and a beetle which she interprets as purposeless:

The beetle was hard at work trying to roll home a great ball of dung it had been collecting all the morning; but Doss broke the ball, and ate the beetle's hind legs, and then bit off its head. And it was all play, and no one could tell what it had lived and worked for. A striving, and a striving, and an ending in nothing (AF 107).

The bitterness of Schreiner's understanding of the lack of purpose or meaning in these interactions is extended through her use of the latter part of this ('And it was all play [...] A striving, and a striving, and an ending in nothing') as an epigraph for Part Two of *African Farm*.

Explanations of the life force by both Marder and Schopenhauer also use the word 'striving'. Marder characterises the vegetal's 'ceaseless striving' as reflective of the 'restlessness of life itself' (MM 162) and Schopenhauer writes that plants reveal a 'restless, never satisfied striving, a ceaseless activity' (WWR1 309). Whereas Schopenhauer's conception of such a force incorporates the metaphysical will, Marder's remains fully material. In developing Merleau-Ponty's phenomenological idea that 'beneath the intentionality of representations

[there is] a deeper intentionality, which others have called existence' (MM 160), Marder develops a notion of corporeal intentionality and sees in vegetative processes a 'non-conscious intentionality' within existence (MM 153).

However, for Schreiner, an explanation of the 'life force' that is rooted in materiality is insufficient. In the 'Times and Seasons' chapter she articulates how difficult it is for one to dismiss everything previously taught and that the loss of a religious faith leaves a gap in meaning. Having previously seen Nature in relation to a 'deity' as 'a poor plastic thing', she now asks 'was it possible [...] to see Nature as she is – the flowing vestment of an unchanging reality?' (AF 150). But Nature as material reality is not enough. When a scientific growth experiment is attempted, although it is successful and a plant grows from a seed until 'it is higher than our heads', the problem is that 'we find no reason for that upward starting' (AF 152-3). It is this lack of purpose in materiality or material processes that remains problematic.

Schreiner recognises humankind's need to find meaning in life and yet, through Waldo, she portrays existential search as detrimental to contentment. Lyndall characterises Waldo as one that has 'the desire to become, to know, to do' which 'is driving us mad' (AF 217). He later characterises himself as like the sea which 'never rests; it is always wanting, wanting, wanting [...] It is always asking a question, and it never gets an answer' (AF 259). The reader is left wondering what route is left.

In this respect, it is helpful to look at how Schreiner articulates a different type of connection between lifeforms in the relationship between human and vegetal. As a child, alone and feeling 'wicked' due to his loss of faith in God, Waldo observes the leaves of the prickly-pear and sees that 'they glinted, and glinted, and glinted, just like his own heart – cold, so hard, and very wicked'. After crying, these 'wicked leaves, blinked, and blinked, and blinked at him', resulting in him revealing to them his 'secret': that 'I hate God!' (AF 42). Waldo feels

some form of sympathy from the prickly-pear and therefore feels emboldened to communicate what he has withheld from his fellow humans. Likewise, in the 'Times and Seasons' chapter, the child, sitting amongst bushes, kisses them 'and they love us back: it seems as though they were alive' (AF 139). The child experiences some form of kinship between himself and the plants.

If these could be read as childish experiences of sentiment or imagination, this is dismissed when the adult Waldo has a similar experience. As he returns to the farm after his journey, on descending into a ravine for water:

There was one among the trees on the bank that stood out against the white sky. All the other trees were silent; but this one shook and trembled against the sky. Everything else was still; but those leaves were quivering, quivering [...] I could not go away [...] Does it seem strange to you that it should have made me so happy? It is because I cannot tell you how near I felt to things that we cannot see but we always feel (AF 262).

Although Waldo is older and more cognisant of material connectivity, he continues to experience the vegetal as communicating with him in a different way. It is an experience he cannot rationally explain; he can only recognise its effect.

To consider this vegetal/human relationship further, it is instructive to return to Bennett's conceptualisation of an onto-sympathy between vegetal and human that I discussed in Chapter Three (see p.79). Although Bennett's onto-sympathy analyses an 'overlap between materialities', it is worth looking at some of the reading she explores in this context, particularly that of Thoreau's *Walden* (1854). He writes that 'sympathy with the fluttering alder and poplar leaves almost takes away my breath' and that 'every little pine needle expanded and swelled with sympathy and befriended me. I was so distinctly made aware of the presence of something kindred to me'. Although Bennett recognises how Thoreau locates the ultimate source of this in the divine, she makes a deliberate decision to leave this

behind to focus upon how this is materialised.¹⁴⁴ In contrast, I would like to stay with Thoreau's more mystical ideas and acknowledge their closeness to Schreiner's. Both Schreiner and Thoreau recognise a sympathy and kinship between vegetal and human, and both also articulate the presence of something that is non-material.

In a letter, Schreiner recalls her own experience of such a presence in the natural world in a childhood visionary experience:

When I was a little child of five and sat alone among the tall weeds at the back of our house, this [...] perception of the unity of all things, and that they were alive, and that I was part of them, was as clear and overpowering to me as it is today. It is the one thing I am never able to doubt.

Although she goes on to record her struggles with 'reconciling this direct perception [...] with what I was taught', she stresses that she could not leave it behind:

I believe scientific knowledge harmonized with my feeling, but I could not shake myself free from it if they did not; there would only be discord, as there was of old between facts as known to my intellect, and my inevitable perceptions.¹⁴⁵

There are similarities between this mystical experience and the relationship between vegetal and human that Schreiner articulates in *African Farm*. In both, Schreiner articulates a continuing belief in something within the world of materiality that she can access through feelings but cannot fully express. Moreover, she purports the importance of feelings as that which can access this noumenal.

In *African Farm*, Schreiner asserts that allied with a loss of faith is a loss of the validity of feelings as a route to understanding. She claims that those who have faith 'feel Him, we feel – that is all!' (AF 146). But through experiences such as Waldo's perceived kinship between

¹⁴⁴ Jane Bennett, 'Vegetal Life and Onto-Sympathy', in *Entangled Worlds: Religion, Science, and New Materialism*, ed. by Catherine Keller and Mary-Jane Rubenstein (New York, Fordham University Press, 2017), pp.89-110 (p.90-94). References to Henry David Thoreau from *Walden and Civil Disobedience*, ed. Owen Thomas (New York, Norton & Co., 1966), pp.87-89.

¹⁴⁵ Olive Schreiner, letter to John T Lloyd, 29th October 1892, <https://oliveschreiner.org> [accessed 25th February 2023].

vegetal and human, and his dreams, Schreiner implies that it is possible to bypass the rational intellect and therefore gain a glimpse, however tentative, of an underlying reality that restores a meaning to life that is more than material. In an image in which she contrasts dreams and rational tangibility, reason is represented through images of disease and entrapment. It is a 'little cankered kingdom of the tangible', which is surrounded by 'bars' that are 'set close about us' that 'our wings [...] are struck against'. Dreams, however, are portrayed as space and freedom. They embrace an 'infinite peace' and enable us to 'glide between the bars into the great unknown beyond' (AF 291).

Schreiner's idea of 'the great unknown beyond' can only be expressed through analogy as the point is that it is ineffable. Schreiner's image of connectivity that comes at the end of the 'Times and Seasons' chapter also allows for the unknowable. In this tree of life image, Schreiner suggests that the 'deep union' that can be observed in materiality has an underlying metaphysical basis:

How are these things related that such deep union should exist between them all? Is it chance? Or, are they not all the fine branches of one trunk, whose sap flows through us all? [...] This thing we call existence; is it not something which has its roots far down below in the dark, and its branches stretching out into the immensity above, which we among the branches cannot see? Not a chance jumble; a living thing, a *One*. The thought gives us intense satisfaction, we cannot tell why (AF 153, emphasis in original).

Unlike Hardy in *The Woodlanders* who sees material and metaphysical explanations of reality as opposing, Schreiner unites them in this image which has similarity to Waldo's perception of 'Universal Unity' that I considered earlier. The 'Universal Unity' image stresses the return to a unified whole after death whereas the tree of life image, coming as it does after the child's struggle to reconcile materiality and a metaphysical, emphasises the union of these separate spheres. Like other mythological and religious 'tree of life' images, it also physically embodies the connection between material and metaphysical, with its 'roots far down below in the dark' and its 'branches stretching out into the immensity above'. Moreover, the 'intense satisfaction' it engenders suggests that such an understanding can restore

meaning to the material world. Bryan Magee contends that Schopenhauer's philosophy suited the needs of those who, having lost their faith, embraced a scientific outlook and yet who could not accept that everything could be scientifically explained.¹⁴⁶ This reflects the value of Schreiner's combined material and metaphysical image to reinstate meaning.

Schreiner's use of a vegetal image embeds the metaphysical realm within a living material reality. The tree is not a mere dead image; the '*One*' is a 'living thing'. Life processes are present in the flowing sap that connects all lifeforms, redolent of the life force. Like Schopenhauer's metaphysical will, the metaphysical becomes an intrinsic part of material life, rather than existing in a separate idealist sphere.

Schreiner's image of the tree also explains why for her, humankind cannot fully grasp the unity behind the whole. As humanity is embedded within the branch system, we cannot perceive the whole from the outside: it is 'too mighty for our comprehension' (AF 154). Karen Barad's linking of ontology and epistemology can extend this understanding. Barad states that 'we are a part of that nature that we seek to understand' (KB 26). She develops this idea to make the point that minds themselves are material phenomena that emerge through the sort of processes that Schreiner is illustrating in this image (KB 361). The mind that thinks is therefore as entrapped within the materiality and processes in Schreiner's tree as is the body. We cannot perceive through a 'godlike approach whereby we may know [the world] as it is "absolutely in itself"' (KB 125). The mind is not able to observe or understand from a position external to the world of materiality and humanity can only resort to metaphor to tentatively articulate such ideas, as Schreiner does through this image. Furthermore, through expressing this 'thought' as a series of questions rather than statements and concluding with 'we cannot tell why', Schreiner resists any definitive explanation.

¹⁴⁶ Bryan Magee, *The Philosophy of Schopenhauer*, revised edn. (Oxford, Clarendon Press, 1997), p.429.

After the understanding expressed in the tree of life image in the 'Times and Seasons' chapter, Schreiner asserts that as we now 'walk in the great hall of life' so 'all is meaningful' (AF 154). At the end of the novel, Waldo himself appreciates that 'life was a rare and very rich thing' (AF, 299). Both the universal child of the 'Times and Seasons' chapter and Waldo recognise the meaningfulness to be found in life after they come to an understanding of the metaphysical unity behind material connectivity. *African Farm* ends with the statement, 'but the chickens were wiser' (AF 390). Although ostensibly this alludes to the fact that the chickens realise that Waldo is dead before anyone else, perhaps Schreiner calls the reader's attention here to the point that wisdom and meaning resides in being.

Chapter Five - 'Long unbroken lines of connection': The Entanglement of Theory, Context, and Matter in Schreiner's *From Man to Man*

Between spirit that beats within me and body through which it acts, between mind and matter, between man and beast, between beast and plant and plant and earth, between the life that has been and the life that is, I am able to see nowhere a sharp line of severance, but a great, pulsating, always interacting whole.

(Olive Schreiner, *From Man to Man*, p.181).

Narrative form is intrinsically ecopolitical: it carries messages of unity and equality or isolation and discrimination that run underneath the texts' thematic surface.

(Justyna Kostkowska, *Ecocriticism and Women Writers*, p.165).

From Man to Man, published posthumously in 1926, represents some of Schreiner's most mature thinking on many of the concerns that she had previously explored in her other work, including *African Farm*. Her key theme here is connectivity. What are portrayed as separate issues in *African Farm*: evolution, feminism, relations between the sexes, and societal critique are, in *From Man to Man*, intertwined. In *African Farm*, Schreiner uses two protagonists, Waldo and Lyndall, to respectively voice her evolutionary and feminist messages, whereas in *From Man to Man*, the character of Rebekah addresses both of these concerns and this adds to the sense of connectivity. For Schreiner, humanity is 'a solidarity and a whole with all its parts reacting on one another' (FM 188). This bears some resemblance to Hardy's conception in *The Woodlanders* of a 'great web of human doings', but for Hardy the 'web' exemplifies the entanglements between people whereas Schreiner's human 'solidarity' portrays humanity as a temporal continuum.

In *From Man to Man*, Schreiner presents humanity as in a process of continuous evolutionary progression, a stark contrast to the implication in Hardy that humanity is over-developed and civilisation detrimental. Schreiner portrays progress and continuity from the perspective of a long-term evolutionary framework. Humankind is embedded within, and part

of Timothy Morton's 'ecological time and geological time'. Morton suggests that such timescales are 'difficult to grasp intuitively' but Schreiner's representation of life as a long-term continuum makes these timescales, and humanity's participation in them, noticeable.¹⁴⁷ By positioning the individual within this evolutionary progression, Schreiner emphasises one's responsibility to contribute towards it.

Connectivity is also a structural and formal principle. Although Schreiner uses two protagonists, the sisters Rebekah and Bertie, for me it is Rebekah who is the more important to Schreiner's project as she acts as a connecting device between the realist narrative and the theoretical sections. As the abstract sections are written or articulated by Rebekah, they become more contextualised in the realist narrative than are the abstract sections of *African Farm* and add to, rather than detract from, the cohesiveness and unity of the novel. I argue that Schreiner's emphasis on how the material context and Rebekah's own corporeality influences the theoretical, so it feminises and adaptively strengthens it as theory becomes entangled with materiality and dividing lines are blurred.

Rebekah is both a practical and theoretical botanist and the representation of the vegetal is at the heart of the novel. In the realist narrative she practices botany in her farming, gardening, and scientific experiments. In the theoretical sections her botanical knowledge is employed in vegetal ontological analogies through which she foregrounds the importance of the collective, the continuity of life, and the values these perspectives engender. Through Rebekah, Schreiner reinforces the importance of context in another sense with Rebekah having to adapt to the context of the patriarchal environment. Rebekah therefore links abstract and realist form, theory and practice, and alterity and adaptation to that alterity, demonstrating how material contexts are agentially entangled with characters, events, and theory. Moreover, as Schreiner represents Rebekah's theory as inextricably influenced by

¹⁴⁷ Morton, p.42.

her life experience, I read the abstract sections as reflective of plant modules rooted in and influenced by alterity. Rebekah is also plant-like in her own adaptations to the patriarchal environment, her theories changing in response to conditions.

This chapter is divided into four parts. I begin by exploring Schreiner's use of form as it is pivotal to an understanding of the connected narrative of *From Man to Man*. With Rebekah as creator of the abstract sections, I argue that Schreiner successfully amalgamates experimental and realist narrative, brokering a new form in which realist context impacts on theory, and vice versa, creating a cohesiveness across the novel. I also assert that through foregrounding the material processes involved in the creation of the theoretical sections, Schreiner blurs the boundaries and connects theory and practice, and mind and matter, through a femininely divergent and adaptive practice. In Part II, I examine how Schreiner uses a long-term evolutionary framework to conceptualise humanity as a continuous collective progressive body. I explore how she articulates this through a series of vegetal analogies which she also uses to critique the hierarchical nature of hegemonic society. I recognise how Schreiner's emphasis on the importance of evolutionary adaptation to environment is related to the importance of context in the formal narrative strategy. In Part III I focus upon the character of Rebekah and how she is used to create thematic and formal connections across the novel. I demonstrate how Rebekah is plant-like in how she entangles theory and practice, thinking and acting. I contend that through her adaptation to the environment, Schreiner reinforces the agency of the entanglement between material context and individual. In the final part of the chapter, I consider Schreiner's evocation of a lifeforce and a creative force, constructing them as analogous continuous drives that are derived from mysterious and unexplainable sources. I explore how Schreiner's lifeforce connects all beings as well as connecting materiality and the noumenal. In my analysis of Schreiner's creative force, I examine how human progress has been facilitated through the entanglement of materiality and mind.

My focus on the natural world, particularly the vegetal, responds to the challenge of Jade Munslow Ong and Dorothy Driver that scholarly criticism on *From Man to Man* would benefit from considering these aspects of the novel. In an interview article in *The Journal of Commonwealth Literature* (2021) that considers current perspectives on *From Man to Man*, Munslow Ong suggests that through exploring Schreiner's interest in the natural world, 'new conclusions might emerge around the intersection of Schreiner's feminism, anti-imperialism, and free thought with the currently underexplored aspects of her environmentalism'.¹⁴⁸ My focus on connectivity in this chapter does indeed explore how Schreiner connects the position of the natural world with the position of women and other oppressed groups in society. Munslow Ong also observes that there is little ecocritical analysis on this novel and recommends 'further research on the social and functional roles of plants in Schreiner's writings'.¹⁴⁹ This chapter both rectifies this omission and extends it. My approach to Munslow Ong's plant-based challenge is ontological whereas Driver's approach is locational and claims that Schreiner's references to indigenous plants are indicative of South Africa as the locus for her 'vision of social change'.¹⁵⁰ While having no intention to undermine this point, my ontological focus sees Schreiner's use of plant imagery and analogy as making a wider point.

In my 2020 article on *From Man to Man*, I used an ecocritical and ecofeminist methodology to examine Schreiner's evolutionary-based model of interconnectivity.¹⁵¹ I argued that Schreiner was writing against categorisation, binaries, and hierarchies, as well as the appropriation of evolutionary theory to support these, and that instead, she articulates the

¹⁴⁸ Jade Munslow Ong in Sanja Nivesjö and Heidi Barends, 'Current Perspectives on Olive Schreiner's *From Man to Man* or Perhaps Only – ', *The Journal of Commonwealth Literature*, 56(1) (2021), 44-60 (p.58). (In this article, Nivesjö and Barends engage three Schreiner scholars, one of which is Jade Munslow Ong, in a discussion about current and future perspectives in relation to Schreiner's *From Man to Man*.)

¹⁴⁹ Jade Munslow Ong in Nivesjö and Barends, p.58.

¹⁵⁰ Driver, p.61. (In the 'Notes' at the end of Nivesjö and Barends's interview article, they acknowledge that Driver takes up the challenge to consider Schreiner's use of plants in *From Man to Man* in the article in this same issue of *The Journal of Commonwealth Literature*.)

¹⁵¹ Hilary Bedder, 'Oliver Schreiner's *From Man to Man*: Alternative Models of Reality and the Problematics of Human Reasoning', *English in Africa*, 47(2) (2020), 99-118.

values of unity and equality. Examining *From Man to Man* from the perspective of the vegetal here extends the conclusions of my article and Schreiner scholarship. The vegetal approach I develop in this study creates the capacity to explore wider issues in this novel and across Schreiner's work. Through this lens, I recognise how her work is embedded in late nineteenth-century discourses centred around evolutionary materiality and the metaphysical, how she extends the novel form to decentralise the human and the individual and configures life as a vegetal-like continuum in which we are all embedded.

In the previous chapter, I used a vegetal ontological model to create a new reading of *African Farm*. Although this approach is also productive for exploring *From Man to Man*, in this chapter I also examine Schreiner's own use of these ontological models. Michael Marder's work is a useful lens for exploring Schreiner's conceptions of vegetal being as she calls into service, like Marder, the vegetal's collective being, and its continuous reiterations that are both independent and yet reliant upon the whole plant for their viability. Marder's approach is also productive for considering how Schreiner contextualises the abstract sections in this novel where I view them as vegetally dependent upon the external narrative.

Reading Schreiner through Marder and New Materialist critics suggests an affinity between their deconstruction of boundaries between theory and practice. However, a New Materialist approach is useful for extending an understanding of how Schreiner articulates entanglements across all matter, and between beings and alterity. Through reading Schreiner's agentic connections between theory and context, and mind and matter, through New Materialist approaches, I argue that these intra-actions result in a reconfiguring of the world and even Rebekah herself. In analysing Schreiner's emphasis on the materiality of Rebekah's writing practice and theoretical writings, Karen Barad's discussion of the differences between performative and representational approaches offers a particularly useful approach.

Schopenhauer's development of his philosophy of the will to an evolutionary theory is useful for exploring Schreiner's evolutionary life force that connects all beings, spirit and body, and mind and matter, across vast periods of time. Schopenhauer is also useful to my examination of Schreiner's creative force. Schopenhauer suggests that the artist is able to overcome the individualistic focus of the will to express the universal and this is helpful to an understanding of Schreiner's exploration of the artistic urge to create and share universal truths.

I. Entanglements between Theory and Practice

In *From Man to Man*, Schreiner employs an experimental form, disrupting the realist narrative with lengthy theoretical sections. These sections outline the values and theoretical positions that underpin and are played out in the realist narrative. For clarity in what follows, I list these theoretical sections in the order in which they appear:

- in chapter seven, an almost fifty-page polemic about evolution and connectivity, that includes a critique of hegemonic society;
- in chapter seven, an allegory in which the 'Spirit of the Ages' instructs fettered humanity to strive for freedom;
- in chapter eight, an almost fifty-page letter from Rebekah to her husband that addresses the problems in their relationship;
- in chapter twelve, an anti-racist allegory;
- in chapter twelve, the story of evolution and the development of humankind as told to Rebekah's children.

These theoretical sections are all written or voiced by Rebekah and are therefore more embedded in and pertinent to the realist narrative than are the abstract sections in *African Farm*, both in terms of their positioning and relevance. Rebekah's polemic opens out of her retreat to her study after assisting Bertie to get ready for a party and reviewing her own

intellectual proclivity and development. Rebekah's letter to her husband is predicated upon her discovery of his adultery. The anti-racist allegory and subsequent story told to her children are framed as a response to her son Frank's assertion that he would no longer walk with his step-sister, Sartje, as he had been teased for 'walking with a nigger girl!' (FM 417). Such contextualisation shows Schreiner more fully utilising the potential of the experimental technique she had developed in writing *African Farm* to create a cohesive model of connectivity across the theoretical and realist parts of the novel.

I read these contextualisations of the abstract sections as ontologically vegetal in the sense that the theoretical sections can be viewed as plant-like and the realist narrative the external environment in which they grow. Marder uses Deleuze and Guattari's conceptualisation of the rhizome to develop his notion of plant-thinking as contextual. Deleuze and Guattari suggest that for plants 'there is always an outside where they form a rhizome with something else'.¹⁵² In recognising how this rhizomatic model allies with his concept of plant-thinking, Marder emphasises the importance of the interconnections between the plant and alterity. He extends this through his contention that what is important is not 'who or what does the thinking' but 'when and where does thinking happen?' and in his recognition that 'all radically contextualised thought is a worthy inheritor of vegetal life' (MM 169). Reading Schreiner's use of form from this perspective, vegetal ontology becomes a formal structural device.

If this contextualisation is read through Jane Bennett's New Materialist concept of the assemblage, Schreiner's context becomes part of the agency that generates the theoretical sections. Agency emerges from the collaborative assemblage of context and Rebekah. The anti-racist allegory and the story that follows, is precipitated by her son's racism but also rooted within the necessity for Rebekah to communicate her values to her children.

¹⁵² Gilles Deleuze and Felix Guattari, *A Thousand Plateaus: Capitalism and Schizophrenia* (London, Continuum, 2003), p.11.

Schreiner emphasises the importance of these contexts by inserting contextual reminders within the theoretical sections. The story to her children is interrupted by comments like 'the boys leaned forward watching her intently' (*FM* 426). In the letter to her husband, Rebekah draws the reader back to the moment by frequent references to 'tonight'.

The contextual relationships between the abstract sections and the realist narrative are also emphasised through Schreiner's explanations of the processes involved in their creation. These are both long-term and current. The letter to her husband detailing Rebekah's unhappiness with their marriage is both a result of that specific evening and her long-term disillusionment with their relationship. The polemic in chapter seven emerges from a long gestation which emphasises its rootedness in her childhood and adult life. As Rebekah takes her book to write in from her drawer that evening, the reader learns that 'in the drawer below were six or seven such books' (*FM* 176) that stretch back to her childhood. Schreiner lists the contents of these exercise books, and these include creative fragments, passages copied from books, discussions on abstract questions, diary entries, and plans for the future. As her polemic emerges from these other writings, the boundaries between these forms become blurred.

Schreiner foregrounds the material process of the production of writing itself, intertwining the corporeality of writing and writer. In the exercise books, the handwriting is sometimes 'filled with the sharply pointed writing of a very small child' and later 'with the larger, more rounded handwriting of a young girl from twelve to twenty' (*FM* 176). Within the polemic itself, Rebekah's handwriting mirrors her thought processes. She 'wrote quickly in a large sprawling hand, because she had much to say' (*FM* 183). When she is questioning her ideas 'she began to write slower and slower [...] after a time, began slowly drawing with her outstretched hand the pictures of faces down one edge of the page she had written on' (*FM* 186).

The corporeality of the process of Rebekah's writing is further emphasised through Schreiner's blurring of the boundaries between different modes of being while she is producing what becomes the polemic. Rebekah is not just writing, she is also thinking, speaking, and walking, and which of these she is enacting at any one moment is often unclear. After reviewing what she has written, Rebekah begins to write. But as she argues with an imaginary interlocuter, Schreiner parenthetically interrupts the polemic to comment on how she 'walked quicker and quicker' (FM 204) and then 'stretched out one hand with the palm extended' (FM 206). Later she 'was whispering so loudly to herself that, in the next room, you would have thought she was speaking to someone beside her' (FM 209). So, although the polemic continues on the page, the reader is often unaware as to which mode of action or creativity Rebekah is performing at any one time. At the end of the polemic and the following allegory, Schreiner tells us that Rebekah 'had been walking nearly three hours' (FM 225). Not writing or thinking or speaking but 'walking'. In fact, her walking has produced on the carpet 'a mark like a footpath where the nap had been worn off, running right around the desk' (FM 175).

The point is that Schreiner's emphasis on the different modes of creation involved in the polemic shows the impact of the material and corporeal on its content. Barad's distinction between representationalism and performative approaches is useful here. For Barad, representationalism enshrines a distinction between the representation and that which it purports to represent (KB 46). In contrast, a performative understanding of discursive practices, including those of thinking, observing, and theorising, views them as 'practices of engagement' with the material world (KB 133). They are '*mutually implicated in the dynamics of intra-activity*' and are themselves 'material (re)configurings of the world' (KB 151-2, emphasis in original). Read through Barad, it is a performative approach that Schreiner embraces here. Her focus on the physicality of Rebekah's creative processes means that they are entangled with her discourse, blurring the boundaries between theory and practice, abstract and concrete, and mind and matter. Corporeality affects the theory, but in turn the

theoretical sections of the narrative alter the reader's reception of the realist narrative.

Furthermore, Rebekah herself does not just creatively construct or partake in the discursive; through the long-term processes of her discursive creation, she is herself reconfigured and therefore participates differently in the world. In this way, the theoretical sections of *From Man to Man* participate in and change the realist narrative and it is their entanglement that creates the meaning.

This is further emphasised by examining how Rebekah's domestic circumstances affect the polemic. While writing:

she thought suddenly she heard the baby stir. She threw her pen down on the table and took up the lamp, went into the next room and bent over his cot [...] Then she tucked the cover in at the back of his neck and went back, closed the door softly behind her and began to walk up and down. If the advance of a nation or a race must always ultimately be stayed (*FM* 192).

Rebekah deals with the interruption and continues with her polemic. Her writing and thought processes are regularly broken up by such domestic duties: 'she had been sitting up for a night, to make poultices for her boy who had bad earache, and, between whiles as he slept, she had written' (*FM* 177). Rather than mere contextual reminders, through these interruptions Schreiner shows how domesticity influences the direction of the polemic itself.

Rather than reading these domestic interruptions as problematic, I contend that they are, perhaps paradoxically, beneficial. As they break Rebekah's chain of thought, they cause her to reflect: 'she had had to go and make a poultice, and she had branched off on a side line when she came back, to question if' (*FM* 177), and later, 'here she had been interrupted again. When she came back she had gone on to seek more narrowly after the cause' (*FM* 178). In her article about the importance of motherhood in *From Man to Man*, Ruth Knechtel cites Ann Heilmann's view that 'these moments represent how "marriage and motherhood

have taken a heavy toll on her creative energy".¹⁵³ However, I argue that these interruptions strengthen Rebekah's polemic. Munslow Ong views Rebekah's movements from darning to text as moving from feminine to masculine tasks.¹⁵⁴ Indeed they are, but they become part of the causal assemblage of the polemic itself, from which emerge the counterarguments, questions, and the consideration of alternative perspectives, all of which create a stronger rather than weaker argument. It becomes femininely divergent rather than masculinely linear or didactic. If these ideas are read through Marder's suggestion that the vegetal's context-dependent life contrasts with the 'context-free abstract rationality' of Western thought, the context-dependency of Rebekah's polemic suggests not just a feminine subversion of masculine argument modes but a more expansive countering of dominant Western modes of thinking.¹⁵⁵

Considering the importance of contextualisation to Rebekah's polemic highlights further connections between Marder's ontological vegetal and New Materialist approaches. Returning to my notion of reading the theoretical sections as vegetal, Rebekah's argument that branches off on a side-line and considers a variety of societal factors and perspectives, is analogous to the plant producing new modules, as an adaptive response to the environment. They allow Rebekah to incorporate alterity (as the vegetal incorporates light, air, soil) to widen and adapt her argument. Likewise, reading this from a New Materialist perspective, that the polemic emerges from the intra-actions between itself and its context, suggests that intra-actions can themselves be seen as adaptive responses to externality. Rebekah does not intentionally branch off on side-lines, but such intentionality is the result of a complex network of agencies and material conditions to which Rebekah adapts.

¹⁵³ Ruth Knechtel, 'Olive Schreiner's Pagan Animism: An Underlying Unity', *English Literature in Transition, 1880-1920*, 53(3) (2010), 259-282 (p.272).

¹⁵⁴ Munslow Ong, p.113.

¹⁵⁵ Michael Marder, 'Plant Intentionality and the Phenomenological Framework of Plant Intelligence', *Plant Signalling and Behaviour*, 7.11 (2012), 1365-1372 (p.1370).

Schreiner's use of narrative form in *From Man to Man* models interconnectivity.

Astrid Bracke suggests that much criticism of the novel form with respect to ecocriticism rests upon viewing it as little more than story, neglecting any analysis of its narrative devices.¹⁵⁶ If we consider the 'story' of the realist narrative in *From Man to Man* in isolation, much of the connectivity across the novel is overlooked. Justyna Koskowska contends that 'narrative form is intrinsically ecopolitical: it carries messages of unity and equality or isolation and discrimination that run underneath the texts' thematic surface'.¹⁵⁷ In *From Man to Man*, Schreiner foregrounds the connections between matter and mind, individuals and types of humanity, and humankind and the non-human, and the causal entanglements between the theoretical sections and the realist narrative participate in this project.

Schreiner also connects the theoretical sections themselves by repeating ideas and attitudes across them. As in *African Farm* (see p.139), reiterations are not mere repetitions but contextually relevant. Rebekah's theories about the development of human societies in the polemic in chapter seven and in the story to her children in chapter twelve, both foreground the importance of shared progress. In the polemic, Rebekah argues that 'permanent human advance must be united advance!' so societies must 'Bring up your rears!' (*FM* 191-2). But this message is slightly different in the story where Rebekah states that 'when I think of all I have and all I know, the only feeling I have is – "Pass it on!"' (*FM* 435). In the story Rebekah's instruction to 'pass it on' is intended to create a responsibility in her children, whereas the 'bring up your rears' of the polemic is part of a theoretical analysis of why societies collapse. Likewise, in the polemic and allegory that follows it, Schreiner addresses the position of women. But it is only in the letter to her husband in chapter eight that these ideas become personalised and converted into potential practical actions. The different

¹⁵⁶ Astrid Bracke, 'Why neither realism nor the novel are dead: Genre and Form in the Anthropocene', unpublished keynote paper delivered at the conference 'Association for the Study of Literature and the Environment (UK and Ireland) postgraduate conference' (online, 4th September 2020), p.4.

¹⁵⁷ Kostkowska, Justyna, *Ecocriticism and Women Writers: Environmentalist Poetics of Virginia Woolf, Jeanette Winterson, and Ali Smith* (New York, Palgrave MacMillan, 2013), p.165.

contexts mean that Rebekah needs to, and is enabled to, adapt her language and ideas so that they have relevance and become increasingly practical.

II. The Progressive and Collective Evolutionary Body in Schreiner's Vegetal Analogies

As well as embedding connections within the formal structure of *From Man to Man*, Schreiner also uses Rebekah's theoretical sections to articulate theories of connectivity. I have already explored how in *African Farm* Schreiner represents the collective or whole as of greater importance than the individual or part. In *From Man to Man* she extends this understanding by approaching it through a long-term evolutionary perspective. In both the polemic in chapter seven and the story to her children in chapter twelve, Rebekah articulates a progressive interpretation of evolutionary theory. She represents the individual as part of an extended continuity of beings and their importance in the role they play in the progressive development of humanity. To this end, Rebekah uses numerous vegetal analogies that use ontological plant strategies to represent her view of the long-term continuity of life and the role of the individual within the whole.

In her story about evolution to her children in chapter twelve, Rebekah uses vegetal growth to illustrate the continuousness of life: 'so short a time ago that perhaps the lichens which are growing on the rocks that have fallen from Table Mountain were growing exactly as they are to-day – our forefathers, yours and mine, were savages' (*FM* 431). She suggests that the reason that the long-term ancestry of humanity is difficult to grasp is less to do with the length of time, but due to the individual manifestations of humans. The lichens, in contrast, represent continuity. While individual humans have come and gone, the lichens have stayed the same. Of course, the lichens growing on the rocks will be the descendants of previous lichens, but the continuous nature of vegetal growth obscures this fact and Rebekah can

therefore use the capacity of plants to grow and reproduce seemingly continuously to illustrate life as a long-term continuum.

It is not simply the individual manifestations of humans that make a continuous species history difficult for us to grasp. In his influential essay on the Anthropocene and climate change, Dipesh Chakrabarty claims that as humans we can only understand ourselves collectively, as a species, from an intellectual viewpoint rather than experientially.¹⁵⁸ Our individualistic subjective experience forestalls recognition of human continuity. In fact, the lesson that Waldo learns in *African Farm* is that a perspective framed by one's own existence is limited (see p.147). But through the comparison with lichen, Rebekah overrides subjective experientiality and aims to enable her children to perceive humanity as a long-term continuous body that bears resemblance to that of the vegetal.

In the story, Rebekah links herself as gardener to her conception of humankind as a progressive continuum:

sometimes even when I am walking in my garden [...] the feeling comes to me, and I want to say – "To all the gardeners that have been before me [...] Thanks!" And sometimes as I work there I feel as if they were working beside me and the garden belongs to them and me. And sometimes I think perhaps in years to come [...] some woman working in a garden [...] will stretch out her hand and say – "To all the gardeners that have been before me-" and I, so long dead in the dust, will live in her heart again' (*FM* 433).

Rebekah feels herself part of the long-term continuum that connects past, present, and future and enables progress. In fact, through imagining the gardeners of the past alongside herself, and herself within the gardener of the future, she almost dissolves any division between the individuals of the past and the present, thereby emphasising humanity's oneness across time. This passage also illustrates how Schreiner characterises the relationship between theoretical and concrete not just through the influence of the concrete on the theoretical

¹⁵⁸ Dipesh Chakrabarty, 'The Climate of History: Four Theses', *Critical Inquiry*, 35(2) (2009), 197-222 (p.220).

sections of the novel, but within the theoretical sections themselves. For Rebekah, the use of material practices familiar to her children enables her to root her theory within the concrete. But it also demonstrates how the concrete is part of the assemblage that contributes to the theory itself.

Rebekah extends her vision of society as a continuum by explaining to her children the debt that they owe to previous generations. This time her analogy is that of an ant heap:

Millions of ants have worked at them for years, and slowly and slowly they have grown a little and a little higher. Sometimes I have fancied, if a little ant should come on the top of one of these heaps, and should rear himself on his hind legs [...] and say, "My ant heap, that I have made! [...]" and that then suddenly a gust of wind should come! The ant heap would still be there, the ant heap on the top of which he chanced to be born [...] but he would be gone for ever' (*FM* 433-4).

The extreme number of ant generations needed to create the ant heap and the ant who assumes it is all his own achievement, pointedly human-like in his rearing up on his hind legs, ridicules the idea that the contribution of any one individual to the development of society is paramount. The endeavour is instead long-term and continuous, and Rebekah's evocation of the reliance upon a series of individuals recalls the Hunter allegory of *African Farm*. Although Rebekah uses the analogy of the ant heap to make her point here, an ant heap is not dissimilar to the plant body. Francis Hallé points out that many plants exhibit colonial modes of being through modular growth and Schreiner uses these colonial characteristics as a corrective to humanity's tendency to valorise the achievements of the individual and downplay their reliance upon the achievements of the past.¹⁵⁹ As Hallé points out, colonialism is a mechanism 'incompatible with the idea of the individual' and 'founded on the sacrifice of the individual' in favour of long-term survival.¹⁶⁰

¹⁵⁹ Hallé, pp.254-261.

¹⁶⁰ Hallé, p.261; p.268.

Schreiner does not deny the individuality and the individual stories of the characters in *From Man to Man*, but places them within an understanding of humanity as a long-term collective, demonstrating that individuality and connectivity are not mutually exclusive. Her use of a long-term evolutionary temporality enables her to perform what Benjamin Morgan refers to as 'perceptual scale shifts'.¹⁶¹ This is shown when, after the discovery of her sexual violation, Bertie goes to stay in an area surrounded by mountains that were 'still bearing the marks [...] of what had been the shores of seas and lakes, the remains of whose mammoth amphibious beasts lay still within the stratified shale' (*FM* 314). The trauma of the individual Bertie is placed within a topographical representation of deep time. Without minimizing Bertie's trauma, Schreiner reminds us of the position of the human individual within huge timescales, emphasising Bertie's agentic incapacity. Later, as Griet awaits Bertie's arrival home, she listens 'as for all the long generations of the past her foremothers had listened [...] for the coming step of the antelope that meant food, or of the enemy that meant war' (*FM* 342). The narrative places Griet's actions within a lineage that connects her to her ancient ancestors and suggests the continuing struggle of the individual in the face of wider agencies. Through this use of the long-term, Schreiner extends the scope of the novel form, countering criticisms of its limited capacity to envision longer timescales, placing the stories of individuals within a wider framework.

Rebekah uses plant analogies to embed her values and articulate a critique of societal inequalities and Social Darwinist-type theories, as well as to put forward a vision of a society in which individuals work together for the long-term good of the collective. Marder's suggestion that the plant contributes to a 'lived destruction of metaphysics' through deconstructing many binaries such as 'the one and the many' (*MM* 11) is a useful lens for understanding Rebekah's use of plant ontology to embed the values that correspond with collective being. They enable her to model her view that the individual is an integral part of a

¹⁶¹ Morgan, p.45.

whole or collective and to critique hegemonic society's atomisation of individuals. Morgan makes the point that the scales we think with are evaluative and laden with judgement.¹⁶² Rebekah's use of the long-term situates the individual within a principle of continuity and reinforces the values embedded in an awareness of collective and continuous being.

Rebekah recognises plant ontology as in some ways preferable to that of humanity. In the polemic, she seeks to understand 'why, when a nation or a race or a dominant class has reached a certain point of culture and material advance, has it always seemed to fall back from it' (*FM* 187). In questioning whether there is an 'immutable law' causing this, she uses a vegetal growth analogy, wondering 'is it absolutely futile to hope that humanity can ever advance as the fern palm grows, beautiful frond beyond beautiful frond opening one out of the other as it mounts up higher and higher?' (*FM* 188). She acclaims the vegetal's continuous growth as a model of progressive continuity and the success to be gained through working as a collective, implicitly critiquing humanity's individuality.

Rebekah reinforces her point by making specific reference to the reliance of plant modules upon the whole plant. She suggests that 'an abnormally nourished class, unsupported by any vital connection with the classes beneath them' would resemble:

the long, thin, tender, feathery, green shoots which our small rose trees sometimes send out in spring, rising far into the air, but which we know long before the summer is over will have broken and fallen; not because they have grown to a height which no rose tree can ever attain [...] but because they have shot out too far before their fellow-branches to make permanence possible (*FM* 191).

Although each individual shoot has the capacity to grow independently (in Marder's terms, it has its own 'intentionality'), it does not have the capacity to be fully independent from the whole plant from which it obtains its support and nourishment. Rebekah points out that although powerful classes in society might rise further than the rest of society, they will be

¹⁶² Morgan, p.47.

unable to consolidate these advances as they remain part of that society. Her explicit lesson is that 'sectional growth is no permanent growth' and that society must progress together and 'bring up your rears!' (*FM* 191). Rebekah's potential allusion to the parable of the sower here suggests that she is reflecting upon the responsibility of those who hear the word, to spread the kingdom of God in order to engender progress. Read in this way, Schreiner's analogy is one of responsibility rather than critique.

As her argument continues, Rebekah's conception of humanity continues to gesture towards the ontological plant whose modules function individually and yet have need of the whole organism to survive. Her conclusion that humankind is 'intimately in its nature a solidarity and a whole with all its parts reacting on one another' (*FM* 188) bears resemblance to the plant body in which modules, for Marder, are 'both members of a plant and independent entities in their own right' (*MM* 84). Her representations of humanity continue to be plant-like. She asserts that 'the individual is part of an organism which cannot reach its full unfolding quite alone' (*FM* 193) and that 'each man is but a cell in the human organism' (*FM* 194). For Rebekah, each human (or plant module) requires the whole society (or plant) to achieve its potential.¹⁶³

Rebekah also uses a vegetal analogy to argue against Social Darwinist eugenic-type theories:

Out there in my garden [...] there are flowers of all kinds growing – tall queen-lilies and roses and pinks and violets and little brown ranunculuses – and I love them all. But if the tall queen-lilies were to say, "We must reign here alone, all the others must die to give place to us," I do not know, but I think I might say, "Is it not perhaps then best *you* should go?" (*FM* 438, emphasis in original).

She suggests that the flowers that view themselves as superior, might assume that they are able to survive alone, and that other species are inferior and therefore expendable. Driver

¹⁶³ In the following chapter, I explore further how, in her allegories, Schreiner's notion of humanity as one body contributes to meaning.

reads this analogy as a 'rejection of exclusivity and supremacy', viewing the 'brown' ranunculuses and the 'many-hued' other flowers as reflective of the indigenous peoples who represent 'South Africa's potential'.¹⁶⁴ Her interpretation suggests that the species perceived as lesser contain promise for the future. I extend this to read the analogy as one that presses into service the evolutionary mechanism of variation. This is made clearer when reading how Rebekah extends her analogy:

And perhaps the next day there might come a blighting frost; the rose bushes would live on and the little violets hidden at their roots, and even the little brown ranunculuses sheltered by higher branches, would be alive; but the lilies – the tall white queen-lilies – would all be dead! (*FM* 439).

The environment - the 'blighting frost' - destroys the queen-lilies. In evolutionary terms, it is the varying responses of different species to environmental conditions that mean that the most adaptable thrive when the environment changes and it is this adaptability that overturns the hierarchy. The queen-lilies that towered over the others become the most vulnerable and the diminutive species' adaptability proves more successful.

Rebekah's argument recognises the importance of externality and therefore heteronomy as opposed to autonomy and the hierarchies that enables. The important lesson that she is trying to teach her children results from the racist comment made by one of them and her analogy counters Social Darwinist appropriations of evolutionary theory that validate the social hierarchies that enable and perhaps encourage racism.¹⁶⁵ Her aim is to show that adaptability, and therefore variation, is essential to evolutionary progress and that these mechanisms neutralise hierarchies by making all lifeforms (and therefore all types of people) of value. For Schreiner, hierarchy is a human construct and, in evolutionary terms, invalid. Furthermore, hierarchy assumes human autonomy whereas in this analogy Schreiner

¹⁶⁴ Driver, p.73.

¹⁶⁵ In my article of 2020 (Hilary Bedder, 'Oliver Schreiner's *From Man to Man*: Alternative Models of Reality and the Problematics of Human Reasoning', *English in Africa*, 47(2) (2020), 99-118), I explore in more detail how in *From Man to Man*, Schreiner explicitly counters the Social Darwinist agendas of writers such as Herbert Spencer and how this 'distorts and misrepresents evolutionary theory' (p.108). I also show how Schreiner counters these through the framework of mutualism. (See pp.108-112.)

illustrates the role of alterity, making humans as vulnerable to change as the heteronomous plant. Although this heteronomy is easily recognised in the plant due to an immediate response to the frost, for humanity, these responses must be longer-term and therefore potentially misapprehended.

Such a role for the environment in evolutionary theory is analogous to my argument for the importance of context to the theoretical sections of *From Man to Man*. Alterity influences the success and progress of the species as it does the content of the theoretical sections of *From Man to Man*. In the way that they counter notions of autonomy, both bear resemblance to Marder's heteronomous plant and New Materialism's emphasis on the role played by entanglements. Moreover, in a double move, Rebekah's story that is itself initiated by context, uses the argument that context is important and relevant to progress.

The importance of variation and all types to Schreiner's values is corroborated through Darwin's *Variation of Plants and Animals under Domestication* (1868) being the only Darwin (and in fact scientific) book named out of the numerous books in Rebekah's study (*FM* 172).¹⁶⁶ This is emphasised when in her polemic in chapter seven, Rebekah explicitly argues for the importance of all types of people. She wonders whether the 'primitive man individually and structurally as well as socially, may, in some future aeon' have a 'restorative function' in society (*FM* 205), emphasising his value in terms of societal progress. Rebekah reinforces his value when she wonders if there might be in the 'little untaught savage the root out of which ultimately the noblest blossom of the human tree shall draw its strength' (*FM* 197). By representing society as a tree, Rebekah suggests that all types of people potentially contribute to its future progress. To the same end, she also critiques female oppression:

¹⁶⁶ In *The Variation of Animals and Plants under Domestication*, Darwin considers the workings of variation in evolutionary theory. Incidentally, in *From Man to Man*, Schreiner misnames this book, calling it *Variation of Plants and Animals under Domestication* rather than *Variation of Animals and Plants under Domestication*. It is tempting to reflect upon whether this is indicative of the importance she places on plants in *From Man to Man*, but this thought must remain speculative.

What has humanity not lost by the suppression and subjection of the weaker sex [...] we have a Shakespeare; but what of the possible Shakespeares we might have had, who passed their life from youth upward brewing currant wine and making pastries [...] stifled out without one line written [...] what statesmen, what rulers and leaders, what creative intelligences have been lost to humanity' (*FM* 219-20).

She argues that through repressing women society is held back. Moreover, Rebekah does not merely voice female oppression, she enacts it: she is one of the 'creative intelligences' potentially 'lost to humanity'.

As well as using vegetal analogies to articulate her understanding of the importance of all types of peoples, in a reverse move Schreiner also asserts the value of all types of vegetation. Although moss and lichen might be considered insignificant, for Schreiner they carry a weight of meaning and connectivity across *From Man to Man*. In chapter eight, Rebekah collects moss and lichen from a variety of locations to examine under her microscope (*FM* 242). Investigating them leads Rebekah to ponder on the different types of mosses at her childhood farm (*FM*, 243), thereby linking the narrative back to her old home. In the letter to her husband, Rebekah recalls her recent visit to the farm and 'the long moss still hanging from the tree in the kloof' (*FM* 286). Meanwhile, in London, as Bertie's feet sink into the luxurious carpet, it recalls to her the 'moss by the rocks in the kloof' (*FM* 353). I have already noted how Rebekah uses lichen in her polemic to articulate long-term temporality, and in chapter three Schreiner similarly recognises the moss and lichen on the rocks at the old farm that had fallen from the mountain centuries before (*FM* 113). Images of moss and lichen are used then to connect places, time, and ideas across the novel: South Africa and London; Rebekah and Bertie; the contemporary world of the novel and deep time, memories of the old farm and scientific research, contributing to the overall unity of the novel. When Rebekah begins to collect moss and lichen to examine under her microscope it is because 'all the little things of life were of much interest to her again' (*FM* 242). Across the novel, Schreiner shows that lifeforms that might seem unimportant are, in fact, of equal importance to those that could be perceived as of more value.

III. The Plant-like Rebekah

Schreiner uses her main character, Rebekah, to thematically and formally further the connectivity across *From Man to Man*. Rebekah not only voices all the abstract sections and is therefore realist character and contributing writer, but through this structural device she entangles abstract and concrete, and mind and matter. Thematically she links science, feminism and the relations between the sexes, evolutionary theory, societal critique, and creativity. Furthermore, it is through Rebekah that the Prelude is linked to the main book. The Prelude concerns a day in the life of the child Rebekah and in a letter written at a much later date than the first drafts of *From Man to Man*, Schreiner says that she realises that the Prelude is 'a picture in small, a kind of allegory, of the life of the woman in the book!!'.¹⁶⁷ Reading the Prelude we see many of the characteristics of the adult Rebekah in the child: nascent scientific investigations, making up stories about the natural world, and intervening in a predatory scenario.

It is as a theoretical and practical botanist that Rebekah links many themes across the book. Her knowledge enables her to use plant ontology as analogy. I have already noted her observations and experiments on lichen and moss, but she also keeps records on the length of time for germination of the seeds she plants (*FM* 176). She is a practical and skilled gardener and farmer. After she has left her childhood farm, her father missed his 'wise little daughter' as he no longer had anyone 'to advise with over his grafts and flutes' (*FM* 93). On her own farm, it is 'her own hands [that] had planted and grafted trees and vines' (*FM* 156). Mrs Drummond praises her garden in Cape Town as 'she always seems to have more flowers and sweeter smelling than anyone else!' (*FM* 167).

¹⁶⁷ Olive Schreiner, letter to Mrs Frances Smith, October 1909 in *The Letters of Olive Schreiner, 1876-1920*, ed. by S.C. Cronwright-Schreiner (London, T. Fisher Unwin Ltd, 1924), p.291.

Rebekah's life is also entangled with the vegetal in other ways: locationally, botanically, symbolically, and structurally. Her association with mimosa will serve to illustrate. Her childhood farm is surrounded by mimosa. She carries out experiments, collecting gall growths from it 'to see whether the galls on the different species of mimosa are all quite alike, or whether they are different' (*FM* 123). She characterises herself as mimosa, resprouting after damage (*FM* 121-2) (an image I explore in more detail later in this chapter). In one of her stories in the Prelude, mimosa and human seem structurally akin. The child Rebekah opens a mimosa pod and finds that 'there, lying inside it, like the seeds lie inside the pod of a mimosa tree – was a little baby'. When she tries to lift out the baby, she finds that 'it was tied to the pod like the mimosa seeds are, with a little curled-up string' (*FM* 47).

Schreiner also presents Rebekah as gaining shelter and emotional sustenance from trees. Her married home in Cape Town is 'tucked away' and 'buried' among oaks, sheltering her from a judgemental society (*FM* 147). At times of emotional crisis, she finds comfort in these trees. After she discovers her husband with a girl, she runs up the mountain through the woods (*FM* 276), and, after he dismisses her letter, she recognises the 'green and golden glory of the light' through the young oaks (*FM* 300) which enable her to regain a sense of hope.

Trees also inspire Rebekah's thinking, again entangling material context and mind. She tells Mr Drummond that as a child thoughts 'nearly always came' when she would 'lie under a pear tree in the garden' (*FM* 468). They also inspire her writing as an adult: it is under the pine trees that she reconsiders some of the arguments that appear in the polemic. In suggesting that vegetal materiality can affect the mind, Schreiner suggests that the agency that creates Rebekah's thought becomes 'confederate' and Rebekah's polemic can be read as a Bennetian co-production of the entanglement of materiality and mind, problematising human autonomy (JB, 23). Reading through Barad takes us further. Barad claims that

‘existence is not an individual affair. Individuals do not preexist their interactions; rather, individuals emerge through and as part of their entangled intra-relating’ (KB ix). Reading Rebekah through this lens suggests that her self, as revealed in her writing and thinking, is created through these intra-actions. Rebekah ‘emerge[s] through, their intra-action’, further dismissing human autonomy and the notion of a separate self (KB 33).

Rebekah’s entanglements with the vegetal also make her plant-like. Marder maintains that his concept of ‘plant-thinking’ includes the idea that ‘human thinking is, to some extent, de-humanised and rendered plant-like [...] by its encounter with the vegetal world’ (MM 10); to some extent, a comparable argument to Barad’s that intra-actions create new phenomena. Rebekah’s botanical enmeshment engenders in her plant-like characteristics and behaviour. I have already explored how Rebekah entwines theory and practice and, from Marder’s perspective, this makes her plant-like. For Marder, as ‘plant-thinking is plant-doing’, the vegetal eliminates ‘the classical opposition between theory and practice’ (MM 181). In the realist narrative, Rebekah also enacts the theory espoused in the abstract sections. In her polemic, she emphasises the importance of motherhood and nurturing to the survival and development of the young; in her role as mother she enacts this care, even going as far as to adopt the child, Sartje, borne of her husband’s adultery with the servant girl. Likewise, in the polemic, Rebekah critiques how society suppresses women; in the realist narrative she works to overcome this situation. Like Marder’s plant, for Rebekah, thinking is being is doing.

Rebekah’s ethics are also plant-like. Through enacting the values generated by her theory, Rebekah’s ethics and compassion are rooted within an understanding of connectivity and unity. This is shown in the love and service she offers to others, for example, in her care of Sartje. This reflects an understanding of the plant-like indivisibility of life. For Marder, as plant being is collective and has an integral relationship to alterity, it offers an ethical model which negates the boundaries between other and self (MM 52-3). In this sense, Schopenhauer’s philosophy in its relation to ethics is also plant-like. Laurence Wright asserts that as in

Schopenhauer's noumenal world all are related through the will, this is the basis for compassion and altruism. In fact, Wright suggests, these values would not make sense if we were separate beings.¹⁶⁸ The ethical actions of Rebekah spring from her recognition that all are connected and that the boundaries that separate us are negated when life is viewed as a plant-like continuum.

It is useful to read Rebekah as plant-like when exploring her relationship to her environment, particularly in relation to her gender. In the previous chapter, I considered Lyndall's struggle to thrive within a patriarchal environment. I now want to consider if the women in this novel are portrayed as similarly at odds with their environment, particularly as they may be more reliant upon it than the male characters, having less scope for self-determination.

In her visit to her childhood farm in chapter three, Schreiner presents Rebekah as 'like a creature returning to its old habitat and resuming its old instincts and habits' (*FM* 118). Although she is framed as a 'creature', her need for a sustaining environment can be read as plant-like, reliant as plants are on their surroundings. Schreiner suggests that Rebekah's old home, where she was originally rooted, is more conducive to her than is her married home in Cape Town. In her adult study, Rebekah seems to have tried to recreate elements of her childhood home. The wooden cabinet that had held her childhood fossils and insects is transplanted into her adult study, as are all her books and her microscope. She has replanted herself into an environment where she can try to flourish.

In terms of female responses to the environment, it is productive to compare Rebekah and Bertie. As sisters, they can be viewed as two plant modules that have developed from the same plant and yet are different. Bertie's response to adversity (admittedly extreme adversity) is to flee from the scene of the violation and then continue to do so as her

¹⁶⁸ Wright, p.29.

damaged reputation catches up with her. But it does her no good – her life in London is sinister and unsavoury. She fails to re-root herself anywhere. In contrast, Rebekah's response to difficulties is to adapt to her environment and in this respect, she is the more plant-like.

Bertie's relationship with the vegetal is problematic throughout the novel. Her tutor initiates the creation of a wildflower garden in the bush with Bertie, but this is a ruse. It is in this unfamiliar space of the bush, away from her home, that he violates her. Subsequently, the wildflower garden is destroyed, the reader assumes as a response by Bertie. Her subsequent relationships with the vegetal are either overblown or unnatural. After being involved in a conversation with Mrs Drummond about her education and tutor 'there was a stain of red on each cheek deeper than the red of the damask rose in Rebekah's garden' (*FM* 168). In London her associations with the vegetal are artificial: 'the soft double-piled carpet had pink roses in it' (*FM* 353); her fan is illustrated with daisies (*FM* 355); the 'Jew' buys her extravagant 'flowers, lilies and orchids that cost sovereigns a bunch' (*FM* 356); and she names the kittens he buys her after the pictures on their bowls: Holly, Larkspur, and Rose (*FM* 385). Bertie's relationship with the natural vegetal seems broken.

Returning to Rebekah's adaptive response to her environment, it would perhaps be easy to infer that adaptation is a passive strategy, but it is not so, neither is it for plants. Merlin Sheldrake quotes the scientist Barbara McLintock: that plants are 'extraordinary "beyond our wildest expectations" [...] because a life lived rooted to one spot has coaxed them to evolve countless "ingenious mechanisms" to deal with challenges that animals might avoid by simply running away'.¹⁶⁹ Plants also grow in response to their environment as well as contributing to that environment. As Marder writes, 'place dynamically emerges from the

¹⁶⁹ Sheldrake, p.75-6.

plant's living interpretation of and interaction with its environment'.¹⁷⁰ Rather than passivity, plant sessility engenders agency. In this respect, Rebekah's response to her environment is active. She not only adapts to the environment; she attempts to alter it to create a place better suited to her needs. In fact, McLintock's explanation of the differing responses of plants and animals perhaps encapsulates Rebekah and Bertie's contrasting strategies: Bertie as the animal that runs away; Rebekah as the plant that develops 'ingenious mechanisms' in order to survive in that place.

Schreiner shows Rebekah's increasing agency in relation to changing her environment as the novel develops. The turning point comes in chapter eight. Although her husband has refused to read her letter, when she fails to meet him on his return home, he is forced to visit *her* study and forced to perch on the edge of *her* desk. As she passes him a note that explains his options, 'he had an unpleasant sensation as he looked at her that she was growing physically taller and larger at the moment' (*FM* 304). Like a plant, she grows in situ, in her study, as she begins to progress to a more independent and sustaining life.

It is Rebekah's botanical knowledge and farming ability that gives her the capacity for independence. One of her active adaptive responses to Frank's infidelity is the purchase of her own farm. It subsequently 'supplied the household with fruit and vegetables' (*FM* 156) and eventually pays all of Rebekah's expenses, as well as Sartje's (*FM* 444). One of the options she offers to Frank on deciding that their marriage is irretrievable, is that she can be independent because 'I have my farm and I can work' (*FM* p.288). In her letter Rebekah tells of how finding the advertisement for the farm is what saves her, making the emancipatory statement that 'I could not study, and I dared not feel: but I could still [work]; it was my hold on freedom and life; and it has been so to me ever since' (*FM* 283).

¹⁷⁰ Michael Marder, Marder, 'Plant Intentionality and the Phenomenological Framework of Plant Intelligence', *Plant Signalling and Behaviour*, 7.11 (2012), 1365-1370 (p.1367).

Rebekah does not therefore simply adapt to her environment, or context, but changes it. In Baradian terms, rather than simply taking her place in the world, she is involved in 'bringing forth new worlds, of engaging in an ongoing reconfiguring of the world' (KB 170, emphasis in original). Like Marder's plant, in her sessility, she is active. She becomes part of the entangled 'confederation' of agency in the world rather than being passively controlled by externality (JB 23). In this sense, her adaptive entanglements are the equivalent in the realist narrative to the responses of her discursive work to context in the theoretical sections of the novel.

Her progress is also shown in the increasing efficacy of her voice. Although Schreiner's use of form has enabled the reader to hear Rebekah's voice, for much of *From Man to Man* her voice is not heard by the other characters: her polemic is unread and Frank throws away her letter, also unread. But Schreiner grants Rebekah a second opportunity in the penultimate chapter to articulate her conception of an evolutionary continuum and societal progress in the story she tells her children, so it does gain a hearing and potential influence. Then in the final chapter, her meeting with Mr Drummond offers her the intellectual discourse and companionship for which she has been yearning. As he now agrees to deliver one of the fossils she has found to where it might be seen, through him she may finally gain an opportunity to have an impact upon the wider world.

Early in the novel, Rebekah anticipates her own and Bertie's differing responses to adversity through plant analogies, comparing her own resilience and adaptability to the mimosa and Bertie's fragility to the aloe:

Some women with complex, many-sided natures, if love fails them and one half of their nature dies, can still draw a kind of broken life [...] The world of the impersonal is left them: they can still turn fiercely to it, and through the intellect draw in a kind of life – a poor, broken, half-asphyxiated life [...] but still life. But Bertie [...] only one life possible, the life of the personal relations; if that fails them, all fails. If you chop down the stem of a mimosa tree, years after you may come and find from the bottom of the old dead stem sprouts have sprung, which

will even bear flowers [...] but an aloe has one flower, once; if you cut that down, nothing more comes (*FM* 121-2).

As mimosa, Rebekah can survive even in inauspicious circumstances. Bertie, as aloe, has only one chance. For Rebekah, love does indeed fail her, but in this analogy, she underestimates her future self. Rather than living a 'poor, broken, half-asphyxiated life', by the end of the novel, Rebekah, with her 'complex, many-sided nature', has created a richer life than she has predicted. Her plant-like ability for active adaptation means she has grown new 'sprouts' and these 'bear flowers' in the form of her increasing independence and achievement.

In the final chapter of the novel, Rebekah and Mr Drummond discuss two modes of life, framed through the metaphor of being 'hedged'. Their discussion begins with Rebekah's response to Mr Drummond's praise of her garden. She says that 'there's a pleasure [...] if you have a very small space, in seeing how much will live in it', to which Mr Drummond replies:

I've sometimes thought that a life itself might be lived more satisfactorily a little hedged about with narrow conditions which compelled one to expand oneself in that circle – there's such a thing as being dissipated with too large an horizon and too much liberty.

Rebekah counters, 'if the hedges are too close round, they may kill the plants' (*FM* 458-9).

This exchange encapsulates the different environmental conditions within which women and men live. Women's lives are plant-like: they are forced to be sessile and 'hedged', while men's lives are more animal-like with a large 'horizon' and 'liberty'. Although Rebekah points out the difficulties of living a 'hedged' life, her 'narrow conditions' have 'compelled one to expand oneself in that circle', and this describes her adaptive plant-like response to external conditions. Although narrow hedges risk killing the plants, her adaptations demonstrate how her agency has enabled her to 'see how much will live' within the restricted life of a woman.

IV. Lifeforce and Creative Force

In her exploration of two forces that connect and are continuous over time, Schreiner frames Rebekah as a connecting device. Rebekah perceives a natural lifeforce and a creative force, and I argue that these representations share many features in common. She envisages these forces as an energy that connects beings over time, that are manifested in materiality and yet are mysterious and unexplainable. In this part of the chapter, I examine Rebekah's understanding of the lifeforce that she articulates in her polemic, and then move on to consider how, in conversation with Mr Drummond, Rebekah's notion of the creative force shares many corresponding features.

Rebekah's conception of a lifeforce is outlined in her polemic in chapter seven:

between man, plant, bird, beast and clod of earth, everywhere the close internetted lines of interaction stretch; nowhere are we able to draw a sharp dividing line, nowhere find an isolated existence [...] between the life that moved in the creature that ploughed in the mud of the lake-shores three million years ago and the life which beats in my brain and moves in my eyes here in the sunshine today, I can see long unbroken lines of connection. Between spirit that beats within me and body through which it acts, between mind and matter, between man and beast, between beast and plant and plant and earth, between the life that has been and the life that is, I am able to see nowhere a sharp line of severance, but a great, pulsating, always interacting whole. So that at last it comes to be, that, when I hear my own heart beat, I actually hear in it nothing but one throb in that life which has been and is (*FM* 180-1).

There are similarities between this image and Schreiner's representation of 'Universal Unity' (*AF* 290) in *African Farm*. But in this conceptualisation, Schreiner emphasises the connections across life rather than the necessity to find a reason for them. The evolutionary context of the polemic perhaps supplies the rationale. The 'internetted lines of interaction' and 'long unbroken lines of connection' serve to negate 'isolated existence' caused by any 'sharp dividing line', the long sentences reinforcing this point. Schreiner's evolutionary connections across lifeforces displace any notion of human exceptionalism, but, more radically, she also connects 'spirit' and 'body', and 'mind and matter'. In her evocation of the long-term connections across time, with the 'life' in the creature of 'three million years ago'

the same as that in the brain of Rebekah today, she also connects matter and mind across a vast period of time. In fact, Schreiner embeds a further connectivity when we recall that Rebekah has herself uncovered fossils of such ancient creatures.

But Rebekah struggles to fully understand or explain this connecting force, as Schreiner had in *African Farm*. In the polemic she goes on to consider a physiologist who might study a small drop of blood or shred of tissue through a microscope because 'it may turn into the key which may unlock for us the meaning of part of that great universal life of which it is an integral fragment' (*FM* 181). Later in the polemic, she uses the vegetal to consider it. She compares this force with the impact of pruning which she suggests is an 'entirely subsidiary process' that 'fails utterly to account really for the tree, whose essential life and essence lie in its power of growth' which she sees as 'mysterious': the 'fundamental mystery of one bud becoming a flower, for one grain of matter in the soil or particle of gas in the air being transformed into bark, for the kernel, and reality of life' (*FM* 221). Schopenhauer's use of the vegetal can perhaps shed light on Schreiner's own attempt to use it to account for this force. He employs it to consider the 'blind irresistible urge' of the will, as in the plant it is clearly seen unobscured by intellect or consciousness (*WWR1* 275). His interpretation is helpful to an understanding of Rebekah's 'fundamental mystery' as metaphysical, additional to, rather than part of, materiality and therefore out of reach of a full understanding.

In conversation with Mr Drummond in the final chapter, Rebekah returns to her concern about the fact that 'we know nothing' of 'the moving power' in life. She says, 'I wish they gave it a larger name' to which Mr Drummond replies that 'the name circumscribes it' (*FM* 471). One might surmise that this unhelpful name is 'God'. Although Schreiner rejected a conventional Christian faith, in her letters she continues to use the word 'God' to articulate the mysterious force at the heart of life. She writes that 'I have never been able to conceive of God, and man and the material universe as distinct from one another' and that 'if I must put it into words I would say the Universe is one, and it lives:- or if you would put it into older

phraseology, I would say; - there is nothing but God'.¹⁷¹ So although Rebekah perceives a metaphysic at the heart of connectivity, Schreiner is hesitant to use the word 'God' and instead leaves the connecting force unexplained. She can only refer to it as a 'great, pulsating, always interacting whole', characterising it only as an energy or drive.

In chapter thirteen, in a discussion on creativity with Mr Drummond, Rebekah draws attention to the closeness between her understanding of the lifeforce and a creative force that is transmitted through artifacts. Using her small Hercules statue as an example, she states that:

after all these hundreds, perhaps almost thousands, of years it has lain buried, whilst the man, whose being it first lived in, has for ages been Italian dust [...] it has sprung out into life again [...] with the joy, the comprehension of it, that throbbed in his brain when he saw it, beating here again in mine (*FM* 475).

Although the artist himself is dead, the artwork he has created has the capacity to communicate to Rebekah, over innumerable years, something of the 'being it first lived in'. This seems analogous to the lifeforce, manifested in materiality but an additional force; the likeness emphasised through the statue bearing resemblance to a buried fossil in which the lifeforce had once existed. Through her re-use of the word 'throb' and the link between the creator's brain and hers, Rebekah calls further attention to the similarity to her earlier description of the lifeforce.

Rebekah asserts that this force engenders in the artist an imperative to create. His 'will is bound' and there is a 'restless pressure which *forces* him [...] to his work' (*FM* 472, emphasis in original). Through comparing this imperative to the bee, Schreiner allies the force in the artist and in nature. The bee 'makes her perfect polygonal cell in the first year of her life' and 'if you ask her why, she says she must – it is so, that's all!'. For the bee 'her whole cell is

¹⁷¹ Olive Schreiner, letter to John T Lloyd, 29th October 1892, Schreiner's emphasis, <https://oliveschreiner.org> [accessed 25th February 2023]

meaningless unless you realise the storing of the honey and the bees that have yet to be born whom she has never seen' (*FM* 470). The bee works, even though unknowingly, for the continuity of the species, and Rebekah suggests that the internal impetus that compels the artist to create, makes him part of an analogous continuity.

Schopenhauer is useful for understanding Schreiner's explanation of the relationship between artist and life-force. He contends that in the artist, rather than the will operating to support the survival of the individual, the intellect is in service to the universal will. As Helen Zimmern explains, in the artist, there is a kind of 'self-annihilation'. This characterises how Schreiner's artistic force compels the artist to 'defy their reason' and create. Like the bee, the artist is in service to the force. Moreover, when Rebekah suggests to Mr Drummond that the artist is one 'in whom some of the accumulated life of his race [...] is stored', she argues that the artist has access to a collective understanding. This also reflects a Schopenhauerian understanding. For Schopenhauer, in the artist 'the veil of Maya is rent'. He can access the universal will and is 'no longer under the illusion that hinders him from recognising himself in all other existence'.¹⁷² For Schreiner, the artist is 'an eye in the great human body', being one who can offer this vision of 'the great body of life' to others (*FM* 470-6).

Like the life force, Rebekah suggests that the creative force has a mysterious source. Although it is manifested within the material, both Rebekah and Mr Drummond suggest that it has an external source. In relation to his writing, Mr Drummond says that 'all the pictures in the thing ran out before me with a flash one after the other [...] It was exactly as though someone quite external to myself had shown them me suddenly'. Rebekah claims that it arrives from 'something beyond ourselves' (*FM* 467), and that although it is 'made of the man's substance [...] yet he feels in a way that it is something not himself but shown to him'

¹⁷² Zimmern, p.229.

(FM 471). This bears relation to Rebekah's conceptualisation of the vegetal's mysterious compulsion to grow. In neither does reason or the self intervene.

As well as the Hercules statue, Schreiner suggests that books transmit the mind of their creators over time. Looking at the books in her study, Rebekah sees that 'behind each was hidden the mind of some human creature which at some time had touched her own' (FM 175), and when Rebekah reads a book written by an Ancient Greek composed 'two thousand years' ago, she surmises that 'it might have been composed this morning' (FM 177). She suggests that books overcome the limited temporality of the individual mind, as Waldo had experienced in *African Farm*.

In *African Farm*, Schreiner considered the materiality of books. She also does this in *From Man to Man* but extends this through allying their materiality to the progress of humanity. In the story to her children in chapter twelve, as part of her attempt to explain to them the debt they owe to the past so that they don't behave like the little ant on the ant-heap, Rebekah explains how essential books have been in the development of humanity. Books, she tells them, had been 'sometimes written on stone tables, sometimes on mud tablets, sometimes on leaves or bark or skin' and that they contain 'the thought and knowledge of mankind [that] might be stored and each generation begin where the last left off'. She emphasises the importance of the matter from which books have been made and asserts that it is this that has enabled humanity to store and pass on 'thought and knowledge'. Through the entanglement of mind and matter, materiality participates and contributes to the development of 'civilisation' (FM 427).

Rebekah further extends her notion of the dependence of humanity's progress on materiality by allying books and the development of writing to the material evolutionary processes of deep time:

If I tear one sheet of paper out of this little book and there were some being wise enough to tell me its whole story, with all the lines and dots and marks upon it, and what they mean and how they came to be, and how the leaf itself came into being, the whole story of the human race on earth would have to be told me (*FM* 430).

Through describing writing as 'lines and dots and marks', Rebekah represents it as concrete before it has useful meaning. Extending this materiality further back, to 'how the leaf itself came into being', shows human progress to be dependent upon a materiality that is older than humanity itself. Human development becomes positioned within an evolutionary timescale and dependent upon non-human lifeforms. Rebekah works to ensure that her children are under no illusions about their own, or human, autonomy in relation to the development of civilisation.

Schreiner extends her focus on the reliance of humanity upon materiality by connecting books to metaphorical roots: 'This little book! – this little book! – it has got its roots down, down, deep in the life of man on earth; it grows from there' (*FM* 430). Schreiner links books, and therefore humanity, to vegetal growth processes that are fixed within the earth. The metaphor encourages us to read 'earth' as both planet and soil, embedding humanity's history within the darkness of the earth, rather than in the ideal sphere of the heavens. Marder points out that Western metaphysics begins with the '*inversion of the earthly perspective of the plant* [...]' and the correlative devaluation of the literal plant' and contends that a vegetal perspective challenges this view (*MM* 57-59, emphasis in original). I read Schreiner here as suggesting that the entanglement of humankind's progress and materiality means that we, like the vegetal, are earth-bound life-forms.

From Man to Man is itself an artwork and can therefore manifest Schreiner's notion that through materiality, art can transcend its time. In talking to Mr Drummond Rebekah states that:

ages ago in Ancient Chaldea there might have been some thinker whose thought seemed to have no relation to the men about him [...] yet, recorded on a mud tablet and preserved through the years and coming to the light today, it might be found most closely connected with our needs and new life, might find its own here today and live again, though the man who made it might be forgotten (*FM* 476).

Through *From Man to Man*, something of the mind of Schreiner is transmitted to us today, perhaps finding new resonances in the twenty-first century. She suspects that the man himself who recorded his thoughts on the mud tablet might be forgotten; my hope is that Schreiner herself is not.

Chapter Six - The Continuous Collective Body of Humanity in Schreiner's Contemporary Allegories

the past is dead, it lives only for us to learn. The present, the present only, is ours to work in, and the future ours to create.

(Olive Schreiner, *Trooper Peter Halket*, p.37)

it grew so bright I could not see things separately; and which were God, or the man, or I, I could not tell; we were all blended.

(Olive Schreiner, *Dreams*, p.119)

Schreiner frequently turned to the allegory form to convey her ideas. In this chapter I explore her use of this form and go on to consider three of her allegories in more detail. I have already considered the Hunter allegory embedded in *African Farm* and elements of Rebekah's allegories in *From Man to Man*, but I now turn to the separately published allegories. Two collections of her allegories were published in her lifetime: *Dreams* (1890), and *Dream Life and Real Life* (1893). A further collection, *Stories, Dreams, and Allegories*, was published posthumously in 1923. Schreiner also wrote an allegorical novella, *Trooper Peter Halket of Mashonaland* (1897) (hereafter *Trooper Peter*) which I consider in this chapter. Although allegory is a long-established literary form, Schreiner re-purposes it to critique aspects of the contemporary world, namely patriarchal, capitalist, and colonialist hegemonies, to offer alternative ways of living, and inspire readers to contribute to change.

In this chapter I argue that the allegory form allows Schreiner to straddle narrative and abstract forms, as she does throughout her work, and it enables her to express her ideas without the need for many narrative contingencies. I assert that through this form she can clearly articulate her notion of the importance of the collective in relation to the individual, characterising humanity as a continuous collective body. To examine this body, I conceptualise it as bearing resemblance to the long-term continuous vegetal body and consider how she locates meaning in this body and in the individual's contribution to its

progress. The ethics this engenders is collective and reading this through the vegetal, I establish the similarity of vegetal ethics to other relationship-based ethical systems. Through this long-term body of humanity, Schreiner merges the material and the metaphysical, corporeality and the ideal, both within humanity and in the new world that is created.

In what follows I begin by exploring Schreiner's use of the allegory form to express her collective vision. I then examine three of her allegories in detail. In Part I, I read Schreiner's evocation of the struggle for female freedom in 'Three Dreams in a Desert' through her presentation of womankind as a vegetal-like continuous body, that links past, present, and future, and that, through struggle, creates a new future. I contend that she situates meaning within the collective continuous body of womankind and that individual sacrifice and struggle becomes meaningful in relation to that body. I further argue that she roots enlightenment in a merging of the corporeal and the spiritual. In Part II, my analysis of 'The Sunlight Lay Across My Bed' focuses upon Schreiner's representation of light as corporeal. I assert that through locating transcendence within the body, she portrays humanity as non-dualistic and a participant within an ecological web of creation. I consider how her critique of capitalism centres on its notion of the separate individual and how she contrasts this to a socialist Heaven in which all is interconnected. Finally, in Part III, I interrogate the allegorical novella, *Trooper Peter* through exploring how Schreiner's collective ethics are rooted in her portrayal of the long-term nature of Christ's kingdom. My analysis reveals the similarity between vegetal, gospel, and Schopenhauerian ethics, in their acceptance of difference. I demonstrate how in this allegory Schreiner asserts the importance of manifesting these ethical values in the here and now. I also examine her use of a tree as symbol of connectedness and a future South Africa, in which black and white peoples are integrated.

One might ask why Schreiner refers to these pieces of writing as 'dreams', even using this as the title of her first collection. She uses this term in some of the titles: 'Three Dreams in a Desert', 'A Dream of Wild Bees', and in many of them the allegory is framed through a

dream. This reflects the fact that many of them seem to come to her in the form of dreams, visions, or flashes of inspiration. She explains in a letter that she has been 'writing out a dream',¹⁷³ and that the Prelude of *From Man to Man*, (that she later refers to as an allegory) 'in an instant [...] *flashed* on me'.¹⁷⁴ Indeed, throughout her life she seems to have experienced mystical experiences, visions, or dreams. It is in writing them out that she calls them allegories, referring to *Dreams* as 'my allegory book'.¹⁷⁵ I suggest that in the allegory form she finds a mode that facilitates the expression of these dreams or visions.

Growing up in a Protestant missionary household, Schreiner would have been aware of the tradition of allegorical extra-biblical writings and interpretations, such as Bunyan's *The Pilgrim's Progress* (1678). In her allegories she follows Bunyan in her use of biblical imagery and rhythms, and the inclusion of biblical quotations or paraphrasing. Her use of dream framing and everyman-type characters who learn from wiser interlocutors is also Bunyanesque. I argue that using such allegorical features and tropes allows her to work within the narrative form but without the need to develop individual characters. In the previous two chapters I explored how Schreiner problematises individuality within the novel form. I suggest that in allegory she finds a form that gives her capacity to focus on the collective rather than the individual. Characters are instead everyman/everywoman-type figures. The allegory form enables her to situate her contemporary societal critique within a wider tradition that embraces a spiritual and ethical universality. It also releases her from the delimited temporality and spatiality necessary to other narrative forms. In fact, it is this wider temporal and spatial framework that she uses in the abstract sections of *African Farm* and *From Man to Man* to leave behind the exigencies and limitations of the novel form to create a wider vision. This places her contemporary societal critique within a wider framework of

¹⁷³ Olive Schreiner, letter to Havelock Ellis, 21st Nov 1887, <https://oliveschreiner.org> [accessed 25th February 2023].

¹⁷⁴ Olive Schreiner, letter to Mrs Francis Smith, October 1909 in *The Letters of Olive Schreiner, 1876-1920*, ed. by S.C. Cronwright-Schreiner (London, T. Fisher Unwin Ltd, 1924) p.291, emphasis in original.

¹⁷⁵ Olive Schreiner, letter to William Philip Schreiner, Sept 1891. <https://oliveschreiner.org> [accessed 30th March 2023].

progress, viewing individual struggle as part of humanity's continuous fight against hierarchical power structures.

Allegorical form also facilitates Schreiner to explore abstract ideas within an engaging narrative structure. In her introduction to *Woman and Labour* (1911), Schreiner states that 'while it is easy clearly to express abstract thoughts in argumentative prose, whatever emotion those thoughts awaken I have not felt myself able adequately to express except in the other form', this 'other form' being allegory.¹⁷⁶ Schreiner implies that emotional engagement is necessary to fully make her arguments. In the allegoric form she finds a way to engage readers in her analysis of contemporary issues and to embed her call for change.

I conceptualise Schreiner's portrayal of humanity in the allegories as a continuous and progressive historical body. Although in many ways this is similar to the portrayal of humanity in *African Farm* and *From Man to Man*, in the allegories she is able to foreground and extend this perspective as the form absolves her from the necessity to develop individual characters, situate meaning in the individual consciousness, or represent progress within the small scale. Using the lens of Marder, I read this continuous body and its associated collective ethics, adaptive strategies, and non-dualist ontology as bearing affinity with a vegetal mode of being. I also read Schreiner's own use of the vegetal in these allegories as symbolic of the continuous body of humanity.

Not only does Schreiner situate progress in this continuous body but also meaning. Marder extends his conceptualisation of vegetal growth as a spatial encoding of time through his assertion that the 'meaning of vegetal being is time' (MM 95). Applying such a perspective to Schreiner's humanity suggests that human meaning and purpose is located within the continuous body. Rather than meaning derived from individual existence or existential

¹⁷⁶ Olive Schreiner, *Woman and Labour* (London, Virago Ltd, 1978), p.16.

search, for Schreiner meaning comes from the individual's relationship to that body and their contribution, often through struggle or even sacrifice, to humanity's shared progress. This is illustrated at the end of the 'The Hunter' allegory (published as part of *African Farm* and re-published in *Dreams*) where, after spending much of his life cutting steps in the mountain for others to reach 'Truth', the hunter realises that 'where I lie down worn out, other men will stand [...] by the steps I have cut they will climb' (D 73).

Her emphasis on the importance of the collective embeds an ethics based on responsibility towards others. Across the allegories she advocates the importance of an ethical responsibility towards others as a way of working together to create a better future. She contrasts this stance to one of egoic individualism upon which are predicated, she contends, capitalist and colonialist ideologies. In fact, in response to her publisher's plan to publish a cheap edition of *Dreams*, she states 'If I dedicated it to the public for whom I intended it, I should dedicate it ("To all Capitalists Millionaires and Middle-men [...] and all high and mighty persons")', making clear that her societal critique is aimed at the values of the powerful who maintain hierarchical hegemonies.¹⁷⁷

For Schreiner, otherness is reconceptualised as unity that extends to the non-human. Reading her collective ethics through the perspectives of Schopenhauer, Marder, and Barad draws attention to how in the negation of individuality, they all extend their philosophies to purport an ethics based on connection. Schopenhauer contends that it is only in the phenomenal that separate individuals are perceived whereas in the noumenal all are connected. Marder views a 'vegetal democracy of sharing and participation' (MM 52) with vegetal beings problematising the binary between individual and whole. Barad asserts that her notion that individuals emerge from intra-actions rather than preceding them means that we 'are always already responsible to the others with whom or which we are entangled' (KB

¹⁷⁷ Olive Schreiner, letter to T. Fisher Unwin, 26th Sept 1892, <https://oliveschreiner.org> [accessed 24th January 2022].

393). Furthermore, in *Trooper Peter*, Schreiner's portrayal of Christ's kingdom embraces a similar stance.

As in her other work, in the allegories Schreiner evinces a non-dualistic understanding of humanity in which mind and body merge. The body therefore becomes an integral part of progress, sacrifice, and unity. In their introduction to the Broadview Press edition of *Dreams* (2020), Barbara Black, Carly Nations, and Anna Spydell suggest that 'just as allegory conjoins the literal and the symbolic, the work feels simultaneously embodied and disembodied [...] the continual drifting from sleep to wakefulness suggests a world that is separate, yet intricately connected to our own'¹⁷⁸ Schreiner uses embodiment to link the framing dreamer/narrator to the dream itself in both 'Three Dreams' and 'Sunlight Lay', but I extend this understanding of Schreiner's use of embodiment. I argue that through it is through placing importance on the corporeality of her characters, that she extends allegory from itself. It is the bodies of the women fighting against subjugation in 'Three Dreams' that must suffer. In 'Sunlight Lay' it is human bodies that enable participation in the whole ecosystem. Furthermore, in both these allegories, by embodying enlightenment itself, Schreiner undermines any notion of a dualistic separation between physical and mental spheres. My vegetal approach to these allegories offers a useful perspective in this respect in that it models a form of life that is inherently non-dualistic, having no separate inner sphere, and in which, at least for Marder, meaning and even thinking can be situated in the material.

For Schreiner, the ideal of the future is concrete and must be established on earth. Her allegories can be read as a 'call to arms', demonstrating the need for action in the material reality of the present to lead to an ideal future that is also located within the tangible, rather

¹⁷⁸ Olive Schreiner, *Dreams*, ed. by Barbara Black, Carly Nations, and Anna Spydell (Peterborough (Ontario), Broadview Press, 2020), p.47.

than noumenal, world. In 'Three Dreams' the future 'Land of Freedom' is 'heaven' on 'earth' (D 84-5). The dreamer/narrator of 'Sunlight Lay' must return to the real world from Heaven to put into action what he has learnt in his journey through Hell and Heaven. In *Trooper Peter*, Peter Halket converts his newly found Christian beliefs into action to attempt to affect change for the South Africa of the future. As such, Schreiner articulates a sense of responsibility to participate in creating a better future for humanity.

Her use of the allegory form means that she embeds her message in a form that can transcend the moment and speak to the future. Indeed, inherent in the allegorical form is the idea that it contains a greater meaning than the immediate situation it narrates. The dedication in the original edition of *Dreams* is 'to a small girl-child, who may live to grasp somewhat of that which for us is yet sight, not touch' (D 57). These allegories are indicative of her writing as part of a wider project which, alongside her political activism in causes such as women's suffrage, racial equality, and the creation of a more equitable society, participates in striving for a more just society.

I. 'Three Dreams in a Desert: Under a Mimosa-Tree': The female body as route to enlightenment

'Three Dreams in a Desert: Under a Mimosa-Tree' (hereafter 'Three Dreams') is an allegory about womankind's struggle for emancipation within a patriarchal society. In this allegory the narrator, falling asleep under a mimosa-tree, has three dreams, which represent the past, present, and future respectively of womankind. In the first dream the narrator sees two huge immobile figures in the sands of the desert. The woman figure lays on the sand, subjugated by the 'Age-of-dominion-of-muscular-force', the 'burden of subjection' and the band of 'Inevitable Necessity'. In the second dream, a woman, who is now mobile, asks the figure of 'Reason' how to get to the distant 'Land of Freedom'. He tells her that she must struggle 'down the banks of Labour' and 'through the water of Suffering', and that any ensuing

individual sacrifice will contribute to the eventual emancipation of women and the freedom of the entire human race. In the final dream, 'heaven [...] On earth' is reached.

It is therefore an allegory of female progress. Jacqueline de Vries suggests that nineteenth-century feminists 'believed their movement paralleled other great evolutionary trends in history' and was seen as part of a 'teleological story of cumulative progress'.¹⁷⁹ In 'Three Dreams', Schreiner represents the female journey as part of a wider journey of human progress. She not only places it within a framework of deep time but also shows female struggle as benefitting humankind as a whole.

In this allegory, Schreiner presents womankind's cause as having resonance with a spiritualised journey. Womankind needs to move out of the desert, through the 'water of Suffering', wearing only 'one white garment' (*D* 82-3) to lead on and eventually arrive at 'heaven' (*D* 85). These and other religious tropes are reflective of, as Rose Lovell-Smith suggests, 'the link between religion and political activism' for feminists at the turn of the century.¹⁸⁰ de Vries asserts that Suffragettes themselves 'harnessed a distinctive feminist spirituality' in their campaigns. She argues that they 'fashioned militancy as a spiritual quest', and co-opted 'religious language, symbols and ideas'.¹⁸¹ Although this allegory could be read as secular in terms of its context and aims, Schreiner brings into play religious tropes to embed the necessary struggle and progress within a wider quest for meaning and purpose.

If the Suffragettes responded to the religious undertones of 'Three Dreams', they also recognised its contemporary concrete reality. Constance Lytton, writing about the reading of this allegory by Suffragettes in Holloway prison, states that it 'seemed scarcely an allegory.

¹⁷⁹ Jacqueline de Vries, 'More than paradoxes to offer: Feminism, history and religious cultures', in *Women, Gender and Religious Cultures in Britain, 1800-1940*, ed. by Sue Morgan and Jacqueline de Vries (London, Routledge, 2010), pp.188-210 (p.190).

¹⁸⁰ Rose Lovell-Smith, 'Science and Religion in the Feminist Fin-de-Siècle and a New Reading of Olive Schreiner's *From Man to Man*', *Victorian Literature and Culture*, 29(2) (2001), 303-326 (p.308).

¹⁸¹ de Vries, p.199.

The words hit out a bare literal description of the pilgrimage of women. It fell on our ears more like an ABC railway guide to our journey than a figurative parable'.¹⁸² As well as reading it as allied to a spiritual 'pilgrimage', through describing it as analogous to the 'ABC railway guide', she also finds in it a materialised reality. Moreover, it is not surprising that the Suffragettes found resonance in this allegory. Schreiner situates the late nineteenth-century struggle for female emancipation within a longer-term context of women's fight for freedom and self-determination. The first dream reflects the situation they are working to defeat, and the second, their own struggles. The optimistic portrayal of the future in the third dream would have provided some motivation to them to continue their fight while suffering from their prison privations.

I argue that the mimosa-tree of the title is both allegoric symbol and literal part of the framing. It is underneath the mimosa that the narrator shelters from the African sun and experiences the three dreams. But Schreiner's inclusion of the mimosa-tree in the title of the allegory is suggestive of a greater importance. I offer a reading in which the mimosa-tree gestures towards the Bodhi tree underneath which the Buddha experienced his awakening. Through the allusion to the Bodhi tree, Schreiner incorporates another signifier of the spiritual into her allegory. For the narrator/dreamer, the visionary awakening is spiritualised and yet what is learnt must be realised in the world of the real, as the Buddha's own awakening was transformed into action.

Reflective of other uses of trees in religion and myth, Schreiner's mimosa-tree is a symbol of continuous growth, echoing her use of the mimosa to represent Rebekah's continuous regeneration and resilience in *From Man to Man* (see p.192-3). The vegetal's spatial expression of its continuous growth means that it can bear the past in its 'extended being'

¹⁸² Constance Lytton, *Prisons and Prisoners, Some Personal Experiences* (London, William Heinemann, 1914) (repr. in *Dreams*, ed. by Barbara Black, Carly Nations, and Anna Spydell (Peterborough (Ontario), Broadview Press, 2020)), p.138.

(MM 155) and is therefore a spatial expression of time (MM 96). From this perspective, Schreiner's mimosa-tree becomes an embodiment of time, and the narrator shelters within this continuity of time. It enables the narrator to experience time itself and to perceive the history of womankind as continuous and progressive.

Marder's extension of vegetal spatiality into meaning or purpose – 'vegetal life is laden with meaning in all its spatiality, materiality, and finitude' (MM 76) - is a useful approach for considering Schreiner's presentation of collective womankind. If Schreiner's collective continuous body of humanity is read as ontologically vegetal, then meaning and purpose can be located within it. Progress, created through continuous struggle, is that of the whole body. For each individual who contributes to this progress, meaning adheres to their contribution to the long-term emancipatory achievement.

The struggle is portrayed in the second dream. The woman enquires of 'Reason' how to cross the river to journey to the 'Land of Freedom'. There is neither a bridge nor a track. 'Reason' explains that these need to be created, and uses the analogy of locusts crossing a stream:

first one comes down to the water-edge, and it is swept away, and then another comes and then another, and then another, and at last with their bodies piled up a bridge is built and the rest pass over (*D* 84).

Schreiner suggests that the body of the individual that must be sacrificed in aid of progress is of no more importance than the individual locust who dies for the sake of the swarm. Like the modules of a plant that are continuously lost – leaves, shoots - their contribution might even be forgotten, as the locusts who are swept away and might not even have contributed to the bridge, 'are heard of no more' (*D* 85), and yet their lives have meaning in relation to that contribution. Reading this through Schopenhauer's notion that viewing individuals as separate phenomena is illusory as in the noumenal we are all connected by the will, suggests that the sacrifice of the individual in favour of the whole body of humanity is

reasonable. Schreiner's use of the symbolic and unnamed figures of allegory to represent these anonymous women further elevates the meaningfulness of their lives.

Through her use of a long-term temporality, Schreiner implies that female subjugation is aberrant in that it breaks the natural continuity of progress. Such natural continuous progression is symbolised by the mimosa-tree and echoed in the progress of the sun across the sky as the dreams progress. It is also reflected in Schreiner's own note that clarifies that the steep banks of the river are caused by 'the course of ages the river has worn its gigantic bed' (*D* 82). In contrast to these natural progressions, womankind's progress has reversed. In the first dream, 'woman' has been laying in the sand for so long that 'the oldest, oldest, oldest man living has never seen her move' and 'the oldest, oldest book records that she lay here. But by extending the temporality back further: before then 'are found the marks of her footsteps' and these are 'side by side with his' as she 'once wandered free [...] with him' (*D* 79), Schreiner shows women's previous freedom and equality with men. Her immobile state is presented as an unnatural interruption and her subjugation politically and deliberately motivated rather than an 'Inevitable Necessity' (*D* 80).

But in showing that man had agency in his subjugation of women, Schreiner also asserts human agency per se, suggesting that women must use their agency to liberate themselves and create a different future. This allegory bears some resemblance to the 'Spirit of the Ages' allegory in *From Man to Man* (*FM* 223-5).¹⁸³ In that allegory, the 'Spirit of the Ages' tells a woman who represents 'Humanity' and is immobile in the desert, and who blames an anonymous 'they' for her plight, that 'no deliverer will ever come. You, you, yourself must save yourself' (*FM* 224).

¹⁸³ In *From Man to Man*, after writing the 'Spirit of the Ages' allegory, Rebekah puts it away in a drawer but wonders if 'some day the little allegory would enlarge itself and she would write it in fit words to make others see the picture'. She expects not but also notes that 'the little picture she would never forget'. I suggest that on a meta-level this allegory does become enlarged and that 'Three Dreams in a Desert' is its development.

In 'Three Dreams', as Schreiner locates the agency to progress within corporeality, I approach it through a New Materialist lens. Barad suggests that through agential matter, the world can be created or reconfigured. For Barad, 'matter's dynamism is generative [...] in the sense of bringing forth new worlds [...] Bodies do not simply take their places in the world' (KB 170). From this perspective, it is through the continuous temporal body that a new 'temporality and spatiality can emerge in this processual historicity' (KB 141). Read in this way, the new world that humankind arrives at in the third dream has been created rather than reached. In the second dream, the woman only 'thinks' she sees 'trees and hills' in the distance; in the final dream, they have made those hills a reality.

Schreiner suggests that such struggle is essential for growth and progress. No one will give woman freedom. Instead, '*she must help herself*. Let her struggle till she is strong' (*D*, 81, emphasis in original). In this respect, Schreiner likens womankind to the vegetal who must continually struggle to adapt and grow and will die if does not do so.¹⁸⁴ Moreover, it is this adaptability of the mimosa that Rebekah recognises in *From Man to Man* (see p.191-2), suggesting womankind's adaptability through struggle is also represented in the framing mimosa. In contrast, in the motionless woman of the first dream, Schreiner suggests that plant-like sessility is unnatural in that she has relinquished many of the characteristics that make her human. Described by the narrator as a 'creature' with her legs 'crushed under her', she is prone rather than an upstanding biped and her inability to raise her neck to see implies a loss of cerebral capacity (*D* 79-81). Her passivity represents the lack of agency of the woman who does not struggle to create progress.

Schreiner also foregrounds the importance of corporeality by entwining progress towards enlightenment with embodiment, countering dualistic notions of the separation of mind or spirit, and body. At the end of the first dream, woman gains enlightenment in association

¹⁸⁴ Hallé, p.97.

with regained embodiment. Once the burden has been removed from her, her body 'quivered, and a light came into her eyes' as 'a thought has come to her'. She 'raised her head' and when there is 'light in her eyes' the 'creature staggered onto its knees' (D 81-2). By the second dream, woman has become upright and mobile. Schreiner reinstates the body as an integral element of humanity and humanity's progress. As such, hers is a radical feminist reworking of the Puritan allegory of Bunyan, which demotes the body, particularly the female body. For Schreiner, it is female bodies that create the bridge over which will pass the 'entire human race' (D 85) to get to the 'Land of Freedom'.

In the final dream, the land that has been created is one of unitedness: male and female, real and ideal. Woman and man now walk 'hand in hand' (D 85). This bears similarity to their relationship before the interruption of the 'Age-of-muscular-force', when their footsteps were 'side by side' and they 'wandered free' together (D 79). Normal progress has been resumed, and the material and ideal united. Schreiner inserts no interruption to progress through a move to the purely spiritual realm, but 'heaven' is created 'on earth' (D 85) and the spiritual continuous with the tangible. As woman in the first dream finds no place in heaven or earth for her, looking 'at the earth, and at the sky, and knew there was no hope for her' (D 81), through struggle and sacrifice, humankind's existence in the future combines these two realms in an image of utopian unity.

II. 'The Sunlight Lay Across My Bed,-': from darkness into light

In 'The Sunlight Lay Across My Bed' (hereafter 'Sunlight Lay') Schreiner allegorises the contrasting ethics of capitalist and socialist societies. It was originally published in *The New Review* in two parts, in April and May 1890, the first part headed 'Hell' and the second 'Heaven', such a division emphasising the two contrasting societies portrayed.

Subsequently, it was published as part of the collected allegories, *Dreams*, in November 1890.

In this allegory the narrator dreams that God takes his soul to visit the capitalist society of Hell. In this hierarchical society, those with most power feast on the blood produced by crushing the bodies of the oppressed in a wine-press. In a second dream, God takes the narrator to three levels of a socialistic Heaven respectively. In the first Heaven, humans are a source of light that is shared for the benefit of all, including the non-human. In the second and third Heavens, the increasing light enables the narrator to perceive a world in which all things are one. At the end, the narrator returns to the world of reality with an altered perspective. I argue that although the allegory is set in the divine spheres of Hell and Heaven, corporeality remains important.

In 'Sunlight Lay' Schreiner further extends her notion of the non-dualistic nature of humanity. In 'Three Dreams', the non-dualistic representation of corporeality is one in which mind and body together become aware and engender progress. However, in 'Sunlight Lay', Schreiner is more radical in that she locates transcendence itself within the body. In the first Heaven, humans emit a light that is corporeal: 'all their body gives the light; they dare not cover any part' (*D* 113). Rather than situated in a separate mental or spiritual sphere, the light is spread across the whole physical body. Viewing this through the lens of Marder suggests that Schreiner gestures here towards a vegetal-like humanity. For Marder, a major contrast between humanity and the vegetal, is the human possession of a separate interiority. In contrast, the vegetal is pure exteriority and the human body in 'Sunlight Lay' seems to have some similarity to this. Furthermore, for Marder, the vegetal is a living critique of the dualistic separation between soul and body, and depth and surface (*MM* 11). Through locating the transcendent light within corporeality, Schreiner diametrically opposes dualistic notions of humanity and reformulates humanity's transcendental nature as embodied.

Marder maintains that the materiality and non-conscious existence of plants is devalued in Western thinking, but in this allegory, Schreiner promotes the importance of corporeality and

reasserts humanity's roots within material existence. In *Return of the Native*, Hardy presents abstract mental light as at odds with the materiality of the body. Schreiner's model of humanity is one in which materiality and a transcendent light are not mutually antagonistic. Such a perspective bears resemblance to her models of connectivity in *African Farm* and *From Man to Man* in which materiality and metaphysics are mutually entwined.

Such corporeality also embeds humanity within the world of all beings. Rather than being separated through the possession of interiority, Schreiner's humankind participates within the ecological web of all beings. Through emitting light, humanity provides the energy for plants upon which the ecosystem runs, even replacing the sun. The narrator, noticing the increasing brightness, asks God 'if the sun were not going to rise', and God replies 'no; we are coming to where the people are'; it is humanity's light that is 'shining on the plants that they may grow' (D 113).

Reading in a less materialised and more symbolic mode, the light of humanity enables humankind to become one with all other lifeforms as they share the light of the spirit. Such a representation of the divine in nature is an incarnational understanding. In *Victorian Parables* (2012), Susan Colon draws on Rebecca Styler's understanding that for Victorian literary women there are 'wider tendencies towards an "incarnational" Christianity', in which the division between secular and sacred is blurred'.¹⁸⁵ I read Schreiner's suggestion that through humanity's sharing of their corporeal light, all creation is enabled to participate in the light of transcendence, as both incarnational and material. The light is divine but located in the materiality of the human who has attained a heavenly non-egoic largesse. This bears some relation to Emma Mason's understanding of Christina Rossetti's notion of grace. Mason suggests that for Rossetti, through grace, human life could "expand" and 'welcome God

¹⁸⁵ Susan E. Colon, *Victorian Parables* (London, Continuum, 2012), p.32.

back into the world'.¹⁸⁶ However, as for Schreiner it is the corporeality of the human that enables this light to expand into the world, she roots this transcendence more overtly in materiality.

Schreiner represents light as that which reveals a perception of the unity of all things: human and non-human, organic and inorganic. As Schreiner's narrator passes up through the levels of the Heavens, he is increasingly able to perceive himself as part of a unity. In the first Heaven, the sharing of the light creates a connection between everything. In the second Heaven, light reveals an underlying pattern behind phenomenal reality. Then in the highest Heaven the light shows the narrator a oneness across everything: 'it grew so bright I could not see things separately; and which were God, or the man, or I, I could not tell; we were all blended' (*D* 119). The narrator sees the noumenal unity behind the world of phenomena. Mason suggests that for Christina Rossetti, in a state of grace humanity can 'perceive itself as one in a participatory and interdependent body that is at once material and also divine'.¹⁸⁷ In 'Sunlight Lay', God allows the narrator to catch a glimpse of his own participation in such a unity in the world of the divine, but this is momentary. Once it is dark again, he resumes the recognition of things as separate. He must return to Earth to learn to recognise unity in materiality as he is not yet in a state of grace.

Such an underlying unity makes sense of the sharing paradigm in Heaven. For Schopenhauer, our notion of separate beings is a misunderstanding as in the noumenal all beings are connected. He asserts that 'genuine virtue' can only come from the 'intuitive knowledge that recognises in another's individuality the same inner nature as in one's own' (*WWR1* 367-8). Schreiner shows people in Heaven acting upon such an understanding. In the first Heaven, people touch the 'maimed stumps' of 'our brother', a disabled man, and

¹⁸⁶ Emma Mason, 'Praying Kin: Christina Rossetti and the Unity of Things', in *Anticipatory Materialisms in Literature and Philosophy: 1790-1930*, ed. by Jo Carruthers, Nour Dakkak, Rebecca Spence (Cham, Palgrave MacMillan, 2019), pp.169-182 (p.173-4).

¹⁸⁷ Mason, p.174.

their light enables these stumps to 'shine brighter than anything in Heaven'. In the second Heaven, the men who are labouring to dig up stones, share their finds: 'when one found a stone he passed it on to his fellow, and he to another, and he to another. No man kept the stone he found' (*D* 115-6).

Schreiner contrasts Heaven and Hell through differing conceptions of the relationship between people. In the light of Heaven there is a recognition of oneness: in the darkness of Hell, an awareness of separation. This creates, in Hell, an egoic mode of being, predicated upon viewing fellow inhabitants as other. In Heaven, as for the plant which incorporates difference within itself, difference is positive and strengthening rather than a deficiency. In Hell, otherness is represented through the positioning of a curtain that hides the horrors of the wine-press from the powerful who are feasting on the wine. Those who recognise and call out their suffering are also destroyed; others learn to remain silent. Even those oppressed join in the struggle for survival by crushing those who have sunk below them in the wine-press. Merlin Sheldrake makes the point that 'modern capitalist thought is founded on the idea of rational individuals acting in their own interest', and that 'without individuals, everything comes crashing down'.¹⁸⁸ Although Schreiner's stance in *African Farm* and *From Man to Man* is one that is critical of individuality and in *From Man to Man* she presents an ethics based on a understanding of connectivity, I read this allegory as her most direct analysis of the reasons for and consequences of individualism. Her critique of capitalism in 'Sunlight Lay' is rooted within the value placed upon individual self, which facilitates the development of hierarchical systems.

In Hell, the instrument used to oppress those without power is the body. It is through their blood, produced through crushing them in the wine-presses, that those without power are used and destroyed. Schreiner potentially alludes here to the wine-press of Revelation and

¹⁸⁸ Sheldrake, p.237.

its resultant blood which represents the wrath of God.¹⁸⁹ But my reading of Schreiner's winepress and blood is more corporeal and, as such, I see it as gesturing towards the Eucharist. Carly Nations, also reading it as alluding to the Eucharist, suggests that the blood/wine in 'Sunlight Lay' is 'not simply an embodiment of sacrifice, but [...] the body itself, sacrificed for the enjoyment of others'.¹⁹⁰ I extend this to recognise that it is through the body that Schreiner contrasts Heaven and Hell. In Heaven, the body unifies all beings; in Hell, the body is used to oppress and destroy the other: the narrator is horrified to realise that the wine drunk by those feasting is created from the bodies of others: '*they* drink it – *their own!*' (D 107, emphasis in original). But, of course, they who drink it, see it as the blood of the other, who are not '*their own*'.

Schreiner also suggests that unlike the society in Heaven in which resources are shared, the decadent society of Hell treats the environment as other. This can be read through Marder's contention that humanity's interiority 'emasculates its integral connection to the environment' (MM 168). Where the feasting houses are now in ruins, the landscape of Hell is barren and arid, the earth laid to waste and 'sodden' with the blood of those destroyed (D 110). Such environmental degradation is indicative of a capitalist, perhaps even colonialist, society that through the exploitation of resources, including people, eventually destroys itself. Looking upwards to access the holy, they do not recognise that God is in the world of materiality, as Schreiner reinforces through stating that 'out in the sunshine, God lay' (D 106). Moreover, responses to the environmental other in Hell and Heaven can be traced in the uses to which fruits are put. In Hell, people use it to destroy one another. Women bite into fruit to poison it, so that 'another may not eat', with the result that 'in Hell all men fear' (D 103-4). In Heaven, the people 'shone long' (D 114) to ripen the fruit which is then shared amongst them.

¹⁸⁹ 'And the angel thrust in his sickle into the earth, and gathered the vine of the earth, and cast *it* into the great winepress of the wrath of God. And the winepress was trodden without the city, and blood came out of the winepress ...' (Revelation 14.19-20).

¹⁹⁰ Carly Nations, "'Made Alive": Olive Schreiner's *Dreams* and the Embodied Vision of Equality', *Nineteenth Century Gender Studies*, 17(2) (2021), p.14-15.

Schreiner recognises the importance of alterity to growth and articulates the importance of the struggle from material darkness into a more spiritual light. The figure in the highest heaven, has had to climb from the 'lowest Hell', and it is through this that 'its limbs grew larger' and 'drops fell from its eyes'. Schreiner represents such striving through a vegetal analogy: the figure realises that 'Hell is the seed ground from which Heaven springs. He sees the sap ascending' (*D* 118). I read this through Marder's notion that both spiritual and intellectual enlightenment in Western thought puts into analogic service vegetal movement from the darkness of the earth towards the light of the sun. Schreiner's vegetal image suggests that enlightenment not only connects the realms of darkness and light, and material and transcendence, but also recognises the necessity of darkness to seed light. But Marder also suggests that such analogies serve to undermine the importance of beginning in darkness and striving towards the light. For Marder the enlightenment analogy 'represses the unconscious remainder it cannot do away with [...] leaving the darkness of mere life behind' and therefore 'undercuts the conditions of its own existence' (MM 177). I assert that Schreiner's image reaffirms the necessity for the originating darkness and that true enlightenment requires the opposing darkness from which to grow. This manifests in the allegory with the necessity for the narrator to return to the real world to make his own journey from his material roots. This is the reason why God refuses each of his pleas to remain in Heaven, telling him that he must 'go back to earth: *that which you seek is there*' (*D* 119, emphasis in original). As the allegory ends with the narrator firstly perceiving the morning light as a 'dull grey', but then becoming cognisant that 'across my bed a long yellow streak of pale London sunlight was lying' (*D* 120), he begins his own enlightenment journey back in the world of the material; the point to which the title alludes.

III. Trooper Peter Halket of Mashonaland: from ideals to action

Trooper Peter was written during 1896/7, contemporaneous with the events it depicts. It concerns Cecil Rhodes' Chartered Company's attempted invasion of what became Rhodesia, the Jameson Raid, and the wider speculative colonialism of Rhodes and his ilk in South Africa. It was published as a stand-alone novella and was an overt attempt to intervene into contemporary politics. As Schreiner states in a letter to her brother: 'it is to [...] the great British public [...] that my little book is addressed [...] They must know where the injustice and oppression really lies'.¹⁹¹

We might question to what extent *Trooper Peter* is an allegory or a novella. Schreiner herself, in explaining its dreamed inception, refers to it as an allegory: 'as I opened my eyes there was an allegory full fledged in my mind! A sort of allegory story about Matabele land'.¹⁹² Matthew Blackman, in considering its formal strategies, assesses whether it is a realist novel or an allegory, recognising Schreiner's use of elements from both forms. He views her use of character, plot, and a plurality of voices as realist, but sees its 'powerful proclamatory voice' as reminiscent of allegory.¹⁹³ Although I am not convinced that the weighing up of the relative importance of these two forms in relation to *Trooper Peter* is helpful, it does draw attention to how Schreiner blurs the boundaries between these forms. In *Trooper Peter*, elements of the realist setting are also symbolic, and this includes the tree that I discuss in detail. Schreiner uses a novelistic plurality of voices and yet Christ's allegorical voice and his ethical position remain paramount. As Blackman recognises, in *Trooper Peter*, the figure of Christ is both 'word of God' but also incarnate.¹⁹⁴ I argue that the crossovers between realist novella and allegory that Blackman observes, rather than being

¹⁹¹ Olive Schreiner, letter to William Philip Schreiner, December 1896, <https://oliveschreiner.org> [accessed 6th April 2023].

¹⁹² Olive Schreiner, letter to Betty Molteno, 20th August 1896, <https://oliveschreiner.org> [accessed 28th March 2023].

¹⁹³ Matthew Blackman, 'Bakhtin and *Trooper Peter Halket of Mashonaland*: Beyond Allegory and Realism', *English in Africa*, 48(1) (2021), 33-52 (p.34).

¹⁹⁴ Blackman, p.45.

problematic are part of Schreiner's very project. In her allegories, Schreiner combines concrete reality and noumenal to emphasise the interconnections between these spheres, reminding her readers that abstract values and beliefs must influence concrete action.

Blackman further argues that in *Trooper Peter* 'it is difficult to discern a singular allegorical and ethical message'.¹⁹⁵ On the contrary, I assert that Schreiner's ethical stance is clear and that it is that of the gospels. However, through my analysis of the ethical framework of this allegory, I recognise how it bears a similarity to that which extends from Marder's vegetal and Barad's agential realism. It is also that embedded in Schopenhauer's hidden connectivity.

In the first chapter of this allegory, Peter Halket, a guileless young trooper employed in Rhodes' Chartered Company, having become separated from the rest of his company, spends a fearful night alone on a kopje.¹⁹⁶ During the night Christ appears to him in the guise of a stranger. Halket proudly reveals to Christ the brutal destruction that he and his fellow colonialists mete out to the natives, their homes, and their land. Christ tells Halket about his own 'company' (his kingdom) and its ethical principles. Halket becomes converted and Christ instructs him to carry out tasks that would contribute to the establishment of the kingdom. Halket feels unable to complete any of these tasks except for Christ's final instruction: 'in that small spot where alone on earth your will rules, bring there into being the kingdom today' (*TPR*, 187).¹⁹⁷ The second and final chapter articulates Trooper Peter's completion of this task. After failing to persuade the Captain to offer mercy to a captured native who has been condemned to death, under the cover of darkness, Halket releases the native, saving his life. Halket himself, caught in the act, is shot dead.

¹⁹⁵ Blackman, p.49.

¹⁹⁶ A 'kopje' is a small hillock.

¹⁹⁷ Schreiner explains in a letter that in the dream in which this allegory comes to her, 'I just as I opened my eyes saw Peter Halket on the kopje and heard the voices talking' (Olive Schreiner, letter to Henrietta Schreiner, 25th December 1901, <https://oliveschreiner.org> [accessed 28th March 2023]).

As in 'Sunlight Lay', in *Trooper Peter Schreiner* contrasts two ethical positions: this time they are those of speculative colonialism and the ethics of the gospel. Schreiner's explanation of gospel ethics bears similarity to a Schopenhaurian compassionate ethics and a Marderesque ethics rooted in 'vegetal democracy' (MM 52). Peter Halket explains to Christ his colonialist ethics: that 'we don't come out here to work [...] we've come here to make money' (*TPR*, 83). Individual gain is the aim - entirely rational when viewed from a point of view centred on self. In a Schopenhauerian sense, he is acting for the benefit of his individual will. However, Schopenhauer maintains that this is a misunderstanding of our underlying connectedness, and reading from the perspective of Helen Zimmern's recognition that Schopenhauerian ethics are 'in unison with those of the New Testament, and might be defined as its scientific expression', indicates that such Schopenhauerian ethics are also reflected in this allegory.¹⁹⁸ Christ's explanation to Halket of the 'unknown that lies beyond us we know of no otherwise than through its manifestation in our own hearts' (*TPR*, 132), is suggestive of such hidden connectedness. It is through such teachings that Halket's ethical stance eventually becomes converted to one that incorporates a recognition of similarity and therefore compassion for his fellow beings.

As Christ puts modular vegetal growth into service in arguing for the acceptance of difference, the similarity of a vegetal ethics to that of the gospel can be recognised more overtly than that of Schopenhauerian ethics. Christ asserts his kingdom's acceptance of difference when he states that it encompasses 'men of every race and from every land', including those of 'every religion, Buddhists, Mahomedans, Confucians, Freethinkers, Atheists, Christians, Jews' (*TPR* 103). He goes on to symbolise unity in difference through tree growth, instructing Halket to tell the English and the Boers, that 'you should stretch out your arms to welcome each stranger who comes to live and labour with you. You are the

¹⁹⁸ Zimmern, p.154.

twin branches of one tree; you are the sons of one mother' (*TPR* 168). The branches symbolise the unity between the offspring of one being. But for Marder, vegetal being is not merely multiple, it problematises and makes meaningless the entire multiple/whole binary. Its modules are neither fully separate nor fully unified. Reading Christ's image of the tree through this image implies that his kingdom likewise negates the entire concept of individuality. He suggests that the two white races are not separate and, in recognition of their combined interests, should share the land and its resources.

Barad's dismissal of the separate nature of the individual might be useful in this context, particularly as she extends her conceptualisation of matter as secondary to relationships or intra-actions, to an ethical position. She suggests that rather than individuals possessing ethical responsibilities towards one another, the ethical obligation exists prior to this. For Barad it is 'not a commitment that a subject chooses but rather an incarnate relation that precedes the intentionality of consciousness' (KB 392). Reading Schreiner's gesture towards the lack of separate individuals in her use of the tree through Barad, the ethical perspective becomes primary, requiring no conscious decision-making. Ethical responsibility is an obligation that operates from a position of there already being an underlying 'relation of responsibility to the other' (KB 391) that is not even really the other but already inter-related. This seems closely related to the point that Christ is teaching Halket: that he has an a priori responsibility towards everyone. There is no other.

But Christ's message that the two white races should share the land is not without problematic racist overtones as it rather bypasses colonisation's fundamental injustice to the native black people of South Africa. However, Schreiner goes on to use another tree as symbol of the integration of black and white races; an appropriate image in the light of the fact that as vegetal being, the tree, is itself symbolic of an integrated mode of being with a heteronomous relation to alterity that neither denies otherness nor appropriates it. In the camp, the condemned black captive is tied to a white tree. Schreiner describes the tree and

the black captive as integrated as 'the black man hung against the white stem, so closely bound to it that they seemed one' (*TPR* 249). Black and white, human and tree, merge. Schreiner extends such an image of integration further. When Halket is shot while releasing the native from the tree, it becomes the place where 'a black man and a white man's blood were mingled' (*TPR* 259).

Schreiner goes on to articulate a further affinity between the captive's body and the tree. He is wasted with limbs that 'had fallen away, making the joints stand out', hair that is 'wild and thick with neglect' and skin that 'was rough with want and exposure' (*TPR* 249-50). The tree is 'stunted', 'gnarled and knotted', with 'misshapen branches' (*TPR* 195). Both have suffered through the other of a tough environment. However, the heteronomous tree has managed to adapt and survive; the black man has not. Alterity for him is a colonial society, diametrically opposed to him as other.

Schreiner uses a long-term temporal framework in which to examine Halket's ethics and suggest the longevity of the kingdom. As such, I read this tree as a visual representation of Christ's kingdom that stretches into the past. Reading it through Marder's notion of vegetal spatiality as the embodiment of time, it serves as a symbol of continuity, growth, and survival. Its contorted and stunted nature inscribes its growth and survival within a harsh environment, as has Christ's kingdom. But Schreiner's Christ lengthens the temporality of his kingdom further back into deep time. He purports the existence of the kingdom before any notion of 'Christianity', even before the development of humanity itself, dating from 'when these hills were young, and these lichens had hardly shown their stains upon the rocks', its 'fore-dawn' recognised within the care and love of animals for their young and their mates that are now extinct (*TPR* 145; 148). Mike Kissack and Michael Titlestad recognise how Schreiner endows Christ with an 'extensive historical panorama' and an 'evolutionary

perspective' which contrasts to the 'limited historical perspective' of Halket's.¹⁹⁹ Such a perspective is, of course, consistent with Schreiner's other writings. But in relation to this allegory, this means that the ethics associated with the kingdom are shown as eternal and fundamental, and in contrast, Halket's appear short-term and opportunistic. Through her use of the long-established allegory form, Schreiner reinforces this perspective, formally situating Christ's ethics within a long-term moral framework.

The tree's spatiality is also suggestive of the survival of Christ's kingdom into the future. Its 'white stem and outstretched arms', along with the stones beneath it that mark Halket's grave, is the final image of the abandoned camp that the men see as they leave at the end of the allegory (*TPR* 264). It therefore becomes an image of endurance and survival into the future. As a symbol of the integration of black and white, it also embodies a future post-colonial unified society. The combined bloods of black and white man under the tree will be utilised by the roots in a future 'material "resurrection"' (*MM* 67). Kissack and Titlestad problematise Halket's sacrifice, asking if it is 'a recapitulation of the impasse and futility of such an unrealistic gesture in the world of political conflict'. As another trooper states, 'There is no God in Mashonaland' (*TPR* 261). Their solution is to read it through what they term Schreiner's "'Mystical Christianity'" which focuses upon 'the merits of considering oneself a conduit through which the divine nature can express itself', as opposed to a "'Church and Biblical" Christianity' which focuses upon authority and obedience.²⁰⁰ The first of these is more representative of Schreiner's interpretation of Christ, but my response to the potential futility of Halket's sacrifice is inscribed in the image of the surviving tree that symbolises the continuance of the kingdom through its embodiment of time.

¹⁹⁹ Mike Kissack & Michael Titlestad, 'Olive Schreiner and the Secularisation of the Moral Imagination', *English in Africa*, 33(1) (2006), 23-46 (p.38).

²⁰⁰ Kissack & Titlestad, p.41-2. They state that their use of the terms and ideas of 'Mystical Christianity' and 'Church and Biblical Christianity' are taken from Linda Woodhead, *Christianity: A Very Short Introduction* (Oxford, Oxford University Press, 2004), p.46; p.71.

I read this tree as symbolic of the message of the crucifixion. With its 'white stem and outstretched arms' (*TPR*, 264), this observation pointedly made after Halket's Christ-like sacrifice, it is similar to a print that Halket remembers from his old school-house of Christ 'hung with his arms stretched out and the blood dropping from his feet' (*TPR* 25). It therefore not only embodies the divine kingdom but is also a reminder of the necessity for sacrifice in aid of the creation of a better future. Christ explicitly articulates this message to Halket. In contrast to Halket's assertions that a Christian is one who believes in Heaven, Hell, God, Christ, and the Bible (*TPR* 99-100), through the voice of the preacher whose story he tells Halket, Christ instructs that 'the past is dead, it lives only for us to learn. The present, the present only, is ours to work in, and the future ours to create' (*TPR* 121). Our only efficacy is through action in the present in support of the future. This is a similar message to that of 'Three Dreams', both reinforcing the Baradian notion that the material future is ours to create. Christ makes his message more pertinent to Halket when he instructs him to act so that 'the day shall come, when the stars, looking down on this little world, shall see no spot where the soil is moist and dark with the blood of man shed by his fellow man' (*TPR* 149). He foreshadows Halket's sacrificial death under the tree and the mingling of his blood with that of the black captive. Furthermore, the tree is not only an image of sacrifice, but a spatial representation of how the past (through growth) impacts upon the future; a lesson perhaps that it offers humanity.

Schreiner stresses the importance to humanity of belonging or rootedness and implies that the lack of belonging on the part of the colonialists emboldens their destructive impulses. Halket acts towards the land of South Africa and its people as if he belongs. Saying he will teach the 'bloody niggers' a lesson, the narrative voice comments that this is his:

pugilistic spirit rising, firmly reseating himself on the South African earth, which two years before he had never heard of, and eighteen months before he had never seen, as if it had been his mother earth (*TPR* 92-3).

Although he asserts himself on 'earth' that is not *his* 'mother earth', Schreiner suggests that a 'mother earth' sense of rootedness is of importance to humanity, perhaps as much as it is for the vegetal. But the colonialist's method of creating rootedness in South Africa is destructive and exploitative, whereas the vegetal's heteronomous mode of being means that it does not assert itself over its environment but is an integral part of it (MM 168). The vegetal can even create place and although Halket might try to do so through the use of force, he cannot 'reseat' himself on South African earth. This is a far more developed understanding of the effects of colonialisation than Schreiner presents in *African Farm*. Whereas in *African Farm* Schreiner presents characters who suffer from a rootlessness which I read partially caused by colonialisation, in *Trooper Peter*, published fourteen years later, she directly addresses this issue as a consequence of colonialism.

But Halket does eventually find belonging and meaning in relational ethics rather than in a fraudulent and untenable relationship to the South African land. His need for a 'mother earth' is also expressed through his frequent thoughts of his mother. While alone on the kopje his thoughts turn to her and although he often brushes it off, he is aware that in South Africa he does not live up to her moral standards. But he recognises his mother in Christ, telling him that 'when your eyes look at me it seems to me as if she was looking at me' (TPR 72). It seems that in Christ he regains the sense of belonging that he cannot find in the land. His relationship with Christ becomes his 'mother earth', symbolised by the tree that is representative of Christ, also symbolising a protective mother with her 'branches, like arms, stretched out on either side' (TPR 195).

Schreiner's use of the allegorical form enables her to create a wider vision in which to express a moral responsibility towards others and the future. This is well illustrated in *Trooper Peter*. Halket's meeting with Christ on the kopje converts his mode of thinking. In calling into question Halket's colonialist beliefs and the odious actions to which they have led, Christ asks Halket 'which of those souls you have seen on earth is to you greatest?', to

which the confused Halket replies, 'we weren't talking of souls at all' (*TPR* 87). Christ deepens his thinking into the realm of the ideal and broader ethical responsibilities in the world of the material. This causes Halket to deepen and widen his perspective, moving away from the small, personal, and individual, towards a longer-term and wider collective moral responsibility towards others and towards the future. I contend that as readers of these allegories, she also leads us towards this wider perspective as a locus for our actions.

In deciding whether to publish this allegorical attack on Rhodes and his values, Schreiner explains her decision-making in a letter to her brother. She writes that:

at last the matter decided itself within me. Don't think I mean anything supernatural takes place; though that decision which one's nature gives when one tries to silence the lower and purely personal interest and to allow the higher elements in it to adjudicate among themselves is what the ancients called the 'voice of God'; and is so to a certain extent; because it the highest and for each soul within itself, the most ultimate injunction it can ever receive.²⁰¹

This seems to me to sum up something of the message of her allegories: that one should follow the moral injunction that asks one to act through a sense of responsibility towards others. Once again, Schreiner hedges her bets about the noumenal. She suggests that the decision is not 'supernatural' but allies the influence to the 'voice of God', again taking up a position that neither fully embraces a religious faith nor fully denies it in favour of materiality.

²⁰¹ Olive Schreiner, letter to William Philip Schreiner, 29th June 1898, <https://oliveschreiner.org> [accessed 24th March 2023], emphasis in original.

Conclusion

Human thinking is, to some extent, de-humanised and rendered plant-like, altered by its encounter with the vegetal world.

(Michael Marder, *Plant-Thinking*, p.10)

In his recent book, *The Nation of Plants* (2021), the botanist Stefano Mancuso, in a 'playful exercise', imagines plants writing a 'Constitution' for their own nation which they present to the 'United Nations General Assembly'. Mancuso writes that the 'articles' that make up this constitution 'were suggested to me by plants themselves'. They are based on a plant mode of being: life as a continuous whole, a non-hierarchical and collective organisation, a heteronomous relationship with alterity, and protecting the environment for future generations.²⁰² In *Plant-Thinking*, Marder treads a somewhat similar path. He uses a 'method drawn from the plants themselves' (MM 7), attempting to 'abandon the familiar terrain of human and humanist thought and to meet vegetal life [...] at least halfway' (MM 10). Although my own interdisciplinary approach incorporates philosophical botany, New Materialism, post-humanist, evolutionary, and econarratological perspectives, I have tried to keep at the centre, the mode of life of plants.

Relationships are key to the work of Hardy and Schreiner. Using the relationship-centred philosophical botany of Michael Marder, the continuous will of Schopenhauer, and the connectivity across matter embraced by the New Materialism of Jane Bennett and Karen Barad, this thesis has shed light on this aspect of Hardy and Schreiner's work. Relationships are evident in their representation of the individual plant, communities of vegetation, and the entanglements and connections between the vegetal and other lifeforms. My approach identifies how Hardy and Schreiner explicitly and implicitly use the vegetal as a model of a relational mode of being. For Mancuso, relationships dominate his 'nation of plants'. He recognises the importance for the sessile plant of 'building stable and cooperative

²⁰² Stefano Mancuso, *The Nation of Plants*, trans. by Gregory Conti (London, Profile Books, 2021), pp.10-12.

communities with other individuals with whom you have to share your living space' and reminds us that ecology is about relationships.²⁰³ Hardy and Schreiner's texts abound with the language of webs, networks, and connections, across which 'internetted lines of interaction stretch' (*FM* 180), and the values they embed are based upon responsibility towards others and denounce human solipsism.

I have demonstrated how Hardy and Schreiner use evolutionary perspectives to create long-term frameworks in which life is portrayed as a continuum. In his novels, Hardy shows the uninterrupted growth of the vegetal creating and re-creating place, embedding vitality, adaptation, and change within a framework of immutability. In his poetry, he highlights how for the vegetal, transience becomes part of the continuing life of the plant. Schreiner, in her novels, uses vegetal analogies to contribute to her evolutionary framework, using plants as symbols of long-term uninterrupted development and models of the relationship of the individual to long-term progress. I read the long-term body of humanity in her allegories as similarly vegetal-like. For Schreiner, this human body participates in progressive evolutionary development, however, Hardy presents humanity as problematically over-developed. The approach I have developed in this thesis responds to these aspects of their work, cognisant of how their incorporation of evolutionary temporalities into the novel expands its form.

Merlin Sheldrake asserts that 'all life forms are in fact *processes*, not *things*'.²⁰⁴ I have argued that in Hardy and Schreiner's work the vegetal is represented as in a state of constant change rather than stasis. Hardy characterises its energy or life force as an inherent element of the materiality, whereas Schreiner envisages it as a metaphysical force supplementary to the material. I situate their divergent views in the late nineteenth-century era of debates over

²⁰³ Mancuso, p.138.

²⁰⁴ Sheldrake, p.60, emphasis in original.

material and metaphysical epistemologies. Yet even for Schreiner, materiality is the location of vitality and agency, and so for both of them, matter matters.

In representing life as a material continuum, Hardy and Schreiner dismantle notions of a hierarchical Great Chain of Being and present all lifeforms, including the vegetal, as of value. But while identifying these connections, they also conceptualise the vegetal as other. Like Mancuso in *The Nation of Plants* and Marder in *Plant-Thinking*, their use of the vegetal reminds us that there is an alternative ontology and that ours is not the only way to live. Schreiner overtly reflects this in her plant analogies, and Hardy does so in his poetry in which he suggests that the vegetal might, in fact, be better adapted to the conditions of life on Earth than is humanity with its burdensome consciousness and focus on self.

Hardy and Schreiner conceptualise humankind as non-dualist beings, mind and body being inseparable. Across Hardy's work, it is when reason and consciousness dominate that humanity misunderstands its true nature and suffers from the ensuing existential concerns. In *African Farm* Schreiner makes a similar point and across her work she validates other modes of perception that embrace feeling and the body. For both writers, human agency, motivation, and meaning are corporeal, and it is through a recognition of such embodiment that our kinship with other lifeforms is evident. Matter matters for us too.

Although this is not intended as a comparative thesis, examining these two authors through a similar lens has been insightful, particularly with respect to where they differ, helping to create new understandings of the position of materiality in the late-nineteenth and early-twentieth-centuries. The editors of *Anticipatory Materialisms in Literature and Philosophy* articulate their intention to read forwards rather than backwards, cognisant of how the literature of the nineteenth-century was deeply invested in notions of material agency and

autonomy that anticipate twenty-first century New Materialism.²⁰⁵ My readings of Hardy and Schreiner centre them in their own era, in which material and metaphysical epistemologies were in debate, while arguing for their relevance to the environmental sensibilities of the twenty-first century.

My study contributes to the current 'plant-turn' in the humanities, which continues to expand across academia, and in non-fiction and literary texts, suggesting that we are starting to recognise something important about the vegetal mode of being. It also further extends post-human discourse in that it decentres the human and questions our exceptionalism. The lens I have developed could effectively be applied to other work by Hardy and Schreiner. Hardy's *Under the Greenwood Tree* with its arboreal setting would be interesting to compare with *The Woodlanders*. There are many Hardy poems which address the vegetal to which I could not do justice in one chapter of this thesis, but which would benefit from further study, perhaps alongside the vegetal poetry of his friend and mentor, William Barnes. This approach could usefully be employed to examine other allegories by Schreiner that embrace the vegetal, as well as her early novel, *Undine*.

Although my current work focuses on the work of Hardy and Schreiner, it would be a useful approach to consider the representation of the vegetal across a wider range of texts and authors. It could be used to examine the environmental and ecological values embedded within texts, to analyse the representation of entanglements across human and other lifeforms, and to assess how meaning, agency, and knowing is widened out to other lifeforms including the vegetal. As my lens extends to the representation of humanity in relation to the role of the individual, ethical responsibility, and the role of the human mind and human corporeality, it offers further potential for exploring how other writers address these features.

²⁰⁵ *Anticipatory Materialisms in Literature and Philosophy: 1790-1930*, ed. by Jo Carruthers, Nour Dakkak, and Rebecca Spence (Cham, Palgrave MacMillan, 2019), pp.1-7.

In terms of the nineteenth-century, my approach offers a useful lens to consider how Emily Brontë uses the moorland setting and how she locates agency and vitality in *Wuthering Heights*, as well as to examine how in *Shirley*, Charlotte Brontë centres botanical knowledge within many of the minor female characters. Reading Elizabeth Barrett Browning's *Aurora Leigh* from this perspective might suggest new ways to understand her representation of the natural world and how it influences the character of Aurora. Turning to the twentieth century, my methodology would provide a valuable perspective for analysing the representation of the vegetation of the North American plains in the work of Willa Cather, as well as for exploring how Sylvia Townsend Warner applies her plant knowledge across her novels, short stories, and poetry, particularly in her extended poem, *Opus 7* in which the nurturing of plants becomes subversive. In more recent work, analysing how writers such as Annie Proulx and Richard Powers represent the role of the arboreal in North America would gain from my approach. I also offer a useful lens for considering some of Ursula Le Guin's science fiction, in which she uses the vegetal to suggest better ways of living in the world, particularly in her novel *The Word for World is Forest*, and her short story, 'Direction of the Road', written from the perspective of a tree.

The editors of the 2020 edition of Schreiner's *Dreams* comment that 'avowed millennials, we felt an immediate bond with Olive Schreiner, as she confronted so many of the issues that resonate in our lives today' (D 7). Although they do not indicate so, I would include in this her representation and use of the vegetal and recognition of the value of all lifeforms. I contend that Hardy's work, particularly his knowledge, description, and use of the vegetal, as well as his understanding of the importance of relationships and entanglements across all beings, also speaks to us today.

I suggest that Hardy and Schreiner's awareness of the importance of the vegetal is a salutary lesson for our times. It is perhaps an irony that while there is a 'plant-turn' in discourse, we have become a species of urban environments, divorced from the everyday

experience of the green world. Hardy and Schreiner were aware and knowledgeable about the plant world, having experienced rural childhoods, and our vegetal-inflected language – ‘roots’, ‘branching’, ‘offshoots’, ‘hedged’, ‘stems from’, ‘field of’, ‘grounded in’ – demonstrates the intimate entanglement of our culture with the vegetal.

Our attitude to plants perhaps reveals us as zoocentric, not merely anthropocentric. We continue to conceptualise the world in terms of individual beings and things, rather than through relationships. Francis Hallé suggests that our language fails to acknowledge the different ontology of plant-life: ‘our language is not appropriate for plants. They do not *know*. They *use* nothing. They have no *needs*, *projects*, or *goals*. We speak an animal language that adapts poorly to the truth about plants’.²⁰⁶ The assertion by others that Hardy’s Egdon Heath is a character because Hardy endows it with a face, a voice, and agency is indicative of this. Marder suggests that ‘human thinking is, to some extent, de-humanised and rendered plant-like, altered by its encounter with the vegetal world’ (MM 10). My hope is that my work contributes to changing the reader’s thinking in this respect.

²⁰⁶ Hallé, p.301 (emphasis in original).

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